
SATIPANYA BUDDHIST RETREAT

DhammaBytes

Short teachings on key Buddhist concepts and doctrines

Bhante Bodhidhamma

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Views about Spiritual Paths

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 13 min

In this opening talk of the 'Approaching the Dhamma' series, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines various attitudes toward spiritual paths and teachers. Drawing from Bhikkhu Bodhi's 'In the Buddha's Words,' he explores how the Buddha's teaching differs from secret doctrines or dogmatic belief systems, emphasizing instead the direct investigation of the visible arising and passing away of dukkha (suffering/unsatisfactoriness).

Using the metaphor of mountain climbing, Bhante categorizes five types of religious ideologies: fundamentalist, relative fundamentalist, relativist, relative universalist, and universalist. He contextualizes the Buddha's teaching within the religious landscape of ancient India, where various spiritual teachers competed alongside Brahminical traditions, Jainism, and emerging Upanishadic thought.

The talk emphasizes the Buddha's unique approach of encouraging direct investigation rather than belief, warning how preconceived notions can distort our understanding of liberation. Bhante illustrates this with examples of how mistaking temporary blissful states for nibbāna can mislead practitioners, stressing that true awakening must come through personal experience and discriminative wisdom rather than blind faith.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So I'm going to carry on with Bhikkhu Bodhi's book, *In the Buddha's Words*. This chapter is devoted to what he calls approaching the Dharma. It's basically our attitude to spiritual teachings, to those who teach spiritual teachings, the teachers, and so on. And how to be discriminative about spiritual practice and stuff.

He's got certain headings, and so we'll go through them. So it's not a secret doctrine. So what he's teaching is not a secret doctrine. It's not a dogma. You don't need blind belief. It's the visible origin and passing away of suffering. It's something that you can actually perceive yourself. Investigate the teacher himself. Heaven forbid. Don't look at me like that. And steps towards realization of the path. I think that's his fullness of it.

So this evening, really, is just an introduction to this. And in his day, there were a choice of teachers. It was a time when the old Brahminical religion of the Rig Veda, which was based on control of the gods through various sacrifices. And there was, of

course, the understanding of rebirth. But that, as I understand it, that was mainly about power rather than whether one was good or not, depending on how you were born. So Brahmin was born from the head of Brahma and therefore was destined to join Brahma somewhere up there.

But by the time of the Buddha, for some time, there'd been people who had really investigated the truth of all that. And that's the beginning of, in the Hindu tradition, of the Upanishads, which are really saying a lot of the things that the Buddha said. And there was... The Jains began there. The Jain leader, the Nigantha, was an elder, contemporary of the Buddha. And it's thought that the ascetic practice that the Buddha did was either connected to him or under some of his disciples. That very fierce sort of ascetic practice. And of course there was the Buddha himself.

And most of the teachers would have been within the tradition of the Brahmins, the Brahminical tradition. The interesting thing about Jainism and Buddhism is that they left that particular tradition entirely and formed their own scriptures from the words of the teacher. So it's a completely different line, you see.

I wrote an essay around the Eightfold Path, and I started off by trying to distinguish five types of ideologues. So I thought I'd read it to you and then see what you think. So there seem to be five types of ideologues in the religious arena. So these are the five, you see. They are the fundamentalist, the relative fundamentalist, the relativist, the relativist universalist, and the universalist. I will now explain in great detail.

The mountain is a good metaphor to illustrate these five different positions. Mountains come up in most spiritual literature. The interesting thing about mountain climbing is that when you're making the effort, when you're moving, all you can see is the ground ahead of you. And then finally when you get tired or you need a rest, you turn around and there's a view. You suddenly realize you're in a different place. And you never see the full 360 degrees until you get to the top. The Buddha talks about the Arhant who really doesn't see, it's only until we become fully liberated that we can really see things as in the noonday sun. So there's something about that end point which is quite awakening or enlightening.

So the fundamentalist says that his is the only true mountain. You think you're climbing a mountain but actually you're descending into a pit. Whereas my mountain will take me to ultimate happiness, yours will take you to utter perdition. I'm right and everybody else is wrong. Utterly wrong. I mean, that's your fundamentalist, isn't it? Just basically, what can you say?

The relative fundamentalist has respect for the traditions. Yes, indeed, they're all mountains. But my mountain is bigger. See? Whereas mine will reach the ultimate goal, yours will stop short, and at some time you'll have to cross over. Everyone is right, but I'm more right than everybody else. So it's compassion for other people's parts, but ultimately, you know, this is the right one.

It's funny because when I was in India once, I went to this Tibetan doctor, as I've been coals or something. He actually said to me in so many words, look, you're a Theravāda. They've got it all wrong. What you want to join is the Mahāyāna. I was taken aback by it actually. Just the Hīnayāna, the lower path. These days they tend to refer to the two types of Buddhist traditions as the northern and the southern path. Northern and the southern Buddhisms.

The relativist, acknowledging his ignorance of other religions, declares all mountains to be equal but different. They lead to their own idea of what is the ultimate good is, and there's no way of telling which is more true. Everyone is right but different. You take your pick and you guess what you choose. There's a postmodernist view that, you know, you live in your own reality, and if you think you've achieved great happiness, then that's it, you know.

The relative universalist argues that once we look below the surface of culture and words, we find that all religions are actually on the same, the very same mountain, all going up the same place. But that each path is distinct and separate. And we're all going in our own religious and cultural way to the same place. Everyone is different but right, and we all end up in the same place. I think probably a lot of people kowtow to that one, I think.

And then finally there's the universalist who takes this position a step further. So espying that indeed beneath the paraphernalia of rites, rituals, customs and culture there are three paths. The way of knowledge, the way of love and the way of action. And that is why many of the actual spiritual practices such as compassionate service, repetitive prayer, mantra, yoga and indeed *vipassanā* can be practiced by people of different religious persuasions. These three paths are intertwined within the individual according to their temperament, all leading to the same place. The outer form is simply a metaphor for this deeper truth. And indeed, a Buddhist universalist may go so far as to say that even those who disavow all spirituality are also on the spiritual path. Eventually they will bump into the truth, everyone is actually on the same path and heading for the same destination. The ultimate universalist.

I don't think you'll find Bhikkhu Bodhi particularly attracted to that one.

It's interesting because Hinduism knows these three paths quite clearly as Jñāna Yoga, Bhakti Yoga and Karma Yoga. The path of understanding somebody like Ramana Maharshi. You've heard of him? Nisargadatta Maharaj, one of my favourites. Do you know him? Yeah, do you know him? Yeah. Yeah. Bhakti. Who was the great Bhakti Guru? Mother. He was into the Great Mother. Was that, was it? Yeah. There are a few like that. Just through love, really. Through the heart, you see. The connection to the ultimate through the heart, rather than through understanding. That's right. Hare Krishna. Yeah, that's right. And then there's the path of action, which is compassionate engagement in the world.

It's interesting because, I don't know, it's just my own take on things, but of the three world, the ones that you can call really world religions, the ones that have transcended national boundaries in a real way, like are Christianity, Buddhism and Islam. And each have a particular bent, don't they? Buddhism is definitely the path of discrimination leading to the path of compassion. Christianity turns that around, doesn't it? The path of compassion leading to understanding. And Islam is the will, you see, the will of the Dharma, the will of surrendering to the truth. You've got these three. So the will, I mean, that's action, giving oneself.

So it's a case really of being aware of our position and not taking it too seriously. And when we approach the Buddha's teachings, his is always one of investigating it. And we'll go into that more deeply later. How he doesn't want us to believe anything. That would be, in a sense it would make, it would distort the investigation of the truth if you come from a position of belief. The liberation in Buddhist terms has to be through something that we have explored and experienced directly for ourselves. And the problem is that if you approach something with a particular view or prejudice, belief, then that's what you'll experience. And that's where the mistakes can be made.

So if you have an idea that *Nibbāna* is some sort of blissed out state, an emotional blissed out state, something like that, a mental state of being blissed out, then in your meditation if you get a blissful moment you'll think, oh that's *Nibbāna*. But it ain't.

So there's a, I always forget her name, but there's a woman who had this terrible stroke. She's fairly famous and she's written a book on it and how she overcame it completely it seems. And the right brain shut down and because the left brain was the only part working it... She was just in this total euphoria all the time. And she expresses this as *Nibbāna*. See, this is the point. So that's one way to get *Nibbāna* is to have a stroke so you can get rid of your right brain. It's a strange thing, you know. Left brain. Left brain, excuse me, left brain. I'm getting confused. It just shows you what I am.

So there's a little, just an introduction into something that we can look more closely at. The way the Buddha asks us to approach the spiritual life, really.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be fully liberated from all suffering. Sooner rather than later.

Discourse to the Kālāmas

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min

In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the renowned Kālāma Sutta (AN 3.65), often cited as exemplifying the Buddha's non-dogmatic approach to teaching. The discourse addresses the timeless question: how do we know what is true? The Kālāmas faced competing religious teachers, each claiming their doctrine was correct while disparaging others—a situation remarkably similar to our modern spiritual marketplace.

The Buddha's response was revolutionary: don't accept teachings based solely on tradition, scriptural authority, logic, or respected teachers. Instead, examine through direct experience whether teachings lead to harm or benefit. Using the concrete examples of greed, hatred, and delusion versus their opposites, the Buddha shows how we can evaluate teachings by their fruits in our lives.

Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the Buddha's emphasis on personal investigation over blind faith, connecting this ancient wisdom to contemporary challenges of discerning truth in our information-saturated world. The talk concludes with the Buddha's famous deathbed instruction to Ānanda: 'Take the Dhamma as your lamp, take yourself as your lamp.' This foundational teaching establishes the principle that ultimately, each practitioner must verify spiritual truths through their own careful investigation and experience.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

There's a very famous discourse that people always quote to express the non-dogmatic way that the Buddha taught, and it's known as the *Kalama Sutta*, the discourse to the Kalamas. The question, of course, is how do we know something is true?

Here's a time where all sorts of gurus and ideas are coming forward. It's quite an exciting little time, really. And you're living in a town, a small town, with only a few thousand inhabitants. These gurus keep turning up and telling you what for. They're all saying slightly different things, and of course, saying everybody else is absolutely useless. So you're stuck. You wonder, well, who's right and who's wrong?

If you think of these days, somebody who's been brought up in a non-religious family suddenly becomes interested in the religious field and goes out in search. I mean, it's colossal, isn't it? Where will you start? So this is, in a slightly lesser degree, the situation of the Kalamas. It's very modern in a way.

So I'll just read it through so you get the feel of the discourse, and then say one or two things and continue next week.

Thus have I heard. So remember all these scriptures were related by Ananda, his assistant, remembered by him. He had to repeat them all at this meeting.

On one occasion the Blessed One was wandering on tour with a large sangha of monks when he arrived at the town of the Kalamas called Kesaputta. Now the Kalamas of Kesaputta had heard: "It is said that the ascetic Gautama, the Sakyan son who went forth from the Sakyan family, has arrived at Kesaputta. Now a good report about that master Gautama has been circulating thus: that the blessed one is an Arahant, perfectly enlightened, accomplished in true knowledge and conduct, fortunate, knower of the world, unsurpassed leader of persons to be tamed, teacher of devas and humans, the enlightened one, the blessed one. And having realized, with his own direct knowledge, this world, with its devas, mara and brahma, this population, with its ascetics and brahmins, with its devas and humans, he makes it known to others. And he teaches a dharma that is good in the beginning, good in the middle, and good in the end, with the right meaning and expressions. He reveals a spiritual life that is perfectly complete and purified. Now it's good to see such a worthy one."

Then the Kalamas of Kesaputta approached the Blessed One. Some paid homage to him and sat down to one side. Some exchanged greetings with him and after greeting and cordial talk sat down to one side. Some saluted him reverentially and sat down to one side and some remained silent and sat down to one side.

And the Kalamas said to the Blessed One: "Venerable Sir, some ascetics and Brahmins who come to Kesaputta explain and elucidate their own doctrines, but disparage, debunk, revile and vilify the doctrines of others. But then some other ascetics and Brahmins come to Kesaputta and they too explain and elucidate their doctrines, but disparage, debunk, revile and vilify the doctrines of the others. For us, venerable sir, there is perplexity and doubt as to which of these good ascetics speaks truth and which speaks falsehood."

"It is fitting for you to be perplexed, O Kalamas. It is fitting for you to be in doubt. Doubt has arisen in you about a perplexing matter. Come, Kalamas, do not go by oral tradition." So this is the bit that's always quoted. "Do not go by oral tradition, by lineage

of teaching, by hearsay, by a collection of texts, by logic, by inferential reasoning, by reasoned cogitation, by the acceptance of a view after pondering it, by the seeming competence of a speaker, or because you think the ascetic is our teacher. But when you know for yourselves these things are unwholesome, these things are blameable, these things are censured by the wise. These things, if undertaken in practice, lead to harm and suffering, then you should abandon them."

"Now what do you think, Kalamas? When greed, hatred and delusion arise in a person, is it for his welfare or harm?"

"For his harm, Venerable Sir."

"Kalamas, a person who is greedy, hating and deluded, overpowered by greed, hatred and delusion, his thoughts controlled by them, will destroy life, take what's not given, engage in sexual misconduct and tell lies. He will also prompt others to do likewise. Will that conduct be to his harm and suffering for a long time?"

"Yes, Venerable Sir."

"Now what do you think, Kalamas? Are these things wholesome or unwholesome?"

"Unwholesome, Venerable Sir."

"Blameable or blameless?"

"Blameable, Venerable Sir."

"Censured or praised by the wise?"

"Censured, venerable sir."

"Undertaken and practiced, do they lead to harm and suffering or not? Or how is it in this case?"

"Undertaken and practiced, these things lead to harm and suffering, so it appears to us in this case."

"It is for this reason, Kalamas, that we said, do not go by oral tradition..." I'm going to repeat that. Remember, this is the oral tradition, so it's put in a very repetitious way so people can remember it.

Now he goes on to the opposite. "So what do you think Kalamas? When non-greed, non-hatred and non-delusion arise in a person, is it for his welfare or harm?"

"For his welfare, venerable sir."

"Kalamas, a person who is without greed, without hatred, without delusion, not overpowered by greed and hatred and delusion, his thoughts not controlled by them, will abstain from the destruction of life, from taking what is not given, from sexual misconduct and from false speech. He will also prompt others to do likewise. Will that conduce to his welfare and happiness for a long time?"

"Yes, Venerable Sir."

"What do you think, Kalamas? Are these things wholesome or unwholesome?"

"Wholesome, Venerable Sir."

"Blameable or blameless?"

"Blameless, Venerable Sir."

"Censured or praised by the wise?"

"Praised, venerable sir."

"Undertaken and practiced, do they lead to welfare and happiness or not? Or how is it in this case?"

"Undertaken and practiced, these things lead to welfare and happiness. So it appears to us in this case."

"It is for this reason, Kalamas, that I said, do not go by oral tradition, and so forth."

And then he gives them this practice: "Then Kalamas, that noble disciple, devoid of covetousness, devoid of ill will, unconfused, clearly comprehending and ever mindful, dwells pervading one quarter with a mind imbued with loving kindness. Likewise the second, the third and the fourth. Thus above, below and across and everywhere and to all as to himself, he dwells pervading the entire world with a mind imbued with loving kindness, vast, exalted, measureless, without hostility and without ill will."

And this he says also of compassion, altruistic joy and equanimity.

"When Kalamas, this noble disciple has thus made his mind free of enmity, free of ill will, uncorrupted and pure, he has won four assurances in this very life.

The first assurance he has won is this: if there is another world and if good and bad deeds bear fruit and yield results, it is possible that on the breakup of the body after death I shall arise in a good destination in a heavenly world.

The second assurance he has won is this: if there is no other world and if good and bad deeds do not bear fruit and yield results, still right here in this very life, I live happily, free of enmity and ill will.

The third assurance he has won is this: suppose evil befalls the evildoer. Then, as I do not intend evil for anyone, how can suffering affect me, one who does no evil deed?

The fourth assurance he has won is this: suppose evil does not befall an evildoer, then right here I see myself purified in both respects.

When Kalamas, this noble disciple has thus made his mind free of enmity, free of ill will, uncorrupted and pure, he has won these four assurances in this very life."

"So it is, blessed one, so it is, fortunate one, when this noble disciple has thus made his mind free of enmity, free of ill will, uncorrupted and pure, he has won these four assurances in this very life."

And then the usual ending: "Magnificent Venerable Sir, Magnificent Venerable Sir, the Blessed One has made the Dharma clear in many ways, as though he were turning upright what had been overthrown, revealing what had been hidden, showing the way to one who was lost, or holding up a lamp in the darkness so those with good eyesight can see forms. So now we go for refuge to the Blessed One, to the Dharma and to the Sangha of Monks. Let the Blessed One accept us as lay followers who have gone to refuge from today until life's end."

Very successful, eh? So let's just look at this, the main thing that he says. The first one he says is don't believe anything. Don't believe anything just because it comes from these things that are established by scriptural authorities or something coming from the past - so oral tradition, lineage of the teacher, hearsay, collection of texts. So fundamentalists might be described as people who believe that the texts are infallible, that they are true records and that they have to be entirely and fully believed.

My brother-in-law believes that the whole of the Bible is the word of God, full stop. And you'll find people in the East who believe that all the scriptures are actually the word of the Buddha, I mean the direct word of the Buddha. Sometimes you can get the flavour of the Buddha's teaching coming through, but to say, you know, to make a statement that it's the actual words he spoke... but it gives them assurance that, you know, it must be right. Of course they don't recognise that the way they read it is their own interpretation. Putting that aside, they just take it for real.

Then there are the four rational grounds: logic, inferential reasoning and reasoned cogitation and the acceptance of views after pondering upon it. Now most people would think that if they'd thought something through it must necessarily be true. But we know from the history of our own rationality that it can lead you in a very strange place.

I mean, our 18th century enlightenment, which was about rationality, and probably its greatest product was the Declaration of Human Rights, also produced communism and Nazism, which were very rational doctrines. Remember, all rationality has to be based on a premise. And if the premise is wrong, then you're going to end up somewhere else. A lot of people would believe that just because they've thought something through, it must be therefore right. It's a dangerous one, eh?

And then there are those on authoritative persons, the impressive speakers and the respected teachers. So we've had the sad death of... maybe that, yeah. I was just reading some of the responses. It's unbelievable, actually. It's as bad as it was when she was there. The opposing views. And, you know, you just don't believe somebody because they have authority.

So now you've got this real problem of how do you find out whether something is true or not? Then on top of that, you've got the post-modern understanding that all our truths are completely relative to the individual person. So whatever's true for you, well, it might be true for you, but it's not true for me.

So you have these three ways of trying to decide for ourselves as to what's true: what's given to us from traditions, what we can think about and rationalise with others and come to some understanding, and what's true for me. So the Buddha simply says well go back to your experience and that's why he talks about something which is so concrete as greed, hatred and delusion and he asks you well does this create harm or not. So he's always going back to direct experience and to using that as a basis for our understanding of what truth is.

So remember that when he died, when he was dying, Ananda asks him, are you going to leave somebody to lead us? And he says, no. He said, take the Dharma, the teaching, as your light, as your lamp. Take yourself as the lamp. See? So the Dharma, of course, is the tradition and all that, and the logic and all that. But eventually, I'm afraid it's us. And if we get it wrong, it's only us that suffer.

So it's a very important point for us to think about. How do we know something is true? How do we know something is true?

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you, by your investigation of this, arrive at that place of utter happiness sooner rather than later.

Desire the Root of Suffering

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 12 min

In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines a powerful sutta dialogue where the Buddha demonstrates his masterful teaching method. Rather than discussing abstract concepts about past or future suffering, the Awakened One brings the teaching directly into the present moment, asking a village headman about his relationships with people in his town.

Through careful questioning about the headman's attachments to his son and wife, the Buddha reveals how taṇhā (craving or desire based on wrong understanding) creates psychological dependency and becomes the source of all suffering. Bhante Bodhidhamma clarifies that not all desires cause suffering—only those rooted in misunderstanding and seeking happiness in things that cannot truly deliver it.

The talk explores the Second Noble Truth and demonstrates how the Buddha's oral teaching tradition used repetition to allow profound truths to be absorbed rather than merely intellectually understood. Bhante Bodhidhamma guides listeners in understanding how spiritual phrases can transform our thinking through contemplative repetition, drawing parallels with the Benedictine practice of lectio divina. This teaching offers both newcomers and experienced practitioners insight into the Buddha's pedagogical brilliance and practical wisdom for recognizing the roots of suffering in daily life.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sama Sambuddhasa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sama Sambuddhasa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sama Sambuddhasa Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and fully self-enlightened.

This particular passage is called the visible origins and passing away of suffering. But the reason I want to use it in this little section which is about approaching the Dharma is that it gives us an even clearer view of how the Buddha taught. It's just nice to see how he very carefully guides people to understanding and reinforces it.

So I'll read through and then we'll stop for little comments. So on one occasion, the Blessed One was dwelling at the town of the Melians named Uruvelacapa. Then Bhadraka, the headman, approached the Blessed One, paid homage to him, sat down to one side and said it would be good venerable sir if the blessed one would teach me about the origin and passing away of suffering.

If headman I were to teach you about the origin and passing away of suffering with reference to the past saying so it was in the past, perplexity and uncertainty about that might arise in you. And if I were to teach you about the origin and passing away of suffering with reference to the future saying so it will be in the future, perplexity and uncertainty about what might happen might arise in you. Instead, headman, while I'm sitting right here and you're sitting right there, I'll teach you about the origin and passing away of suffering. Now listen and attend closely and I will speak.

Remember, these are all remembered and it captures the manner in which they spoke to each other. Yes, venerable sir.

The Blessed One said now what do you think headman are there any people in Uruvelacapa on whose account sorrow lamentation pain dejection and despair would arise in you if they were to be executed in prison fined or censured? Well there are such people when it was there. But are there any people in Uruvelacapa on whose account sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair would not arise in you in such event? There are such people. So why is it, headman, that in relation to some people in Uruvelacapa, sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair would arise in you if they were to be executed, imprisoned, fined or censured, while in regard to others they would not arise in you?

Well, those people in Uruvelacapa, Venerable Sir, in relation to whom sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair would arise in me if they were executed, imprisoned, fined or censured, these are the ones for whom I have a desire and attachment. And for those in relation to whom they would not arise in me, these are the ones I have no desire and attachment. Probably the opposite.

Headman, by means of this principle that is seen, understood, immediately attained, fathomed, apply the method to the past and the future thus. Whatever suffering arose in the past, all that arose rooted in desire, with desire as its source, for desire is the root of suffering. Whatever suffering will arise in the future, all that will arise rooted in desire, with desire as its source, for desire is the root of suffering.

And you get this and the usual great praise. He's wonderful venerable, it's amazing venerable sir, how well that was stated by the Blessed One. And then he tells the Buddha what he just heard. Whatever suffering arises all that is rooted in desire has desire at its source for desire is the root of suffering. That's what therapists do, isn't it? They listen to you and then they tell you what they've just heard. So he's pretty good to tell the Buddha that in fact he's just heard what he said.

Now you'll notice here that the Buddha always starts with what a person can experience right here and now. So he doesn't start talking about suffering and pain in the past like why did it happen in the past, now I've got this pain, if I do this, what will happen? He brings it right down to the very present, to the very present now, and he's just asking a very simple question. If anybody whom you have a love for, an attachment for, were to suffer some sort of misfortune, would you suffer for them? Yeah, I would. But of course, other people whom you don't know, or those people whom you dislike, as a result, you might rejoice.

So very quickly brings the person to understand this role of desire. Now remember that whenever we're talking about desire we're always talking about a specific type of desire because translating words from one language into another is always very difficult to get the exact translation. This desire is translating the word *taṇhā*, and *taṇhā* is the desires that we have based on wrong understanding, and that wrong understanding is seeking happiness in something which is not going to deliver basically that. And what happens is we form a psychological dependency on something and that's where the problem lies.

So desires to do with wanting to become liberated, desires coming out of a pure act of love or a pure act of generosity or an act of compassion or joy like giving somebody a present for their birthday but doing it just for the joyfulness of it to increase the other person's joy, all those desires are to our benefit. They make the heart grow. But as soon as something creeps in there which is to do with I give a present so somebody will like me, then I'm into a relationship which eventually can cause me suffering.

So now he wants to reinforce that. So now he gets to be more personal. So this man repeats to the Buddha, right, well, this is the root of desire. And then he tells him, he says, look, Venerable Sir, I have a son called Chirovati. So now this man, in his insight, is now linking it to the relationship he has to his son, who stays at an outside residence. And I rise early and send a man, saying, go, man, and find out how Chiravasi is. And until that man returns, Venerable Sir, I'm upset, thinking, I hope Chiravasi has not met with any affliction. So there's a parent's worry.

And what do you think, headman, replies the Buddha, if Chiravasi were to be executed in prison, fined or censured, would sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair arise in you? Venerable sir, if Chiravasi were to be executed in prison, fined or censured, even my life would seem futile. So how could sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair not arise in me? In this way, too, headman, it's to be understood. Whatever suffering arises, all that arises rooted in desire, with desire as its source, for desire is the root of suffering.

Now, you have to make these statements, you have to repeat them and let them sink in. They have to be digested. What the Buddha is saying is, whatever suffering arises, all that arises rooted in desire. You have to keep repeating that. Remember, suffering is not the same as pain, physical pain. That's a given. But whatever suffering arises, all that arises rooted in desire. With desire as its source, for desire is the root of suffering.

These phrases have a real power when you just gently repeat them to yourself in the quietness, in some way in which you can feel the digestion. You don't have to think about it, because it's going in, it's like osmosis, you're absorbing it, and it's actually beginning to change your attitude by doing that. That's the way spiritual reading works. You don't have to think about it.

And then he wants to really drive it home. This is the final nail. What do you think, headman? Before you saw your wife or heard about her, did you have any desire, attachment or affection for her? No, venerable sir. Then was it, headman, only when you saw her or heard about her that this desire, attachment and affection rose in you? Yes, venerable sir.

Now what do you think, headman? If your wife were to be executed, imprisoned, fined or censured, would sorrow, lamentation, pain and despair arise in you? Venerable sir, if my wife were to be executed, imprisoned, fined and censured, even my life would seem futile. So how could sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair not arise in me? He drives home the point. Well, in this way too, headman, it's to be understood. Whatever suffering arises all that is rooted in desire with desire as its source for desire is the root of suffering.

So there's something about the oral tradition where you repeat it and repeat it and repeat it, and these phrases if you when you read the scriptures, when you come across a phrase which catches you, and it doesn't have to be the scriptures, it could be any spiritual work, and a phrase catches you, or a sentence catches you, or even a small paragraph, and you think, that's interesting, don't think of it, just keep repeating it, keep repeating it.

And you find that you keep going back to it, it's like a piece of music, and then eventually you get fed up with it. And at that point, you know it's been digested. And then it comes out in funny ways. It actually changes the way you think. It comes out, as it were, through the back entrance. And that's a beautiful way. This is the way that the Benedictines, that's their *Lectio Meditatio*, isn't it? *Contemplatio*. I think that's right. So they read. And they do this repetition business. And then they sit in stillness. If thoughts come up, it's fine. It's not as though you're trying not to think. But what you want to do is to absorb these little sentences that you find. Little paragraphs.

There we are. Suffering is rooted in desire. Second noble truth. I can only hope that these words have finally driven home the truth. Suffering is in fact rooted in desire. And hopefully you'll work towards your liberation and find *Nibbāna* sooner rather than later.

Sādhū, sādhū, sādhū.

How to Test the Buddha

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 14 min

In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines a remarkable discourse where the Buddha instructs his followers on how to investigate whether a teacher is truly awakened — including the Buddha himself. Drawing from the Vīmaṃsaka Sutta, this teaching reveals the Buddha's extraordinary openness to scrutiny and his insistence that spiritual claims must be verified through personal experience.

The discourse outlines a systematic method of investigation: observing a teacher's conduct and speech for defiled, mixed, or purified states; examining whether their attainments are stable over time; assessing how they handle fame and renown; and determining if their restraint comes from genuine freedom rather than fear. Bhante shares the story of Ajahn Chah's investigation of a supposedly liberated teacher, illustrating how authentic spiritual realization manifests in consistent behaviour.

This teaching emphasizes that faith (saddhā) in the Buddha, Dhamma, and Saṅgha should ultimately be 'rooted in vision' — grounded in one's own direct experience of the path and its fruits. The Buddha's radical transparency and invitation to question everything reflects the Dhamma's foundation in verifiable truth rather than blind belief, making this essential listening for anyone serious about authentic spiritual practice.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

If you remember, we read the Kalama discourse, where the Buddha is basically saying that you have to question everything that's been taught to you, and it has to be true for yourself. You have to put it into practice and make sure it's true for yourself. Then, of course, he takes the opportunity of telling them what the Dhamma is. But this here, this particular section is the Buddha actually telling people how to investigate whether the teacher is fully liberated or not. He was talking about himself.

Thus have I heard: on one occasion the Blessed One was living at Savatthi in Jeta's Grove, Anathapindika's Park. And there he addressed the group of monks. Remember in the scriptures "monks" refers to the listeners, so it could have been quite a large congregation really. "Venerable Sir," they replied, and the Blessed One said this: "A monk"—

occasionally I'll translate that as a person—"a person who is an inquirer, not knowing how to gauge another's mind, should make an investigation of the Tathagata in order to find out whether or not he is perfectly enlightened."

So he's already saying that to these people who are his followers: How do you know I'm the Tathagata? How do you know I'm fully liberated? And they reply: "Our teachings are rooted in the Blessed One, guided by the Blessed One, have the Blessed One as their resort. It would be good if the Blessed One would explain the meaning of these words. Having heard it from him, we shall remember it." "Then listen and attend closely to what I shall say." "Yes, Venerable Sir."

"A person who is an inquirer, not knowing how to gauge another's mind"—in other words, not being able to see a person as they are—"should investigate the Tathagata"—remember that's what he referred to himself as; he translates rather sillily as "thus gone," just "the transcendent" I think, because he always talks about the other shore, so "the transcendent one" I think is the best translation I've come across—"should investigate the Tathagata with respect to two kinds of states: states cognisable through the eye and through the ear. Thus: Are there found in the Tathagata or not any defiled states cognisable through the eye or through the ear?"—in other words, how he behaves and what he says—"And when he investigates him, he comes to know: no defiled states cognisable through the eye or through the ear are found in the Tathagata."

That's the first thing, right? So, in other words, observe a person's behaviour and listen to what they say.

"When he comes to know this, he investigates further thus: Are there found in the Tathagata or not any mixed states cognisable through the eye or through the ear? When he investigates him thus, he knows: no mixed states cognisable through the eye or through the ear are found in the Tathagata." So mixed states refers to the fact that sometimes we behave well and sometimes we behave awfully. Sometimes we say things are good and sometimes not. So these are mixed states. But these are not found in the Tathagata. That's the important point.

"When he comes to know this, he investigates further: Are there found in the Tathagata or not cleansed states cognisable through the eye or through the ear? When he investigates this: cleansed states cognisable through the eye or through the ear are found in the Tathagata." And of course those are your beautiful states.

There's a little story that I remember hearing about Ajahn Chah, which if I remember rightly goes something like this. He'd heard that there was somebody who was fully liberated. And so he thought, well, I'll go and live with the person. And for a long time, I

don't know how long, he was quite convinced that this person had in fact was fully liberated and he had that reputation. And one day he caught—what had happened was somebody had offered meat to the monks there, and a dog had got onto the meat, and he saw this, the Tathagata, this very liberated person, get very angry and give the dog one hell of a kick. And upon that, it seems, he left.

So he doesn't say—it's not actually in this particular discourse, or at least he's not quoted in this discourse—that you have to live a long time with somebody to know what they're like.

So that's the first thing, you see, to actually observe the person, the Tathagata, to see what they do and what they say.

Now the next thing is, he investigates further: "Has this venerable one attained the wholesome state over a long time, or did he attain it recently? When he investigates him, he comes to know: the venerable one has attained this wholesome state over a long time and has not attained it just recently." So that gives a certain depth to his practice, you see.

"Now when he comes to know this, he investigates still further: Has the Venerable One acquired renown and attained fame so that the dangers connected with renown and fame are found in him? For as long as a monk has not acquired renown and attained fame, the dangers connected with renown and fame are not found in him. But when he has acquired renown and attained fame, those dangers are found in him." So the dangers are, of course, conceit, arrogance, etc. "And when he investigates him, he knows thus: this venerable one has acquired renown and attained fame, but the dangers associated with renown fame are not found in him." That's another way you can tell whether somebody is fully liberated.

"And when he comes to know this, he investigates him further: Is the Venerable One restrained without fear, not restrained by fear? And does he avoid indulging in sensual pleasures because he is without lust through the destruction of lust? And when he investigates him, he comes to know: yes, the Venerable One is restrained without fear, not restrained by fear, and he avoids indulging in sensual pleasure because he is without lust through the destruction of lust." Lust here refers to any sensual pleasure.

"Now if others should ask that monk thus: What are the Venerable One's reasons and what is his evidence whereby he says that Venerable One is restrained without fear, not restrained by fear, and he avoids indulging in sensual pleasures because he is without lust through the destruction of lust? Answering rightly, that monk would answer thus: Whether that Venerable One dwells in the Sangha, or alone, while some there are well

behaved, and some are ill behaved, and some there teach, and some there teach a group, while some here are seen concerned with material things, and some are sullied, are unsullied by material things, still the Venerable One does not despise anyone because of that. And I have heard and learned this from the Blessed One's lips: that I am restrained without fear, not constrained by fear. And I avoid indulging in sensual pleasure because I am without lust through the destruction of lust."

In other words, even though he himself is fully liberated, he does not despise people who aren't because of their behaviour. He remains impartial, faithfully enough.

"So the Tathagata monk should be questioned further about this, about this: Are there found in the Tathagata or not any defiled states cognisable through the eye or through the ear? The Tathagata would answer: No defiled states cognisable through the eye or through the ear are found in the Tathagata. And if asked: Are there found in the Tathagata or not any mixed states cognisable through the eye or through the ear? The Tathagata would answer thus: No mixed states cognisable through the eye or through the ear are found in the Tathagata. And if asked: Are there found in the Tathagata or not cleansed states cognisable through eye or through the ear? The Tathagata would say: Cleansed states cognisable through the eye or through the ear are found in the Tathagata. They are my pathway, my domain, yet I do not identify with them."

So now he's answered these questions, you see, but he makes the clear statement that this is the way he lives, but he does not identify with them. So again it's a statement of the Tathagata being the transcendent one. Transcendent but also immanent in the world.

"A disciple should approach the teacher who speaks thus in order to hear the Dhamma. The teacher teaches him the Dhamma with its successively higher levels, with its successively more sublime levels, with its dark and bright counterparts. And as the teacher teaches the Dhamma to a monk in this way, through direct knowledge of a certain teaching here in that Dhamma, the monk comes to a conclusion about the teachings. He places confidence in the Buddha thus: the Blessed One is perfectly enlightened, the Dhamma is well proclaimed by the Blessed One, and the Sangha is practising in a good way."

So here we see the growth of faith, and the growth of faith drawing the monk, or the practitioner, into further practice. There's a note here which tries to clarify that. I may as well try and read it: "When the Dharma has been taught by the Master"—this is from one of the commentaries—"when the Dharma has been taught by the Master, the monk, by directly knowing the Dharma, through penetration of the path, fruit and *Nibbāna*, comes to a conclusion regarding the preliminary teachings of the Dharma about the

aids of enlightenment, which are the factors of enlightenment." In other words, it's a long-winded way of saying that as the person becomes, has his own experience of path and fruit, he understands the factors of enlightenment.

And then finally: "What are the Venerable One's reasons and what is his evidence whereby he says the Blessed One is perfectly enlightened, the Dharma is well proclaimed by the Blessed One, the Sangha is practising the good way? Answering rightly, that monk would answer thus: Here friends, I approach the Blessed One in order to hear the Dharma. The Blessed One taught me the Dharma with its successively high levels, with its successively more sublime levels, with its dark and bright counterpart. And as the Blessed One taught the Dhamma to me in this way, through direct knowledge of a certain teaching here in that Dhamma, I came to the conclusion about the teachings, and I placed confidence in the teacher thus." So in other words, at this point he's actually had the experience of path and fruit, and the confidence is a strong one in the Buddha. "The Blessed One is perfectly enlightened, the Dhamma is well proclaimed by the Blessed One, and the Sangha is practising well."

"When anyone's faith has been planted, rooted and established in the Tathagata through these reasons, terms and phrases, his faith is said to be supported by reasons, rooted in the vision"—in other words his own experience—"firm. It is invincible by any ascetic or Brahmin or Deva or Mara or Brahma or by anyone in the world. That is how, monks, there is an investigation of the Dhamma in accordance with the Dhamma. And that is how the Tathagata is well investigated in accordance with the Dhamma. That is what the Blessed One said, and the monks were satisfied"—the listeners were satisfied—"and delighted in the Buddha's words."

So, the Buddha here is telling us that we just need to keep that questioning going. We need not to take anything just because he's the Buddha. Everything that has been handed down to us has to be verified by our own personal experience. That's what it comes down to.

I can only hope this small exposition has been of some assistance and that you may be fully liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Sādhū, sādhū.

01 Introducing the Buddha

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this opening talk of the series, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines how Buddhism has been reinterpreted in different cultures throughout history, from Tibet to Japan to the modern West. He discusses the various ways Western practitioners view the Buddha - as ethical reformer, empiricist, existential psychologist, or agnostic teacher - while emphasizing that the Buddha's own self-understanding transcends these limited interpretations.

Drawing from passages in the Aṅguttara Nikāya, Bhante explores the Buddha's declaration of himself as the Tathāgata - one who has 'gone beyond' or 'come from beyond' the ordinary psychophysical organism. The talk covers the Buddha's description of his unique arising "for the welfare of the multitude, out of compassion (anukampanā) for the world," and his mastery of the six unsurpassed qualities, four analytical knowledges, and the four stages of awakening from stream entry to Arahatship.

This foundational talk encourages practitioners to remain open to the Buddha's own understanding of his transcendent nature, while acknowledging the empirical approach that makes his psychological insights so accessible to modern practitioners. The discussion touches on challenging topics like rebirth, emphasizing the Buddha's emphasis on direct experience over blind faith.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

I'm going to start on this new chapter, which is entitled "The Bringer of Light" from *The Buddha's Words* by Bhikkhu Bodhi. I want to begin by quoting something from his foreword.

When Buddhism first came to the West, they thought that the Buddha was really the sun god, a mythical figure. It was only later that, when they rediscovered the sites in India—I think it was Cunningham, who was an army surveyor—found the actual sites and therefore established the truth that in fact he was a human being, lived about 500 years before the common era. At the same time was the Jain leader, the Mahāvīra. And at the same time that the scriptures were being developed in the Brahminical religion, which we now call Hinduism.

But it says here, depending on our biases and predispositions, we may choose to regard the Buddha as a liberal ethical reformer of a degenerate Brahmanism, as a great secular humanist, as a radical empiricist, as an existential psychologist, as a proponent of a sweeping agnosticism, or as a precursor of any intellectual faction that meets our fancy.

Whenever Buddhism has gone into a different country, it's always been reinterpreted by that country. And it's always kept the basic tenets. Nobody can declare Buddhism without the Four Noble Truths. It's absolutely basic. But the way that a country receives it depends on their tradition they receive.

So, for instance, in Tibet, the shamanism of Bon had a great effect on it. And then when it moved to China, Taoism had a great effect on the reinterpretation of the Buddhist teachings. When it got to Japan, it was similar. The Japanese had a similar problem with things like rebirth, because they didn't have it. They had ancestors and they worshipped, but they didn't have this idea of onward-going rebirthing. And their way of tackling that problem was to simply centre the teaching on the immediate presence. So whenever you read Japanese Buddhism, it's all about the here and now, rather than these future lives, which you would get from the scriptures.

When it comes to the West, what's happened in the West is that a whole load of stuff has come. All types of Buddhism have landed on our doorstep. From every country where there is Buddhism, it's here. It's here in Britain, it's here in Europe, it's definitely here in America. So as it comes in, we ourselves have our own interpretation. Not only as a society as a whole, but individually.

Here we have a list of ways that people have seen the Buddha. Often he attracts people who believe in only one life, who are based in science because the way the Buddha talks about the psychology is so close to the way we understand it. And that's one of the reasons why all this mindfulness has entered into the mainstream. It's because we can understand it, we can understand the human being from that point of view. It's almost basic psychology, and the role of desire, addiction, all that. So it makes immediate sense to us, that part of the Buddha's teaching.

He's an empiricist. In other words, nothing is given to us without it being tried out. If it doesn't work, it isn't Buddhism, full stop. So everything that he puts to us through the meditational practices, which isn't just this *vipassanā*, it includes the goodwill practice and all. There's a whole flurry of practices. And they're there as something for us to try. It has to be something experienced. And it either works for us or it doesn't.

One of the things that annihilationists in his day, materialists, would say to the Buddha was, "I don't believe in all this rebirth stuff." He said, but even so, if you follow the Dharma, if you follow these teachings, you'll get benefits in this life. And if after this life you're just annihilated, fine, but at least you'll have the benefit of it in this life.

And then existential psychologist. So it's a psychology for this present moment with nothing beyond really the psychophysical organism. It's like defining a human being only by their body and their minds. Their mind meaning their emotional life and their thoughts.

And then a sweeping agnosticism, like not believing in anything. This often refers to a discourse where he goes to these people called the Kalamas, and we'll come to that later on in the book, who are very confused because this teacher says this, this teacher turns up and says that, so they're completely confused. And by the end of this talking to them, he says, "Look, if it's not right for you, it's not true. You've got to try it out. You've got to actually make it true for yourself."

So in a sense, it's that sort of not believing anything, not believing anything in the sense of a blind belief. It's more in the sense of a confidence. So we have this quality of *saddhā*, which is translated as confidence, not so much faith, because if you say faith to people, it tends to give the suggestion that you've got to believe it, whether it's true or not. But that would be the wrong attitude. From the Buddha's point of view, that would actually undermine your investigation. And it's the process of investigating ourselves which is the process of liberation. So if you don't investigate yourself you just stay as you are. You can read as many books as you want which is not going to liberate you from suffering.

So that's the first thing, that basically we have to remember that when we read about the Buddha himself, the Buddha as a person, we're always interpreting what he does from what satisfies us. But, unfortunately for a lot of people, the Buddha doesn't talk about himself in quite such humanistic terms, in terms of "I am just this body and mind." He actually refers to himself as the *Tathāgata*.

Now this word, the word that it is, is *Tathā*, which means "there", and it can be either translated as "come there", *Āgata*, or "gone there". And basically it translates as transcendent. It's somebody who has transcended the psychophysical organism. Now that's a very different sort of statement. And in that sense, he's fulfilling, in his own terms, some very deep, original archetype that is within us, that there is something in us which is actually beyond this body and mind.

So, depending on where you stand, that would either be an impossibility, and you're not prepared to accept it, or it opens up a possibility. I had a person come there. He was studying some sort of science. It might have been biology at a university. And he came on one of the courses I was holding at Gaia House, and he came to me after two or three days when I'd given these talks, and he said, "I came here to meditate. I don't believe all this stuff about afterlife and all this stuff." And he couldn't handle it. Off he went. I would never put it to him that he has to believe this in order to get the benefit of the meditation. But he just couldn't handle being in any situation that suggested that there was anything beyond this body and mind. The human being as you can actually see them.

This idea of something beyond, all over the scriptures, the explanation of *Nibbāna* is always something beyond the phenomenal. It's an island. It's something which is separated from, that you have to move towards. So that's there within the scriptures. But again, you have to remember that that's not something you have to believe, but it's something we need to know. That he doesn't talk about himself as just being a liver and heart and a bit of emotions and the brain.

And the one that I think where we associate with the Buddha is, of course, with his humanness. So he goes through that struggle. He actually liberates himself as a human being here on this earth. And the path that he treads is the path that he's actually pointing to. And he says that he's not inventing the path, he's discovering it, he's rediscovering it. It was always there, it's just that he was able to rediscover it and lay it out before us. So it's not that he invented Buddhism. And that's what I think to us as Westerners, that's where we make our connection to him as somebody who also practiced, who also went through all the problems that we have and then declared that he didn't have those problems anymore.

And of course included in this business of things that we find hard to believe is the whole teaching around rebirth. And we'll come to passages which presume that that's exactly what happens to us. Now, I've put on my website, if you go onto it, on the front page on the left panel there, there's a special page. I've named it "Subjects." And if you click on that, it'll take you to a page which looks at certain things that we have difficulties with. So rebirth, euthanasia, vegetarianism. And there's a link there to a YouTube of a young American boy who remembers his past life as a pilot being shot down by the Japanese in the Pacific. And if you follow that through, you see him both as a little kid, about four years old, and later on as an 11-year-old. And there's no doubt that he... It's astonishing because he knows things about the family. He doesn't belong to his old family. But he remembers them. He remembers who it is. And when he goes to see

his sister, who then is an elderly lady, he tells her things that only the family would know. So you've got a big problem if you think it's something that comes through on your genes, because he's come from a completely different gene family.

So I just want to read this opening passage which actually is the Buddha declaring himself as to who he is and what he is. And remember when we say monks it's anybody who's listening.

"Monks, there is one person who arises in the world for the welfare of the multitude, for the happiness of the multitude, out of compassion for the world, for the good, welfare and happiness of *devas* and humans. Who is that one person? It is the *Tathāgata*, the *Arahant*, the perfectly enlightened one. This is that one person."

Now, you'll notice here he says, for the multitude. Often that's translated as "the many." He doesn't say for everybody. Some people just aren't ready for it. And this word compassion is a lovely word. It's not the usual word that some of you might know, *karuṇā*. It's *anukampanā*. And *kampati* means to shake, to tremble. And *anu* means to tremble towards. So you get the feeling of a resonance, out of resonance with other human beings, he offers this teaching to alleviate their suffering.

"There is one person arising in the world who is unique without a peer, without counterpart, incomparable, unequaled, matchless, unrivaled, the best of humans. Who is that one person? It is the *Tathāgata*, the *Arahant*, the perfectly enlightened one. This is that one person."

Now it sounds really sure enough, doesn't it? I mean, can you imagine saying something like that about yourself? "I am the one." So here we have to recognise that these scriptures were worked on and there are three levels to the scriptures. The original level you can see, it's very chatty, it's very conversational and you can see that his teaching has not been formalised so greatly as it becomes. Then there's the middle section which is the formalised part and this would be part of that. And then towards the end of the scriptures, you get these lists, lists which move then into a later work, which is called the *Abhidhamma*. And he obviously said things about himself, which were then built up into these statements.

"The manifestation of one person is the manifestation of great love, of great vision, of great light, of great radiance. It is the manifestation of the six things unsurpassed, the realization of the four analytical knowledges, the penetration of the various elements, of the diversity of elements. It is the realization of the fruit of knowledge and liberation,

the realization of the fruits of stream entry, once returning, non-returning and *Arahatship*. Who is that one person? It is the *Tathāgata*, the *Arahant*, the perfectly enlightened one. This is that one person."

Now there's a hell of a lot in that little paragraph because it presumes that we understand all these different things that they're talking about. But what he's saying here is that he has discovered this path, and he's not only discovered it, he knows it root and branch. And he's been able to lay down all the facets of that particular path. And you can see that from the massive amount of teaching that there is around these scriptures. So that every part of that journey is covered. And that's what he's saying here.

This stuff comes up later, so we needn't go into it in such great detail. But just so that the six things that are unsurpassed is the unsurpassed sight of the Buddha and his disciples. The unsurpassed hearing of the Dharma from the Buddha and his disciples. The unsurpassed gain, the gain of confidence in the Buddha and his disciples. The unsurpassed training. So this is the higher morality, higher mind, higher wisdom as taught by the Buddha and his disciples. The unsurpassed service, the service to the Buddha and his disciples, and the unsurpassed recollection. So that's meditating, contemplating the Buddha and his disciples. These are the six unsurpassable things.

When it comes to the analytical knowledges, the four analytical knowledges, it's basically a way of discussing things, a logical way, a philosophical way. And they include an analysis of a meaning of something, the reasons and causes and conditions why they arise, an analysis of the language that you're actually using, and understanding all the processes that bring about something. It's an analysis of that. So the Buddha's teaching is really about deconstructing things, about analyzing things and seeing how they come to be.

And then finally, all that business about the elements, all that is to do with what makes up a human being. Again, there'll be another time we can go into that in more detail. Obviously, the first two big elements are the body and the mind. And then these things that we mentioned at the end, the stream entry, once returning, non-returning, and *Arahant*, these are the four paths and fruits that are entered upon on the path. And they are gradations of insight as you go through. And they each have an effect on our personality and on our characters.

So, for instance, by the time that you're a non-returner, you've lost, really, any attachment, any psychological dependency on any pleasures of this world for your happiness. So your happiness is based on something else. That's what attachment is. Attachment is psychological dependency on something outside ourselves for our personal happiness.

So that gives you some idea of how the Buddha talked about himself. So, although there are these interpretations, remember that it's for us, really, to decide where the Buddha stands for us in our lives, and yet not to be closed by that definition that we've put on that person, just to be open to the fact that actually what he's saying about himself may actually be true.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and that in contemplating the Buddha's life it may bring about a certain urgency to your own spiritual practice that you may arrive to that lovely place of *Nibbāna* sooner rather than later. *Sādhu, sādhu, sādhu.*

The Birth of the Buddha

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min

In this second episode of the series on the Buddha's life, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the traditional account of the Buddha's miraculous birth from the Acchariyabbhutatthamma Sutta (MN 123). The talk explores how the oral tradition developed mythic elements around the Bodhisattva's descent from Tusita heaven, his pure birth, and his first proclamation as a newborn declaring his final rebirth.

Bhante contextualizes this narrative within the ancient Indian worldview of cyclical time and multiple Buddhas, while noting parallels with other religious traditions. He explains the six realms of existence and the concept of the Bodhisattva - one aspiring to become a fully self-awakened Buddha who establishes a dispensation.

Crucially, the Buddha concludes this mythic account by returning to the essence of his achievement: perfect awareness of feelings, perceptions, and thoughts as they arise, remain present, and pass away. This juxtaposition highlights how the ultimate 'marvel' of the Tathāgata lies not in supernatural birth circumstances, but in the complete awakened awareness that defines true Buddhahood.

The episode offers insight into how early Buddhist communities understood their teacher both as a historical figure and as part of a cosmic pattern of awakened beings, while emphasizing that the Buddha's true significance lies in his discovery and teaching of the path to liberation.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa — honour to the Blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

We're using this book, *In the Buddha's Words* by Bhikkhu Bodhi, to investigate the discourses. We've moved into the chapter concerning the Buddha himself. Last week we discussed how people see the Buddha, either as a humanist who came up with a wonderful ethical code to make us all happy, right over to as far as a supra-human being who's capable of enormous and amazing things. There's a vast way that we can interpret the Buddha.

Here, of course, in the West, we tend to see him much more as a human being who discovered a path. Some of us believe that this *Nibbāna* that he talks about, you can get it, but you've only got one life, so you've got to be pretty lucky. Others think that you go on, and so in future lives you'll be able to get it.

This particular discourse that has been chosen gives us these two sides and we'll see how the mythic side of the Buddha was built up. It concentrates on the conception and birth of his life. I'll read it and then make comments as I go along. Remember that this is an oral tradition and therefore it has a repetitious feel about it. I won't actually put you through that misery. I'll just read out the kernel bits.

Thus have I heard. Remember it's Ānanda who remembers all that the Buddha said, and at the first meeting after his death, he's the one who related the words of the Buddha. All these discourses begin with "thus have I heard." On one occasion, the Blessed One was living at Sāvattthī in Jeta's Grove and Anāthapiṇḍika's Park.

Now, Anāthapiṇḍika was one of these new breed of people who was a merchant. This was something quite new, within the last hundred or so years of the Buddha's time. It's all part and parcel of a change in that society towards ruled by a group of elites, which was what we would call a sort of democracy, to kingship. Anāthapiṇḍika was a very successful businessman, a merchant. In those days they were moving away from barter to using money. That was the shift. Anāthapiṇḍika, upon hearing of the Buddha, had goose pimples all over his skin. When he finally met him, he determined that this was the man. He determined to buy him a piece of land for his monastics.

By this time, the Buddha had gathered around him some monks and some women, some nuns. He bought this field from Prince Jeta. Jeta didn't want to sell it. He said, "Well, what would you sell it for?" He said, "Not even if you covered the whole ground with gold coins." So Anāthapiṇḍika went on to cover the whole ground with gold coins. In this way, it became the Buddha's first monastery. It was at Sāvattthī. Sāvattthī was the capital of Kosala, which was north of the Ganges. King Pasenadi was a great supporter of the Buddha. Same caste, the Khattiya caste.

They're in this grove, they're in this monastery. A number of monks were sitting in the assembly hall when they had met together on returning from alms round. After their meal, this discussion arose amongst them: "It is wonderful, friends, it is marvellous how mighty and powerful is the *Tathāgata*. For he is able to know about the Buddhas of the past who attained final *Nibbāna*, cut the tangle of proliferation, broke the cycle, ended the round and surmounted all suffering. For those blessed ones, their

birth was thus, their names was thus, their clans was thus, their moral discipline was thus, their qualities of concentration were thus, their wisdom was thus, their meditative dwellings were thus, their liberation was thus."

Here they're saying it's an amazing thing that the Buddha also knows all about the past Buddhas. Remember, the East and the ancient world always thought in cyclic time. They didn't think in linear time. You always get this with all these saints at the time, like the Nigantha, who was the head of the Jain sect — there are always the Jinas, the victorious ones. They always look back to a whole train of them. If you know a modern Hindu saint called Nisargadatta Maharaj, he wrote I Am That. He also says that he's part of a row of equally enlightened persons. The Buddha's obviously been talking about these past Buddhas and they were quite amazed that he knew so much about them.

When this was said, the Venerable Ānanda said to the monks, "Friends, *Tathāgatas* are wonderful and have wonderful qualities. *Tathāgatas* are marvellous and have marvellous qualities." Remember the word *Tathāgata* is what the Buddha referred to himself as. It means one who has gone there, one who has arrived, best translated as the transcendent.

However, their discussion was interrupted for the Blessed One rose from meditation when it was evening, went to the assembly hall and sat down on a seat made ready. Then he addressed the monks, "For what discussion are you sitting together here?" "Here, Venerable Sir, we were sitting in the assembly hall when we met together" and then they go through the whole business that I've just told you. They came back from alms round and said how wonderful he was. The Blessed One said, "That being so, Ānanda, explain more fully the *Tathāgata's* wonderful and marvellous qualities."

Now Ānanda really settles down to explain the wonderful things that happened around the Buddha's birth. "Mindful and clearly comprehending, the *Bodhisattva* appeared in the Tusita heaven."

The *Bodhisattva* is the name we give somebody who has determined to become a fully liberated, self-liberated being. The *Bodhisattva* — this translates into Mahayana as the *bodhicitta*, the mind seeking enlightenment. Some of you might know about Ajahn Mun, who was a modern saint. He died in the early twentieth century. He's very famous and from him there came a group of monks who were all also recognised to be fully liberated. Ajahn Mun, whose biography is written by one of his disciples, Ajahn Mahā Boowa, came to a point where he realised that in his past life he had made this determination to become a fully self-enlightened Buddha, decided it was too hard, gave it up and just became an Arahant. They say that in Sri Lanka now there are five

Bodhisattvas. There are five monks who've declared themselves as seeking fully self-liberated beings. This means that they start a dispensation like the Buddha did. They start a line of teaching.

He's in the Tusita heaven. There are six realms. The hell realms, the animal realms, the realms of the hungry ghosts, the human realm, the realm of the angry gods, and the deva realm, the realm of the happy gods. All these can be, if you're not into this sort of stuff, all these can be translated as human mental states. When you're pathetic and find yourself in a gutter, you're definitely in the animal realm. If you were to really be born in that state, there wouldn't be much hope in Buddhist understanding.

The hell realms would be equivalent to our ideas of psychosis and deep depressions and such. There are places where you don't see an escape. Remember Dante wrote over the gates of hell, "Abandon all hope ye who enter here." That is hell. The difference between hell and purgatory is that it's just as painful but purgatory offers a way out. There's no permanent hell in Buddhist understanding. Everything is impermanent. It just lasts a very long time.

The hungry ghost realm, that's the place where we suffer our griefs. The human realm we know. The angry gods are really the place where you have these battles between good and evil. Then finally, of course, the happy realm where all the millionaires live.

"Mindful and clearly comprehending, the *Bodhisattva* remained in the Tusita heaven." It's understood that that's the last rebirth before he takes his final birth as a human being. This Tusita heaven is a very happy place. "For the whole of his lifespan the *Bodhisattva* remained in that Tusita heaven. Mindful and clearly comprehending." He's fully aware as we are presumably now. "The *Bodhisattva* passed away from the Tusita heaven and descended into his mother's womb."

Now we get this wonderful passage which is really quite cinematic. "When the *Bodhisattva* passed away from the Tusita heaven and descended into his mother's womb, an immeasurable great radiance surpassing the divine majesty of the devas appeared in the world with its devas, Māra and Brahmā, in this population with its ascetics and brahmins, with its devas and human beings. Even in those abysmal world intervals of vacancy, gloom and utter darkness, where the moon and sun, mighty and powerful as they are, cannot make their light prevail, there too an immeasurable great radiance surpassing the divine majesty of devas appeared, and the beings reborn there perceived each other by that light. 'Ah, so indeed there are also other beings born here.' And this 10,000 world system shook, quaked and trembled and again an immeasurable great radiance surpassing the divine majesty of the devas appeared in the world."

That's a lovely vision. Whether it's true or not is immaterial.

"When the *Bodhisattva* descended into his mother's womb, four young devas came to guard him at the four quarters so that no humans or non-humans or anyone at all could harm the *Bodhisattva* or his mother. When the *Bodhisattva* descended into his mother's womb, she became intrinsically virtuous, refraining from killing living beings, from taking what is not given, from sexual misconduct, from false speech and from wines, liquors and intoxicants, the basis of negligence."

It's interesting. A lot of the Christian mythology you see mirrored in these sorts of stories from the East.

"Other women give birth after carrying the child in a womb for nine or ten months, but not so the *Bodhisattva's* mother. The *Bodhisattva's* mother gave birth to him after carrying him in a womb for exactly ten months. Other women give birth seated or lying down, but not so the *Bodhisattva's* mother. The *Bodhisattva's* mother gave birth to him standing up."

I was thinking about that, and I presume it's to do with dignity, rather than flat on your back with your legs up in the air. You're standing in a very gentle pose. I remember seeing a clip of a film of a woman in New Guinea, actually, hanging from a branch giving birth. So it's not unknown. And by herself, by the way.

"When the *Bodhisattva* came forth from his mother's womb, first devas received him and then human beings." After all these phrases, he's always said, "This too I remember as a wonderful and marvellous quality of the Blessed One."

"When the *Bodhisattva* came from his mother's womb, he did not touch the earth. The four young devas received him and set him before his mother saying, 'Rejoice, O Queen, a son of great power has been born to you.'" That sounds biblical, doesn't it?

"When the *Bodhisattva* came forth from his mother's womb, he came forth unsullied, unsmeared by water, mucus, blood, or any kind of impurity, clean and unsullied. Suppose there were a gem placed on a fine cloth, then the gem would not smear the cloth, nor the cloth the gem. Why is that? Because of the purity of both. So too, when the *Bodhisattva* came forth, he came forth clean and unsullied.

"When the *Bodhisattva* came forth from his mother's womb, two jets of water appeared to pour from the sky, one cool and one warm, for bathing the *Bodhisattva* and his mother. As soon as the *Bodhisattva* was born, he stood firmly on his feet on the ground, and then he took seven steps facing north, and with a white parasol held over

him, he surveyed each quarter and uttered the words of the leader of the herd: 'I am the highest in the world. I am the best in the world. I am the foremost in the world. This is my last birth. There is no more renewed becoming for me.'

That's an image, isn't it? That little baby. That little scrunched up creature. It's a great image.

"When the *Bodhisattva* came forth from his mother's womb..." Again, we have that repeat of the immeasurable great radiance surpassing the divine majesty of the devas appeared in the world. "And the 10,000 world system shook, quaked and trembled and there too an immeasurable great radiance surpassing the divine majesty of the devas appeared in the world."

We have all this mythic stuff around the Buddha. The Buddha now brings us back to ground. This is what he says:

"That being so, Ānanda, remember this too as a wonderful and marvellous quality of the Buddha. Here, Ānanda, for the *Tathāgata*, feelings are known as they arise, as they are present, as they disappear. Perceptions are known as they arise, as they are present, and as they disappear. Thoughts are known as they arise, as they are present, and as they disappear. Remember this too, Ānanda, as a wonderful and marvellous quality of the *Tathāgata*."

He brings us right back to what the *Tathāgata* actually is. He's the one who knows. All this other stuff is, in a sense, immaterial.

Then, "Venerable Sir, since the Blessed One's feelings are known as they arise, as they are present, as they disappear. Perceptions are known as they arise, as they are present, as they disappear. Thoughts are known as they arise, as they are present, as they disappear. This too I remember as a wonderful and marvellous quality of the Blessed One."

That is what the Venerable Ānanda said. The teacher approved and the monks were satisfied and delighted in Venerable Ānanda's words. I can only hope that this has been a tremendous inspiration and that you will continue in your practice and attain that awareness of the Buddha sooner rather than later. The listeners were highly delighted.

The Bodhisatta Leaves Home

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 20 min

In this third episode of the series on the Buddha's life, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the profound reasons behind Prince Siddhattha's decision to leave the householder life and embark on the noble search for liberation. Drawing from the Ariyapariyesanā Sutta (MN 26), he explores the distinction between ignoble search—seeking what is subject to birth, aging, sickness, death, sorrow and defilement—and noble search for the unborn, unaging, deathless supreme security of Nibbāna.

The talk covers the future Buddha's encounter with his first teacher, Ālāra Kālāma, who taught the attainment of the base of nothingness (ākāṅkhaññāyatana), one of the formless absorptions (arūpajhāna). Despite mastering this profound meditative state and being offered joint leadership of the community, the Bodhisatta recognized that such attainments, while impressive, do not lead to true disenchantment, cessation of suffering, or final liberation—only to rebirth in corresponding realms.

Bhante Bodhidhamma clarifies common misconceptions about the Buddha's attitude toward lay life, emphasizing that the problem lies not in possessions or relationships themselves, but in being "tied to, infatuated with, and utterly absorbed" in them. He also introduces the five spiritual faculties (saddhā, vīriya, satī, samādhi, paññā) essential for spiritual development.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samasambuddhasa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samasambuddhasa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samasambuddhasa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

Now in the next passage that Bhikkhu Bodhi has chosen, The Quest for Enlightenment, there are a few discourses that describe what happened on his journey to become enlightened, and they're all slightly different, but generally speaking, the thing was he went to these two teachers who taught him how to do the absorption states, then something like two years, and then he spent four years doing these very hard self-mortification exercises, and then he became liberated. But here in this one, it doesn't mention the fact that he went off and did these self-mortification exercises. But it does tell us at the beginning why he left home.

Among these, there are two kinds of search: the noble and the ignoble search. And what is the ignoble search? Here, someone, being himself subject to birth, seeks what is also subject to birth. Being subject to ageing, seeks also what is subject to ageing. And being subject to sickness, he seeks also what is subject to sickness. And being subject to death, he seeks also what is subject to death. Being subject to sorrow, he seeks something which is subject to sorrow. And being subject to defilement, he seeks what is subject to defilement.

So remember that one of his big awakening moments was the realisation that there's sickness, ageing and death. And like the comedian says, life's hard and then you die. So that was one of his reasons for leaving the lay life, the life of the householder, as it's put usually here. But seeking himself subject to sorrow, seeks what is also subject to sorrow. So that again comes back to the idea of impermanence. So the loss of someone you love. So you're seeking something which eventually is going to bring you sorrow. Subject to defilement, he seeks also something subject to defilement. So that can range from anything which forms an attachment like pleasures to something illegal and horrible.

So having stated his ground, he then says, "And what may be subject to birth, aging, sickness and death, to sorrow and defilement? Wife and children." Remember, he's a bloke. So obviously for a woman it's a husband and children. "Men and women slaves." So remember all ancient societies had slaves in one way or the other. It didn't really move very much in the medieval ages either. The word serf comes from the Latin servus which meant slaves. We now have servants and serving. "Goats and sheep, fowl and pigs, elephants, cattle, horses and mares, gold and silver. These acquisitions are subject to birth, aging, sickness and death, to sorrow and defilement, and one who is tied to these things, infatuated with them and utterly absorbed in them, being himself subject to birth, to sorrow and defilement, seeks what is also subject to birth, aging and death, to sorrow and defilement."

So now, whenever I read something like this out, and of course, in the story of the Buddha leaving the lay life, and the fact that after he was fully liberated, he didn't go back, there's a tendency to think that the Buddha had a real downer on lay life. But remember you have to read it slightly carefully because he doesn't say that. He says "tied to these things, infatuated with them, utterly absorbed in them." That's the problem. Remember the problem is our relationship to the life that we're living, and the usual question that comes up is whether it's better to become a monastic in order to achieve full liberation.

Well, ideally speaking, no. One is either drawn to an institutional form of the spiritual life or a non-institutional form. An institution is defined by its rules and regulations. So there's a lay institution. Before he died, he said he was quite happy because the four assemblies had been established: the monks and the nuns, the lay women and the lay men. He called them the four assemblies. And he felt that these were now grounded and established and he was happy for them. And for each of these he established a certain rule. So the rule of the nuns was slightly different from the monks, and the rule for men and women were generally the same. But even so, as you read the scriptures, there are different advice given to both. But generally speaking, it's the same *sīla*, the same five precepts. So you have to be careful when you read this sort of stuff. The Buddha's not got a downer on the lay life.

So then he says, so what is the noble search? Well, it's someone being himself subject to birth, having understood the danger of what is subject to birth, seeks the unborn supreme security from bondage, *Nibbāna*. Being himself subject to aging, having understood the danger in what is subject to aging, he seeks the unaging supreme security from bondage, *Nibbāna*. And being himself subject to sickness, having understood the danger in what is subject to sickness, he seeks the unailing supreme security from bondage, *Nibbāna*. Being himself subject to death, having understood the danger in what is subject to death, he seeks the deathless supreme security from bondage, *Nibbāna*. Being himself subject to sorrow, having understood the danger in what is subject to sorrow, he seeks the sorrowless supreme security from bondage, *Nibbāna*. And being himself subject to defilement, having understood the danger in what is subject to defilement, he seeks the undefiled supreme security from bondage, *Nibbāna*. This is the noble search.

And often you'll see in the discourses that's exactly how he describes *Nibbāna*. It's unborn. It's unaging. It's unailing. It is the deathless. That's a very regular one, the deathless. It is undefiled and it is sorrowless. There's no *dukkha*, there's no sorrow in *Nibbāna*. So whatever is the cause of our unsatisfaction in today's life, that you will not find in *Nibbāna*.

"Before my enlightenment, while I was still only an unenlightened *bodhisattva*" – remember this word *bodhisattva* means someone seeking, in Theravāda Buddhism it's someone who seeks full self-liberation – "I too, being subject to birth, sought what was also subject to birth." And then he goes on and he says, "And I considered thus: why, being myself subject to birth, do I seek what is also subject to birth? Why, being myself subject to aging, sickness, death, sorrow and defilement, do I seek that also which is subject to aging, sickness, death, sorrow and defilement? Suppose that being myself subject to birth, having understood the danger in what is subject to birth, I seek the

unborn supreme security from *Nibbāna*. Supposing that being myself subject to aging and sickness, death, sorrow and defilement, having understood the danger of what is subject to aging, sickness, death, sorrow and defilement, I seek the unaging, the unailing, deathless, sorrowless and undefiled supreme security from bondage, *Nibbāna*."

Now this word, seeking from bondage, one of the definitions of *Nibbāna*, the words that make it up, is to be unshackled. Unshackled. And one of the things that you're liberated from are the ten fetters, so it's another way of describing *Nibbāna*. And he talks about the taste of *Nibbāna* is what we read in our little verses here. The taste of *Nibbāna* is freedom, is this unshackling freedom.

"So now later while still a black-haired young man endowed with the blessing of youth in the prime of life, though my mother and father wished otherwise and wept with tearful faces, I shaved off my hair and beard, put on the ochre robe and went forth from the home life into homelessness." So his mum and dad were really upset. There, of course, it says ochre robe. See, that again is an anachronism because at the first, he would just do what a lot of the ascetics at that time were doing, which was just picking up these rag robes from the charnel grounds, or any old robe, and just sewing it together in any bits and pieces.

And it's interesting that in the West, we have the example of St. Francis. He did exactly the same. If you ever see his robe in Assisi, it's just a patchwork of sackcloth. Very inspiring. I suppose that's how bad it can get. Wait till the day of floods, wait till the day of doom. We'll all be out there collecting little bits of rags and trying to keep warm.

"Having gone forth, monks, in the search of what is wholesome, seeking the supreme state of sublime peace, I went to Ālāra Kālāma and said to him, 'Friend Kālāma, I want to lead the spiritual life in this dharma and discipline.'" Now, in those times, there were, of course, many teachers who had their own disciples and who taught a particular way of meditation, particular attainments. And here, all of them had a dharma and a discipline. So the dharma is the truth, the practice and the way of the truth. And the discipline was the rules and regulations to support it. And that's exactly what the Buddha said he left when he died. He said, "I've left you the dharma, the theory and the practice, and the vinaya, and the rule, the *sīla*." And that's your institution.

"And Ālāra Kālāma replied, 'The Venerable One may stay here. This dharma is such that a wise man can soon enter upon and dwell in it, realizing for himself through direct knowledge his own teacher's doctrine.' I soon quickly learned the dharma. As far as mere lip reciting and rehearsal of this teaching went, I could speak with knowledge and assurance and I claimed, 'I know and I see.' And there were others who did likewise. And I considered, 'It is not through mere faith alone that Ālāra Kālāma declares, by

realizing it for himself with direct knowledge, I enter upon and dwell in the dharma. Certainly Ālāra Kālāma dwells knowing and seeing this dharma.' Then I went to Ālāra Kālāma and asked him, 'Friend Kālāma, in what way do you declare that by realizing it for yourself with direct knowledge you enter upon and dwell in this dharma?' And he replied, in reply he declared the base of nothingness."

Now, you'll see here a distinction which the Buddha makes between knowing the dharma as an intellectual understanding and actually realizing it for himself. And now he's asking Ālāra Kālāma, "Well, what is your realization?" And he says it's the base of nothingness. In other words, what is your *Nibbāna*? What is the point of this whole practice?

Now, the base of nothingness is what we call one of the *arūpajhānas*. So, the *arūpajhānas*, these absorption states, these ecstasies, are based on something which is created by the mind. So it could be through a mantra, it could be through the breath, it could be through *mettabhāvanā*. But then, and you can go right up with certain, not all of them, like you can't get the fourth *jhāna* with something like *mettā* because it's a feeling. But with the breath you can, you can attain this state of equanimity. Here meaning this absolute stillness of the mind. But then there's a flip, and the mind, as it were, leaves the phenomenal life and enters into this other state called the *arūpajhāna*.

And these *arūpajhānas* have the same quality, but within them there is a different perception, for want of a better word. So the first one is the perception of space and then the perception of consciousness, the perception of nothingness and the perception of neither perception nor not perception. So all these are words you might say, but the point is that in that realm of the mind, completely abstracted from the sensual world and from the perceptions and feelings of the sensual world created by the mind, so the mind has now completely abstracted itself from connection with the world, there is this state called the state of nothingness, which means that there's nothing in it. So it's like being conscious, being fully conscious with nothing in it. As an image of that, being in a completely dark room and yet being awake, being conscious in it. You're not conscious of anything. So that was what he got to, this state of being.

"So I considered, 'Not only Ālāra Kālāma has faith, energy, mindfulness, concentration, wisdom, I too have faith, energy, mindfulness, concentration, wisdom. Suppose I endeavor to realize the dharma that Ālāra Kālāma declares he enters upon and dwells in by realizing it for himself with direct knowledge.'" Now, you'll notice here that even at this stage, before he's fully liberated anything, he's saying that he was aware that you needed these five spiritual faculties: faith, energy, mindfulness, concentration of wisdom.

So the faith, of course, is basic. Bhikkhu Bodhi translates it as faith, but that has all sorts of connotations for us in the West because of belief. It's more like confidence, a complete confidence in the teacher and in what he's suggesting that we can attain. The energy, of course, is the energy to be mindful and to continue with the investigation, or the practice, rather. And then there's the concentration, which is that steadiness of attention. It doesn't wander all over the place. So here already, he's suggesting that he understood what the five faculties, the five spiritual faculties were.

"I soon quickly entered upon and dwelled in that dharma by realizing it for myself with direct knowledge. Then I went to Ālāra Kālāma and asked him, 'Friend Kālāma, is it in this way that you declare that you enter upon and dwell in this dharma by realizing it for yourself with direct knowledge?' 'This is the way, friend.' 'It is in this way, friend, that I also enter upon and dwell in the dharma by realizing it for myself with direct knowledge.' 'It is a gain for us, friend, it is a great gain for us that we have such a venerable one for our fellow monk. So the dharma that I declare I enter upon and dwell in by realizing it for myself with direct knowledge is the dharma that you enter upon and dwell in by realizing it for yourself with direct knowledge. And the dharma that you enter upon and dwell in by realizing it for yourself with direct knowledge is the dharma that I declare I enter upon and dwell in by realizing it for myself with direct knowledge. So you know the dharma that I know and I know the dharma that you know. As I am, so are you. As you are, so I am. Come friend, let us now lead this community together.' Thus Ālāra Kālāma, my teacher, placed me, his pupil, on an equal footing with himself and awarded me the greatest honor."

"But it occurred to me, 'This dharma does not lead to disenchantment, to dispassion, to cessation, to peace, to direct knowledge, to enlightenment, to *Nibbāna*, but only to rebirth in the base of nothingness.' Not being satisfied with that dharma, disappointed with it, I left."

So here, even though he attained this very high state of concentration, very high state of stillness, complete stillness in the base of nothingness, yet he realized that it was only going to produce more rebirth into this state and therefore did not undermine his enchantment with life, his lack of being caught up in life, the dispassion. It wasn't a cessation of suffering. It wasn't going to bring an end to his unsatisfactoriness. It didn't lead to peace. And it wasn't a direct knowledge of enlightenment itself and therefore was not what he was really seeking, which he's already calling *Nibbāna*. Even though if you remember, Ālāra Kālāma also thinks that he's also achieved *Nibbāna*. But he now comes to the conclusion that he hasn't. And he says, "Not being satisfied with that dharma, disappointed with it, I left."

So I shall leave that for this evening. And if you come back next week, there's a very exciting installment when he meets Udaka Rāmaputta. I can only hope that you have been greatly excited and drawn to deeper practice. May you be fully liberated from all suffering and not be confused by different *Nibbānas* sooner rather than later.

Sādhu, sādhu, sādhu.

04 The Essence of the Awakening

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 14 min

In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's own account of his Awakening, focusing on the central discovery of paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination). Drawing from the Mahāparinibbāna Sutta and related texts, he explores how the Buddha's insight into the twelve-link chain of causation—from consciousness and name-form (nāma-rūpa) through to aging and death—revealed both the origin and cessation of dukkha (suffering).

The teaching illuminates the Buddha's methodical investigation: 'When what exists, does aging and death come to be?' This careful attention (yoniso manasikāra) led to the breakthrough wisdom that aging and death arise dependent on birth, birth dependent on becoming, and so forth, tracing back to the mutual dependence of consciousness (viññāṇa) and the psychophysical organism (nāma-rūpa). Bhante explains how we cannot escape 'the bubble of consciousness'—consciousness requires the body-mind complex, while the body-mind complex requires consciousness to be known.

The Buddha's beautiful simile of discovering an ancient path through the forest illustrates how he rediscovered the Noble Eightfold Path (ariya aṭṭhaṅgika magga) that leads to the cessation of this whole mass of suffering. This teaching offers both intellectual understanding and practical insight for anyone walking the path toward Nibbāna, emphasizing that this ancient road remains open to all sincere practitioners today.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened One.

So now the next passage I want to read is the one where he tells us really about what constitutes his awakening, or at least the main thrust of his awakening we can say:

"Monks, before my enlightenment, while I was still a Bodhisattva, not yet fully enlightened, it occurred to me: 'Alas, this world has fallen into trouble, in that it is born, ages and dies, it passes away and is reborn, yet it does not understand the escape from this suffering, headed by aging and death. When now will an escape be discerned from this suffering, headed by aging and death?'"

So this is an old theme, isn't it? This goes back really to that youthful time when he wakes up to the existential problems of life. But this seems to tell us that it was on his mind really, even when he was becoming ascetic. This is all before he became liberated.

"And then it occurred to me, when what exists, does aging and death come to be? By what is aging and death conditioned? Then through careful attention, there took place in me a breakthrough by wisdom: When there is birth, aging and death comes to be. Aging and death has birth as its condition."

It seems pretty obvious really, doesn't it? The scriptures make it a huge breakthrough. But he says, well, what is the primary condition for aging and death? Well, it's birth. So we have to be a little patient because he now goes deeper, of course. So that was his first thought. Well, you've got to start from somewhere. So how is it I'm growing old and having to die? Well, it's because I was born. That's pretty straightforward.

"Then, monks, it occurred to me, when what exists, does birth come to be, existence come to be, clinging, craving, feeling, contact, the six sense bases, name and form... by what is name and form conditioned? Then through careful attention there took place in me a breakthrough by wisdom: When there is consciousness, name and form comes to be. Name and form has consciousness as its condition."

So here we're running through dependent origination, usual stuff. So these all refer back to themselves. Clinging is dependent on existence, craving dependent on clinging, feeling... it's going back on itself, right? But then he comes to this point of consciousness, name and form. Name and form is really the psychophysical organism. Remember that when he talks about form, at its most subtle level, it's the point where mind and matter meet. So in other words, we can't know a fingernail. You can't be in a fingernail. You can only know it by the sense of touch. So that's at its more subtle level. So he's come now to this point about consciousness.

"Then, monks, it occurred to me, when what exists does consciousness come to be? By what is consciousness conditioned? Then, monks, through careful attention," so this is the *vipassanā*, "there took place in me a breakthrough of wisdom: When there is name-form, consciousness comes to be. Consciousness has name-form as its condition."

So without the psychophysical organism there can't be consciousness, basically.

"But then it occurred to me, this consciousness turns back. It does not go further than name form. It is to this extent that one may be born and age and die, pass away and be reborn. That is, when there is consciousness with name and form as its condition, and name and form with consciousness as its condition. When name and form is

conditioned, the six sense bases; with the six sense bases as conditioned, contact; and so on, the whole path of dependent origination, such is the origin of the whole mass of suffering."

So, he's taken us back to this point of consciousness. Now that consciousness is disputed a little bit. It's an act of knowing. If there wasn't consciousness, there'd be just an automaton, wouldn't there? Just a machine. There's something that knows. But it can only know what it knows through the psychophysical organism. And the psychophysical organism is unknowable without consciousness. So if you took away the psychophysical organism how could consciousness of anything arise? If you took away consciousness how could the knowing, how could you know anything about the psychophysical organism? So these two rest against each other, the one arising completely dependent on the other. That's where the origination starts and ends. You can't go beyond that. You can't go beyond the bubble of your consciousness. Basically what he's saying. You can't get outside the bubble of your consciousness. And you can't get outside the bubble of your psychophysical organism. That's it.

Then he says, "Origination, origination. Thus monks, in regard to things unheard before, there arose in me vision, knowledge, wisdom, penetration and light." So these are just synonyms for enlightenment, awakening, understanding. And then of course he goes back on it. So now he's understood how we come to exist, how we go through this process of becoming. So now of course he goes back on that.

"So when what does not exist does aging and death not come to be? With the cessation of what does the cessation of aging and death come about? Then monks, through careful attention, there took place in me a breakthrough by wisdom: when there's no birth, aging and death does not come to be, and with cessation of birth comes cessation of aging and death."

So then, the process of cessation, right? Without the psychophysical organism, you can't have the sixth sense basis. You can't have contact, you can't have feeling, you can't have craving, so on, so on.

"And then it occurred to me, when what does not exist, does consciousness come to be? When what does not exist, does consciousness not come to be? With the cessation of what, does the cessation of consciousness come to be? Then monks, through careful attention, there took place in me this breakthrough by wisdom: When there's no name and form, psychophysical organism, consciousness does not come to be. With the cessation of name and form comes the cessation of consciousness."

So now he says, "This occurred to me, I have discovered this path to enlightenment. That is, with the cessation of name and form comes cessation of consciousness. With the cessation of consciousness comes the cessation of name and form. And with the cessation of name and form, there comes the cessation of the six bases, and through the six bases, contact, and so on and so forth. Such is the cessation of this whole mass of suffering. Cessation, cessation, thus monks, in regard to things unheard of before, there arose in me vision, knowledge, wisdom, penetration, and light."

That's why here we chant this dependent origination because it's so core to his understanding of how everything happens and everything disappears. And because he saw that, he saw there was nothing in it that was substantial. All this is not self, all this also doesn't have any substance to it. And it's in constant motion, you're constantly turning that wheel, going through that process.

And then as usual he gives us an image: "Suppose a man wandering through a forest would see an ancient path, an ancient road travelled upon by people in the past. He would follow it and would see an ancient city, an ancient capital that had been inhabited by people in the past, with parks and groves, ponds and ramparts, a delightful place. Then the man would inform the king or his royal minister: 'Sire, know that while wandering through the forest I saw an ancient path, an ancient road, travelled upon by people in the past. I followed it and saw an ancient city, an ancient capital that had been inhabited by people in the past, with parks, groves, ponds and ramparts, a delightful place. Renovate that city, sire.' Then the king or the royal minister would renovate that city. And sometime later that city would become successful and prosperous, well populated, filled with people, attained to growth and expansion."

"So too, monks, I saw the ancient path, the ancient road travelled by the perfectly enlightened ones of the past. And what is that ancient path, that ancient road? It is just this Noble Eightfold Path, that is, right view, right intention, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness and right concentration. I followed that path and by doing so I have directly known aging and death, its origin, its cessation and the way leading to its cessation. And I've directly known birth and existence," I always prefer the word becoming, frankly, "clinging, craving, feeling, contact, the six sense bases, name and form, consciousness, volitional formations," that's your *saṅkhāra*, "their origin, their cessation, and the way leading to their cessation. Having directly known them, I have explained them to the monks, to the nuns, to male lay followers and the female lay followers. This spiritual life, monks, has become successful and prosperous, extended, popular, widespread, well-proclaimed among the *devas* and humans."

I can only hope that this little reading and small explanation will drive you swiftly along the road, travelling to *Nibbāna*, sooner rather than later.

Sādhu, sādhu, sādhu.

Anusaya - Latent Tendencies

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 8 min

In this DhammaBytes talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the concept of anusaya - latent tendencies or predispositions that lie dormant in our psychic system, ready to manifest when conditions arise. Drawing from early Buddhist scriptures through to the Abhidhamma, he explores how these seven fundamental tendencies evolved in the Buddha's teaching: sensual lust, attachment to existence (bhava), aversion, conceit, wrong views, doubt, and ignorance.

Using the compelling analogy of a computer's latent potential, Bhante explains how these anusaya exist not as stored memories but as pure potentiality - conditioned by past saṅkhāra (volitional formations) yet having no substantial existence until activated. He maps their psychological structure, showing how ignorance forms the foundation, branching into conceit and wrong views, which then manifest as the three primary responses: greed (wanting pleasure and becoming), aversion (not wanting), and confusion (doubt).

This teaching offers profound insight into how our conditioned responses arise and why insight meditation is essential for liberation. As Bhante emphasizes, until these latent tendencies are eradicated through wisdom, unwholesome actions will continue to arise. The talk connects ancient Buddhist psychology with modern understanding of subconscious conditioning, showing how paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination) can be broken at the crucial point of ignorance through vipassanā practice.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened.

So the word tonight is *Anusaya*, A-N-U-S-A-Y-A. And the translation in the Pali text dictionary is a bent, a proclivity, latent tendency and predisposition. And the one that really interests me is this translation of latent tendency. But we'll come to that in a minute.

In the early scriptures, the Buddha only talks about *anusaya*. He doesn't actually say what they are. It's just latent tendencies. We've all got latent tendencies. But later on, in the scriptures, a different level of the scriptures, perhaps as his teaching matures, things are added to this latent tendency. Pride, doubt, ignorance, lust, and so on. And in the end, in the Abhidhamma, they list it as seven.

So the first one, well, the way they list it is sensual lust. I think it's probably better, even though it says *kāmarāga*, it does mean body lust, but anyway. Attachment to existence, aversion, conceit, wrong views, doubt, and ignorance. So none of them have come as a big surprise, eh?

Now, to try and make sense of this list... It seems to me that you've got to just turn the order around a bit for some reason. If we take ignorance as a basic platform, as a latent tendency in the sense of not knowing, then you immediately enter into the delusion on the one side of wrong views and on the other side of self, which expresses itself as conceit. So it's, I have this view, I'm right and everybody else is wrong. That's your basic position.

And from there, you fork into three, which relates to the way that the self relates to the world. Sensual pleasure and becoming. So that's to do with greed and acquisitiveness. Then you've got the aversion, so that's the negative side, not wanting. And then the doubt, which is the befuddlement that comes because of this basic ignorance. So that's your sort of latent dispositions.

Now, these latent dispositions, what... It can't be the fact that, at least as I understand it, the Buddha didn't teach that we had some sort of store memory that you pick books off, like a library or something. It's more like, and that's why I like this word, latent tendency, some sort of predisposition, but it doesn't actually have any actuality.

And I think one of the best analogies is of a computer really because if you take metaphor to a logical end it's normally a sign of madness so it only works at certain levels so when we shut the computer down and unplug it and all that it's dead it's not but we know it's got this tremendous latent ability and then when you plug it in You can connect to the whole worldwide web, for heaven's sake. I mean, that's the potential of it. But when it's unplugged, it remains there just as purely latent.

So all these conditionings, see the other word it uses, predisposition, and that links us with these *saṅkhāras*, these volitional conditionings. So they're lying there in wait, you might say, but in this sort of non-existent form. But it's there within the psychic system, you could say. So something happens and they're there to be pulled out.

And that I think connects rather nicely with our modern psychology about subliminal stuff and subconscious stuff. Although you do get the feeling from Freudian stuff and all that, that's already there as it were. It's in a sort of stored memory. But I think this is slightly more subtle in the sense that every moment comes to an end completely. It's a radical impermanence. So you can't hold anything, and yet there's the potential. So it's one of these little mysteries, really.

So really, without going into all these different things more deeply, those are your seven latent tendencies. Ignorance, the not knowing, which forks into this I am conceit with wrong view. And that again forks into these three avenues, the sensual pleasure, the becoming...

There's always that. There's the *bhavataṇhā*. When he describes *dukkha* as such, it's attachment to pleasure, the desire to keep becoming, becoming a self, in other words, keep being reborn as me. And the opposite is *vibhava*, which is the desire to put an end to that. And that comes into the other fork, the aversion, not wanting. It comes in obvious forms of not wanting something and not wanting to live. And the third one is this doubt which comes from befuddlement, which comes from confusion that arises out of this self.

So those are your seven *anusaya*. And in a sense, if you think about it, that is the platform out of which we then create the world. We create these *saṅkhāras*, create these volitional conditionings.

So underneath it, there is that not knowing. It's creating a certain disposition, which then manifests a disposition of I am with a view, then manifests as this more obvious psychological thing of wanting, not wanting, being confused. And then as something happens to us in daily life, It picks up on one of these and then you suddenly find yourself being greedy or being hateful or being confused. And that's basically, I think, how it is.

So these *anusaya*, you could look at them as the potential which has been created from past actions that we call these *saṅkhāras*, volitional conditioning. So these volitional conditionings become, sink, as it were, into this level of sheer potential. And I think that's what the Buddha is saying.

And the final thing is that until these *anusaya* are actually eradicated from the system, there's no way our unwholesome actions can stop. And the only way you can undermine them is through insight, which breaks the delusion. That's why in dependent origination the real break is at that point of ignorance.

So that brings to an end my little homily on the Anusaya. I can only hope it has been of some benefit. May you be liberated from all your Anusaya sooner rather than later.

Hetu — The Unwholesome Roots

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 10 min

In this DhammaBytes talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Pali term 'hetu' (root) and the three unwholesome roots that drive our suffering: lobha (greed/acquisitiveness), dosa (aversion), and moha (delusion). He reveals how these roots function as Buddhism's depth psychology, showing how our fundamental delusion of selfhood creates the basic relationship of 'this is me and mine' that separates us from the world.

Bhante explains how this mistaken identity generates constant anxiety about control, leading to the twin impulses of grasping what we want and pushing away what threatens us. He distinguishes between avijjā (not-knowing) and moha (delusion), showing how our innocent not-knowing becomes the active delusion that we are separate psychophysical beings. Through practical examples like struggling with a stubborn gate, he demonstrates how these roots manifest in everyday moments.

The talk emphasizes how vipassanā practice helps us recognize these deeply conditioned patterns, creating space between awareness and reactive impulses. Bhante addresses the fear that arises when we challenge our fundamental assumptions about selfhood, explaining how becoming comfortable with 'don't know' mind is essential for liberation. This foundational teaching connects to the broader framework of paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), offering practitioners insight into the psychological mechanisms that perpetuate dukkha and the path to freedom.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

The word I'd like to tackle this evening is *hetu*. It means root—the roots of our suffering. It's really what you would call these days our depth psychology. And it splits into three roots, which won't come as a surprise to you: greed, hatred and delusion.

The word for greed is *lobha*. Most of you would know perhaps the word *taṇhā*, which means desire. But *lobha* is that attitude that's translated as greed, though I think it's much better to understand it as acquisitiveness. The second one is *dosa*, which means aversion, not wanting. And the third one, *moha*, is delusion.

Now we've come across the word *avijjā*, which means ignorance. It's translated as ignorance, but actually it's far better translated in a very neutral sense of just not knowing. And then we make this mistake, and that mistake we call our delusions.

So the mistake, of course, is to believe ourselves to be phenomenal psychophysical organisms, human beings—which is understandable. I mean, our consciousness moves into the cellular life of the fetus, and when it's born, what does it know, apart from what it's experiencing? You can't expect anything else except for that consciousness to say, well, this is what I am. Not actually saying it intellectually, but just a direct relationship with what it experiences as being me. And this is what we call the self.

So the self isn't a thing, it's not an object, it's a relationship. It's a relationship we have to what we experience: this is me or mine. So there's your basic position in the world which we call delusive, a delusion, *moha*. This is me and these things are mine. So identity and possessions.

Now you can see that once you've established that relationship with the world, there's a whole load of things which aren't me, aren't mine. And that's where the barrier comes. Underlying, remember, the sense of self—and this is really quite an important understanding—is that the self actually in itself, or we in ourselves, never truly believe in the self itself. And the way that expresses itself is through a constant anxiety of being in control of our lives, of our things and so on.

If the self were actually rock hard, if it were a real rock hard self, which was immutable and eternal, then obviously that wouldn't happen. It's just that there's somewhere inside us that knows that this relationship doesn't quite fit, isn't quite right. And so we're constantly trying to acquire the future. And that's what *lobha* means in its deepest sense. We're trying to control the future.

And to do that, you've got to, of course, get rid of anything that upsets your presumed future. So your attitude, our attitude to life, is always this trying to make sure that things are going to go the way I want them to. And if anything gets in the way then I want to get rid of it. Simple as that. And it comes down into the moment as holding on to what we have and defending it from the enemy. And the enemy is simply all those who want what we have. Very simple.

So once we recognize that mechanism, and we know it's coming from this deeper delusion, this deeper mistake we've made of presuming that this is what we are, then our challenge is to be aware of that. I mean, that's what the *vipassanā* is about. It's leading us to the awareness of every time the mind is holding on to something or pushing

something away. And what we find is that just to be aware of it allows us just a small space of freedom. And the freedom is not to act according to those impulses. That's where the liberation is.

But these roots—they're roots, they're deep within our psychology—are so deeply rooted that we're not aware of how afraid we are of letting go, so afraid of just living in the moment and making the decisions in the moment with the faith that things evolve. And if things happen that we don't want to happen, then that's also part of our evolution. We can't stop things happening which are against us, because we live in a world that we can't control.

So the trick is to be aware of how the mind is constantly wanting to control. Therefore it doesn't listen, it doesn't really see the way things are, the way things really are, and it constantly finds itself in this little conflict, this conflict with the world as it is.

Even a simple thing like opening the gate. I was out there the other day, and for some reason it wouldn't open. So I found myself getting irritated with it. The gate should open when I want it to open, in the way that I want it to open. It just refused to do so. Even the slightest things, you'll catch the irritation, you'll catch the grabbing, you'll catch the desire.

And the more we don't act on those impulses, the more we're challenging that deep delusion that we have of who we are. And the more we do that, the more we come across this anxiety, this deep-seated fear. And it's not a place we like to be. It's not a place we like to be at all. We don't like to be in a state of don't know. And it's getting used to that. It's getting used to the fear that surrounds that, the anxiety that surrounds that.

And once we're used to those feelings and how it feels to be like that, then we've already distanced from it. And what we realize has been a great prevention for us to actually dig deep is the fear of that fear, the fear of that anxiety. We just bounce off it, pull off it quick. And by making fear itself an object and getting used to the feelings of fear, used to the feelings of anxiety, this fear of it disappears, or begins to disappear, or at least diminishes.

And of course, once we lose the fear of fear, what is there to frighten us? So this is the Buddha's deep psychology, really. From then on, it moves into how it manifests through daily life through the dependent wheel of origination.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated in this very lifetime, sooner rather than later.

Sīla - Good Conduct

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 9 min

In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines sīla, the Pali term for ethical conduct that forms the first pillar of the Buddha's threefold training (sīla-samādhī-paññā). He traces how unethical behavior arises from our fundamental delusion about who we are and our attachment-driven attempts to find happiness in the world through manipulation and control.

Rather than mere rules or commandments, the Five Precepts (sikkhāpada) are presented as a path of training that begins with obvious ethical guidelines—like not harming living beings—and refines into subtle aspects of compassionate living. Bhante explains how ethical behavior naturally develops alongside wisdom, creating a systemic transformation where harmful tendencies like cruelty, theft, and dishonesty evolve into their positive counterparts: compassion, generosity, and truthfulness.

The talk emphasizes how vipassanā practice supports this transformation by helping us recognize conditioning without judgment, allowing unethical patterns to naturally atrophy when we stop empowering them. This process of refinement extends to the smallest details of daily conduct, cultivating a gentle, courteous way of being that reflects our growing wisdom and compassion. Essential listening for understanding how ethical conduct forms the foundation of Buddhist practice and awakening.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

The word I'd like to look at this evening is the word *sīla*. It translates as morality, ethical behaviour. And it always comes first in the teachings. It's always *sīla-samādhī-paññā*. It's always ethical behaviour, concentration, and then wisdom.

To understand that, I have to go back to the beginnings as to why unethical behaviour happens. And it goes back to that point where we make a mistake. And this mistake of who we are, or what we are, manifests in a relationship of attachment to the world, or better, seeking happiness in the world. That's how the Buddha would put it, seeking happiness here and there. And that sort of relationship creates conflict. So we're always trying to manipulate the world and other people to make ourselves happy. And if they don't, we tend to want to just get rid of them. So you can see how from that

basic mechanism, it's very easy to begin to behave in a way which is harmful. And that would be the definition of something which is not ethical. If it does harm to others or to ourselves, then it's unethical.

The five precepts — that's how we translate it, but the actual word *sikkhāpada* is a path of training. They're not actually commandments as such. Ethical behaviour is a measure of our delusion or wisdom. When you realize that you start at the basis of your behaviour, then that's actually where your training is.

Take something, the first one that we take, which is pretty straightforward, not to harm or kill any living being. So we start there. I think most of us have probably given that up. But then there's a more subtle way of harming living beings in perhaps ways that we weren't particularly aware of, like not putting food out for the birds in the mid-winter. There's all sorts of little ways where our lack of interconnectedness manifests in ourselves as callousness.

So it becomes very fine, and then once we begin to see where that is, then the thing begins to flip. And just as we might have been cruel towards animals, that moves over towards compassion. Just as we were perhaps once thieving from banks and not sharing things with people, it moves towards generosity. All these things, like not being truthful, even to the slight point of exaggeration, it moves towards truthfulness. So it's not as though you move towards a place which is not ethical, you move towards the more positive places.

Now that movement doesn't come without wisdom, and that's the important thing to realize. So the approach to our happiness, to our ultimate happiness, has to have this sort of two-pronged approach. It's not only the growth of wisdom, it's not only the growth of understanding, but the change in behaviour. So the whole thing has to be systemic. And that's what *sīla* is pointing to.

And it's there, of course, within the Eightfold Path. So, with the right understanding, there's a change in the heart. And that's the second of the path, the right attitude. From that is right speech, right action, and eventually right livelihood. So it's a systemic process.

Now, some would say it happens naturally with the meditation, and I think that's true. But it's also good just to egg it along a bit, just to keep pushing it a wee bit and just to notice how sometimes our behaviour upsets people. Of course, it might be their problem, not yours, but even so, it's that ability to be sensitive to our relationships to people, which actually makes us more aware of intentions that we weren't perhaps particularly aware of.

One obvious thing is when we want to help somebody. Whether we like it or not, there's always that sort of self-regard within it, a certain conceit that needs to be thanked, that needs to be acknowledged, that needs to be appreciated. And if the person whom you've just given all your money to doesn't say thank you, you feel very upset. It's a case of being aware of those things.

And what our *vipassanā* practice is telling us is not to get judgmental about it, it's just a conditioning. It's no good then berating ourselves and judging ourselves as evil. It's a recognition of, that's a conditioning, and all I have to do is be aware of it and not empower it. It's as simple as that. And as we stop empowering those behaviours that we see are not ethical, not *sīla*, they atrophy, they just die away. You don't have to do anything. That's the simplicity of the path.

And then, of course, there's a refinement of that until you're really talking about even small movements like making a noise when you're eating. It can get extremely fine about your behaviour and about a certain delicacy, a certain courtesy. It moves towards a real gentle way of being in the world. Stabbing the plate with our knives and forks. Have compassion on the plate. Never meant any harm. Just the way we brush our teeth, gently. Just getting it over with. Things like that. So it moves us towards a real refinement of behaviour. And that's really that process of *sīla* as a show of how wise and gentle, compassionate we can become. So *sīla* is really quite a basic teaching.

When Buddhism first began as a practice in the 60s and 70s and 80s, people were very afraid to talk about *sīla*, talk about behaviour, especially sexual behaviour because it was meant to be free and easy. But eventually it affects the whole way that you treat human beings. And you go back to that golden rule, which began in that axial age with the Buddha, Lao Tzu, Socrates, Jeremiah, all these people, and it was just that one, you can reduce it all to that one phrase, do unto others as you would have them do unto you. Not do unto others before they do unto you. We have to abandon that.

So I hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated sooner rather than later.

01. Dāna - Generosity

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 13 min

In this opening talk on the ten pāramī (perfections), Bhante Bodhidhamma explores dāna (generosity) as the foundational virtue in the Buddha's gradual teaching method. He explains why the Buddha always began teaching laypeople with generosity before moving to morality, rebirth, and the Four Noble Truths.

The talk examines three essential conditions for wholesome giving: the wealth or gift must be earned virtuously, the amount must be appropriate and wise, and the receiver must be worthy of the gift. Bhante addresses the subtle psychological dynamics of giving, including how unconscious expectations and the desire to 'feel good' can undermine pure generosity.

Drawing on practical examples from daily life, he explores how mindfulness can reveal our hidden motivations and how awareness of unwholesome intentions actually disempowers them. The discussion includes guidance on developing spontaneous generosity through practice, distinguishing this from impulsive giving that often leads to regret. This foundational teaching provides essential understanding for both meditation practice and ethical conduct in daily life.

Namo tassa bhagavato harahato samma sambudassam Namō tassa bhagavato harahato samma sambudassam Namō tassa bhagavato harahato samma sambudassam

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened One.

I'm going to start on the ten perfections. I'll just run through them quickly: generosity, morality, renunciation, wisdom, energy, patience, truthfulness, resolution, loving-kindness and equanimity. We won't do them all tonight. We'll just do the *dāna*, which is generosity.

Dāna is the core virtue for the Buddha because whenever he's teaching laypeople he always starts with *dāna*, generosity. The reason is that you can be completely immoral and yet be generous. So a thief can be very generous even if it's with your money. It's like a quality that can exist prior to a good morality. Then he always talks about morality, then he goes on to rebirth, and then finally when he feels that the audience is open enough, he hits them with the Four Noble Truths. So he has his way of gradual teaching.

By the way, when you hear *dāna* within Buddhist company, they're normally referring to giving food to monks, because when they say they're giving dana, that's what they're normally referring to.

The whole point about generosity, of course, is that it undermines selfishness. Our society is particularly selfish, I think, compared to others. That's the enemy of generosity: selfishness. The more subtle enemy, of course, is the feeling of doing it for feeling good, and we'll come to that in a minute.

Now, the scriptures talk about three conditions for a wholesome giving. If you're offering wealth, if you're offering money as a donation, it has to be earned virtuously. It's interesting, isn't it? If you just thieved it from the bank... It's like if people win on the lottery. Now, it's no big evil thing to win some money in the lottery, but it's still based on taking money from other people. Even though the other people have gladly put their money in, it's still a slightly off way of earning money. Gambling is a form of gambling. Even if you were to give that money, there would be just that little bit of unwholesomeness about it. In fact, I know of one person who won a lot of money. He was a Muslim and he offered it to his mosque. They wouldn't receive it. They wouldn't take it.

The gift itself, like the amount you give, has to be appropriate, has to be wise. Somebody was telling me just now that somebody's bought their daughter, I think she's 12 years old, a 500-pound watch. It's pretty much, isn't it? What does it do to a kid of that age? So you've got to be wise about the amount you give.

And the receiver themselves has to be worthy of your gift. They have to be worthy of it. So I mean, it's no good giving month tickets to Las Vegas. It wouldn't be right. And when people ask you for money on the streets, you have to be careful. I always... you know that they're either going to use it for drugs or for drink, so it's one of those little dodgy things. I mean, if you say well look I'll buy you a hamburger and they say well I don't want to eat and they just want your money for a bit more drink... In fact there was once in London and this young guy came up to me and said, can you give me some, can you help me? I said why do you want it? He said well I want to buy some hash. I said I don't want to do that. He said oh come on, I'm being truthful. I thought, well... he thought because he was being truthful therefore he was worthy of a gift. It's funny.

It's the same when you offer to do something for somebody. So you're offering time in that case, in which case you have to be careful of your motives. Often we think we're doing something out of a pure heart but there are subliminal unconscious conditions that we put on things. You have to be quite open to any negative feelings. Now, remember that if you're offering to do something for somebody and you're aware of these little things like, well, they might give me some money when I'm finished... remember that to

be aware of it is not to be dominated by it. So you can still be aware of that unwholesome thought and then determine that you're going to do it for wholesome reasons. Because there's an intention there, it's not activated. When it's subliminal, when it's unconscious, it can have an effect on what we're doing. And then you know that afterwards when they don't give you anything and you're upset. So then you know that there's been some sort of subliminal reason for doing something. Our awareness, our mindfulness puts us in contact with these little subterranean desires.

And of course what you're doing is worthy. It's no good saying to the judge, I was only helping him rob the bank. I didn't want any money. The act itself has to be virtuous, has to be wholesome. And again, the person has to be worthy of the gift. You have to feel they're worthy of it. Often when you have a next-door neighbor who's elderly, and they want a bit of help, so obviously that's... But I remember I used to visit a friend of mine. Every time you turned up, they'd say, oh, I'm glad you've come. Can you help me do this? And after a while you think, well, I've got to stop going, frankly. I'm being a bit abused now.

So those qualities about the virtue of your giving, the purpose of your giving, what it is you're actually giving and the virtue of the person who is receiving your gift, that makes the perfect gift.

When you make an offering often we do it quite impulsively and then often we regret what we've given or what we've done. If we can get into the habit of just stopping for a moment and just saying, well, I'll think about it or I'll just consider that for a minute and just get the right attitude going... When you actually give something or decide to do something for somebody, just make sure that you've actually phrased it within yourself to make that offering pure. You say something like, well, I'm giving this without any hope of return, or I'm doing this... That doesn't stop you doing things, offering things which aren't, shall we say, pure generosity. I mean, at Christmas you give presents and you get one back. That's all right. It's a social interaction. It's not evil to do that. It's just that it's not coming from the pure heart.

And remember that if you do give something, or you do something for somebody, and then you get this little voice come back saying, truly you are a most generous person, you're quite extraordinary, your virtue is above everybody else... So when you hear that little voice, you point to it and say, ah, I see you, Mara, the evil one, but it didn't actually affect my action, so therefore it didn't have the effect it would normally have of making what we do a little selfish. So it's seeing our unwholesome intentions which disempowers them. It's when we don't see them that they creep up behind us and then we realize afterwards that there have been unwholesome intentions.

And I suppose it's a paradox when you think that the more you give with that way, the more joyful you feel. But it's because we can rejoice in another person's joy. That's why we feel joyful when we help somebody. And then, of course, the mistake arises. You start doing it in order to feel good. See? And the whole thing... So let's be careful. Mara's tricky.

And the last thing is about spontaneity. Spontaneity doesn't arrive spontaneously. You've got to work at it. So if you think of sports people... I mean, like a tennis player, they're just acting, you can't even call it a reaction really. I mean, they're totally in the game, with the game, acting spontaneously. But they've done hours of practice. So at first it might seem that this is forced, contrived. And you're sort of playing this game of saying, well, why am I doing that? Okay, here I give with the fullness of my heart. But it's through the practice of that, that eventually you find yourself doing things spontaneously. Which is slightly different from doing something impulsively from old conditionings, which you normally tend to regret.

So if you're like me, you tend to say yes too quickly. You do the yes, and then you think, I don't want to do that. What did I say that for? So it's getting out of that habit. And it's not insulting to somebody to say, well, hold on, I'll have to think about that. It just gives you a bit of a space to make the right intention, and then there's no regrets.

So, just remember those three factors, just to end off with that. What is your intention? Is the gift worthy? Is it coming from a worthy place? And is the person you're helping, in some way or other, worthy of the gift? So, that's why they say the most perfect of all gifts is to give it to somebody who's fully enlightened. If you put an advert in the paper and say, is anybody fully enlightened because I want to make this perfect gift? Because in doing it with a perfect heart and giving exactly what the person wants, and this person is very worthy of your gift, because they've perfected the path, and through that example they spread merit into the world.

Merit is a funny way of translating *puñña*. I found a very good translation for it. It's goodness power. Goodness power. I thought it was a really good translation.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be fully liberated from all insidious intentions sooner rather than later.

02. Sīla: Virtuous Conduct

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 13 min

In this second talk on the pāramīs (perfections), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines sīla—virtuous conduct that helps us reach 'the other shore' of Nibbāna. He explains how sīla encompasses wholesome bodily actions, speech, and livelihood, beginning with the foundational Pañcasīla (Five Precepts) that form the basic ethical platform for all practitioners.

The talk traces the progressive refinement of ethical conduct from negative prohibitions to positive transformations: from not killing to actively protecting life, from not stealing to generous giving, from sexual restraint to the skillful sublimation of energy. Bhante explores the eight precepts (Aṭṭhasīla) taken by laypeople on observance days, the ten precepts of novice monastics (sāmaṇera), and the 227 rules of fully ordained monks.

Rather than rigid commandments, these training rules (sikkhāpada) are presented as practical tools for investigating our attachments and developing wisdom. Sīla reflects our understanding—it's not abstract knowledge but a wise way of relating to the world through right speech, right action, and right livelihood. The talk concludes with practical advice for daily ethical reflection, reviewing our kusala (wholesome) and akusala (unwholesome) actions as part of spiritual development.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened.

So continuing with these perfections, and remember that's an odd sort of translation—it's those virtues, actions that we need to arrive at the other shore. That's what *pāramī* means, the other shore. It's just the Buddha's way of talking about Nibbāna, it's that other place, transcendent place.

And what he says is, when he's asked the question, or when he asks the question, what is karmically wholesome morality? It is wholesome bodily actions, wholesome verbal actions and purity of livelihood. So when we talk about *sīla*, morality, it really is confined to outward actions, to the way we affect the world through our actions, our speech, and through our livelihood.

It starts with the negative propositions. So there are various levels. The first one is this five, the *Pañcasīla*, the five *sikkhāpada*, which means root training rules. And that's what we chant in the evening. So they're pretty basic to any society. We're not going to kill each other, kill beings in that sense, but to kill other human beings. And we're not going to steal, take what is not freely given. Not misuse our sexual powers. Not to use wrong speech. That's divided into both telling lies and lying, slanderous speech, doing people down, gossip, and coarse speech—there's one other. It'll come to me. So, and then finally, of course, intoxicants. Nothing that's going to affect our consciousness.

So those are your five basic not-to-dos. And obviously, once we stop behaving like that, then it becomes more and more refined. So whereas it's not killing human beings, we don't want to harm any living beings. So there's a refinement of that. And then of course it transforms. So from not wanting to harm any living beings, we want to protect them. So that's the process, starting with that very negative formulation, and we end up with a very positive one.

So it's the same with taking what is not freely given. So from gross thieving from the banks and that, to being careful even with simple things like not taking pens from work. One gets very sensitive about that. But of course what one moves towards is generosity, giving away.

Sexual energy and that is refined in the sense that it moves from only using that energy within a skillful relationship, a loving relationship. And of course if you're not in relationship then it moves you towards celibacy. And celibacy is not simply—it's not a denial of sexual energy, it's a transformation of it, it's a sublimation of it. Sublimation is not a word we come across these days, because I think we get confused about suppressing. But suppressing something is a negative thing. It's about pushing something away out of negativity or fear.

But sublimating is seeing that actually what there is is just energy and through our conditioning we've channelled it in certain areas. And if we've channelled it into our sexual appetite, then it's a case of, as it were, letting that energy move over towards something more skillful, if we can't use our energy as a sexual energy. It's not stuck there. So that's a refinement of that energy.

When it comes to speech, the speech moves from coarse speech—that was the one I missed out—coarse speech, we move towards truthfulness, kindly speech, and speech at an appropriate time. So often we're being truthful, we're being kind, but we're not quite choosing the right situation to say what we want to say, and it causes upset, when if we had just waited for the opportunity, then we would have been able to have said something to help a situation.

So you've got these refinements. And the last one is intoxication. So basically in the spiritual life, you want to keep your consciousness clear. You want to keep it awake. So putting anything into consciousness is going to distort it. It's exactly what you don't want to do. And the refinement of it is this moment-to-moment awareness. That's what we're moving towards.

So those, you might say, are your basic platform of practice. And then the Buddha gives an opportunity to lay people to, as we say, turn the screw a bit on the full moon days. That's when, in Theravada Buddhist countries, the person might practice the eight *sīla*, the eight *sikkhāpada*, the eight rules of training.

So on a full moon day or a new moon day, you might find that people go to the local monastery and there they take slightly monastic vows in the sense that they don't eat after lunch, they don't worry about entertainment, they let go of radio, TV, iPods, all that sort of stuff. They don't worry about self-beautification, cosmetics, jewellery, all that sort of stuff. And if they're staying overnight they're just happy with just a straightforward bed, abandoning luxurious beds.

So those training rules are, as it were, finding out where your attachments are. That's what they're about. And by doing that, of course, you've got something to work with because it's attachments that we have to undermine.

Then there's the entrance into the order, what we call the *sāmaṇera*. So that moves into ten precepts. And it's the same as the eight, except the bit about entertainment and beautification are made into two. But added to that is this business of not touching money, not using money. So you're retreating from the world, from the world of enticement, once you've got no money, that's it.

And then finally when you join the order, there's a 227—it leaps, it's a quantum leap into 227. And again the whole idea of the rules is that part of it is based on that moral rule of not to harm living beings and so on, but the other side of it are just institutional rules which are meant to help the monastic remain more and more mindful.

So clothes for instance—it never occurs to me to get up in the morning and think I shall wear blue today. It's just this is it, I've just got these robes and that's the end of it. And it stops any worry or concern about how you look or how you should look, because you all look the same. The whole idea is to draw a line as to what it is you want to get involved with when it comes to the world.

Food—we only eat what we are given, so we don't choose what to eat. So those are refinements in terms of letting go of wants, the ordinary wants of life.

And a lot of this the layperson can also practice, just reducing the amount of—I mean, looking at your wardrobe and just asking, do I need all this stuff, how many pairs of shoes do you need. So that's how the morality in Buddha's understanding works because morality is the measure of wisdom or lack of it. So wisdom isn't something abstract. Wisdom is a way of relating to the world. It's not a knowledge, it's a relationship, a wise relationship. And this mirrors itself in our attitudes and this goes outwards into the world in right speech, right action and then right livelihood.

So this right livelihood, for instance—the worst of course is you don't want to get involved in the traffic of arms and human beings, flesh, intoxicants and arms. So once you're not involved in that, really any other form of livelihood can be taken as being something wholesome and to be used as a spiritual practice. That's what you do with your energy into society. And it's finding ways of making our livelihood and our ordinary daily lives work for us towards the spiritual end. So we have to have the principles right. So basically we're developing the good heart. Anything that we do with a good heart, from putting our attention and care into things, becomes a spiritual path, just naturally.

So that's what *sīla* means in the Buddha's practice, in the Buddha's understanding. Morality, we translate it as morality or ethics, behaviour, moral behaviour. And he just laid out a very simple platform that we can use to investigate our actions. And it's good practice, sometime in the day, sometime in the evening, just to review the day and just see whether we've been skillful or unskillful. So that's the words. That's how we translate this, *kusala-akusala*. Wholesome, unwholesome, skillful, unskillful.

They're not to be looked at as commandments, putting down upon us. They're just basic rules and regulations that come out of our human existence. Just being humans, this is the situation we're in, and because of our relationship to the world, we do things which are unwholesome, and they can be, in some way, fitted into these five basic laws about harm, about truthfulness, about our relationship to things, objects, taking what's not freely given, about our sexual energy—that can be widened out to just all appetites. Whether we're eating or enjoying this or enjoying that, it all comes under, in a sense, that business of greed. And intoxicants, just being careful not to put into the body what's going to upset our consciousness.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Nekkhamma — Renunciation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 12 min

In this third talk on the pāramī (perfections), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines nekkhamma — renunciation — beginning with the Buddha's Great Renunciation when he left his palace life to seek awakening. He distinguishes between harmful self-mortification practices (which the Buddha rejected as 'dukkha, anadyo, anatasamito' — ignoble, useless suffering) and true renunciation, which involves temporarily letting go of attachments to understand our relationship to them.

The talk offers practical guidance: choose something you're attached to — a favorite TV program, evening activities, even your cup of tea — and deliberately abstain while sitting in silence to feel the fire of craving. This reveals how attachment to pleasures creates frustration when denied, grief when lost, and the constant anxiety of potential loss. Bhante explains that renunciation isn't mere psychological therapy for addiction, but spiritual insight leading to discovery of 'the other shore' — nibbāna, the unconditioned.

True renunciation naturally transforms selfishness into generosity, aversion into love. Like the Zen ox-herding pictures, after reaching the empty circle of completion, we return to the world with wisdom. As we age, life itself becomes a natural renunciation — learning to let go with dignity rather than clinging brings peace and prevents unnecessary suffering.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So we're on to the fifth of these *pāramī*, of these perfections. And this one is renunciation. *Nekkhamma*. N-E-K-K-H-A-M-M-A. Just in case you want to remember it.

It translates very well as renunciation. Now it's a key thing in Buddhist understanding, renunciation, and it's symbolised in our practice through the Buddha's own Great Renunciation—that's what it's called. It's that point where the vanity of life and the necessity of sickness, old age and death finally get through to him and he leaves. He leaves his home, he leaves his wife, his child is just born. He's a young man, he's only twenty-nine when he goes.

So we have this image of him getting on his horse, Kanthaka I think his name was, with his servant Channa and riding off to the river across the Rubicon. So it has this mythical image of crossing into another country, a river. And of course he would talk about Nibbāna eventually as being the other shore. Anyway, he gets to the river, cuts off his hair, dons the rag robes of a mendicant and off he goes. His poor horse, Kanthaka, stricken by grief, dies. Little myths around that. But it's known as the Great Renunciation. He leaves everything.

And one of the practices that he does before he becomes liberated is, of course, he tries self-mortification, the mortification practices. And these were really based on the idea that desire arose mainly from the body, so if you didn't eat then your desire for food went and so did your greed. So they were pretty tough practices to overcome the body, thinking the body as being the problem. And he practised these in his usual way to the final degree.

And if you remember, he left his companions, his five companions, and they thought he'd gone soft. But his eventual description of these mortification exercises was *dukkha anañño anattasamhito*, which means ignoble, which means it's not on the path, it doesn't lead to liberation, useless, and suffering. So there he is, trying to get rid of suffering, and he's just piling it on with these very heavy exercises of mortification.

But renunciation is something different. Renunciation is stop doing something in order to discover your attachment. That's the purpose of renunciation. And one of the distinctions we can make these days is between fasting, which is a word people don't generally use these days apart from fasting for health, and dieting. So the idea of fasting for health and dieting is you get your weight down so you can eat again, more. It's just a trick we play on ourselves. But that's not the spiritual point of fasting. Fasting was always to let go in order to see what your relationship was to what it was you were letting go of.

So if we take renunciation in that very broad sense of the term, I mean, just look at your life and just catch what you're attached to. And then just say, no, I'm not going to do it for a while, just to feel the amount of energy I'm putting into that particular object, that particular pleasure that I have.

I mean, one of the things I have said to people is, choose your favourite program on TV. So some of you will be watching the World Cup. Just sit in front of the TV, get yourself a cup of tea and a biscuit and don't turn it on. And just feel what happens when your program is on that you're normally wrapped up in.

And you can take anything that you're attached to, it doesn't matter. It could be going out of an evening, it could be DVDs, it could be a cup of tea. I dread doing renunciation of a cup of tea! But if you just think of your—just as the desire comes up for something and then you say no. But now it doesn't work unless you sit in silence, unless you actually turn into yourself and just feel the fire of that craving. You've got to feel it. And as the craving comes up, then that's telling you how attached you are to the object.

Now, why would you want to get rid of an attachment to something which is giving you pleasure? It's because that attachment is coming from an essential delusion of seeking happiness in pleasure, seeking happiness in the world. And we don't really want to stop that unless we see the aftermath. So the aftermath of attachment to pleasurable things is frustration when you can't get it, grief if you lose it, boredom. People these days, the general ordinary person doesn't connect boredom with pleasure.

And it's a big problem because the more bored you are, it means the more you'll be seeking pleasure. And boredom is the measure of the way that something that you've enjoyed has lost its oomph, has lost its buzz. So that's why you can't keep eating the same piece of chocolate. You've got to have it flavoured with orange or lemon. There's always going to be variety. So variety is the spice of life, but it's also a real disease. It brings about diseases, and those diseases are this continual lack of satisfaction, of gratification rather. So you're always seeking for something stronger.

There's that grief if you lose it, frustration if you don't get it, and this constant underlying anxiety that you may lose it. Hence you get this massive insurance industry. So unless we make that connection with the happiness that we get from pleasure with the aftermath of it, then of course renunciation doesn't make any sense.

Now, there's a deeper reason for that renunciation, because as you pull away from the world, you're also discovering what is beyond the world. You're also discovering what is on that other shore. And that cannot be discovered so long as we're attached to this world. So the process of renunciation is also not simply a psychological therapy for addiction, for compulsive behaviour. It's actually a spiritual insight because it's leading you to see that there is something other. This other shore, *Nibbāna*, what is it?

So the practice of purification is absolutely essential. You can't progress without understanding the role of renunciation in the spiritual path. And if you look at any tradition, any spiritual tradition, you'll find that it's always leaving the world. You're leaving the world. Think of anything you know—Sufis, Christian monks, Christian ascetics—they're always leaving the world.

Now we then think, well, if we left the world we just become a blob or something or a useless person. But of course this is a spiritual progress in which you are leaving the world but also developing a new relationship to the world. And that relationship no longer has this false idea that it's going to bring you happiness because you've found your happiness in something which is beyond the world, the unconditioned.

When we come back into the world having made that discovery, then of course we act in the world with that wisdom. And that's exactly what the Buddha did. And it's exactly what anybody who's enlightened does. They always come back into the world. In the oxherding pictures of Zen, remember, you get to number nine and it's the circle. So that's the completion. But then in the tenth picture, the monk is coming back into the world.

Now, although that's in the grand scheme of full liberation, we do it all the time. As you let go of something, you've also let go of some small compulsive behaviour. That compulsive behaviour is now put to better use. It turns into its opposite. So where there was compulsive behaviour—it's all about me, me, me, servicing me, me, me—it now moves outwards, it becomes you, you, you, them, them, them. So it moves from selfishness to generosity, aversion to love, cruelty to compassion. So there's always that coming back into the world. It's just a natural transformation.

But renunciation is difficult. It's not easy. It's not something that anybody would do unless they saw some benefits. I mean, if you're an addict, you see the benefit. If you're an alcoholic, obviously you want to try and let go of that. But we don't see how addiction in our lives, with a small 'a', is actually the source of a lot of restlessness and suffering and the usual stuff that I've mentioned—frustration, grief, the whole lot.

So renunciation is an absolute key virtue to develop in our lives. And you don't have to push it, just very slowly. And of course life itself, as we move towards sickness, old age and death, is a natural renunciation. And if you can't let go of life as you get older—as we get older, as we move towards the grave—then of course it becomes a real pain, a real suffering, isn't it? We have to grow old with dignity.

And that dignity becomes natural if we can just find that easiness of releasing, of just letting go. This is the way it is. I can only hope that my words have been of some assistance. Now through your constant effort at renunciation, you will liberate yourselves from all suffering and achieve the great peace sooner rather than later.

04. Paññā: Intuitive Intelligence and Wisdom

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 9 min

In this fourth talk on the pāramī (perfections), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines paññā - the perfection of wisdom and intuitive intelligence. He distinguishes wisdom from mere knowledge, explaining that wisdom concerns how we relate to the world rather than simply accumulating information.

Bhante outlines the Buddha's teaching on three progressive stages of wisdom: sutamaya paññā (wisdom from listening), cintāmayā paññā (wisdom from reflection), and vipassanāmayā paññā (wisdom from direct insight). He explores how receiving teachings can be transformative, how contemplative reflection makes knowledge truly our own, and how vipassanā meditation develops our intuitive intelligence beyond conceptual thought.

Using the famous example of Archimedes' eureka moment, Bhante illustrates how genuine insights arise when our intuitive faculty operates independently of discursive thinking. In the Mahāsi tradition, noting practice helps separate this intelligent awareness from thought processes, allowing direct perception of phenomena's characteristics like impermanence. This direct seeing into the three marks of existence - impermanence, dukkha, and anattā (not-self) - becomes the liberating wisdom that frees us from delusion and leads to perfect peace.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So the next perfection—it began, remember, with *dāna*, giving, morality, *sīla*, and then renunciation, *nekkamma*. Wisdom, *paññā*, is the next one.

So now, *paññā*, spelled P-A-N-N with that Spanish symbol on top. I forget the name of it. Does anybody know it? Spanish symbol. And the A. And this *paññā*, it's got that root sound, ñ, which comes right through the Greek, gn, and comes to us as knowledge. And the *pā* is giving it a real power. So there's two words: *vijñāna* it comes to the same word which means to discern or discriminate, and *paññā* means to really see deeply. So we translate that as insight.

Now it has both the active form as an insightful moment, but it also has a passive form as wisdom, your collected wisdom. And remember, wisdom is not to be confused with knowledge. Wisdom is to do with how we relate to the world. It's a much bigger word than just knowledge.

And the Buddha talks about three stages. The first one is *sutamaya paññā*, which is the understanding or the insights you get from listening to somebody, as you are now. And if you think about it, that's how you enter into anything, whether it's a secular subject like science or history, and it's a spiritual path. First of all, you listen. You receive something. So it's the wisdom you get from receiving something. And this can be just an intellectual understanding—oh yes, it's very interesting—but it can also strike quite deeply.

And there are occasions in the scripture where people just on hearing a scripture seem to have had a quite deep insight just on the hearing of it. So listening to something can be quite life-changing. Maybe there is something that you have experienced. In my own life, I would say the experience of actually not so much reading, but seeing *Waiting for Godot*. I can always consider that the beginning of my spiritual path. It had such a profound effect on me. And I couldn't stop talking about it for days, to the annoyance of everybody who knew me. And that wasn't as though I thought about it or anything. I was just receiving the basic message that that play had to give. Just hitting it at the right time in the right place.

The next one is *cintāmaya paññā*. *Cinta* is just the word for the mind. So that's basically when we receive something, we begin to mull it over in our minds. And in so doing, as it were, it becomes our own knowledge. So that's why you get what we call inspirational reading. In inspirational reading, and this is something that the Benedictines in the Christian tradition developed, it's called *Lectio Divina*, divine reading. You read something—that's your receiving. And then, as it were, when something strikes you, a bit like music, a bit like a poem, you keep repeating it. You keep just reading it over and over until you get this sense of absorbing it, a digestion. And at that point, maybe not immediately afterwards, but at some time you find yourself thinking about it. And this thinking about it actually makes it your own knowledge.

Now, if you can't think about it, it never actually gets to be your own knowledge, and you normally can't explain it. I have a very good personal example of that. I've read relativity theory in very simple layman's terms many a time, but I still can't explain it to somebody. I seem to lose the thread of the logic of it at some point. But I understand it when I read it. This is the funny thing. But when I try and think about it, I tend to lose it.

And then finally, of course, there's this *vipassanāmayā paññā*. So seeing things at that direct grasp of things. And that, of course, is really beginning to employ a faculty within us which is not thought.

So this faculty within us, *paññā*, this intuitive wisdom, this intuitive intelligence—intuitive awareness is sometimes called—but if we just separate it from awareness, which is more the receiving part, the actual bit that's intelligent, the intuitive intelligence, normally speaking, does not distinguish itself from thought. And the whole process of *vipassanā* is to begin to separate that intelligence from thought. And that in the Mahāsi tradition is done by noting. So the thought is contained in a word, but as it were, the intelligence is pointing at something else: the direct feeling of a thing or the direct characteristic of a thing such as its arising and passing nature.

And in so doing, in freeing itself from thought, it now has a direct grasp of the way things really are. And the paradox is that it couldn't have got to that point without going through that process of receiving knowledge and thinking about it. And it's through that very medium of thought that once it's had an insight, it can then tell itself what it's just seen. Otherwise, it wouldn't be able to reflect upon the insights that it has.

And I think the greatest example of that in scientific history, or the most common one, or the most famous one, is Archimedes. So Archimedes is trying to figure out whether this crown is real gold or not, and he needs the weight and the volume, and he divides one into the other, or he gets confused, and eventually comes up with a specific weight, and then he knows it's pure gold. When it comes to weight of an irregular object, there's no problem. He just puts it on weights and he knows how many grams it is. But how do you get the volume of an irregular shape? Now, to us, of course, it seems very obvious. But in those days, somebody's got to crack that. Somebody's got to actually break through that conundrum. How do you get the volume of an irregular shape?

So he's thinking about it and he's probably racking his brains about it. The king would probably chop his head off. And finally, he gives up and he takes a bath. And as he's relaxing—I can only presume he's relaxing, not thinking about it—getting into a bath, and as he gets into the bath, he suddenly sees that the water is rising, and it must be rising by the displacement caused through his own body. And there he is, he's got it, and he shouts, "Eureka! I've got it, I've found it." If he'd never have had a bath at that moment, we probably would still not know how to get the volume of an irregular shape.

So that ability that we have within us, this intuitive intelligence, is what *vipassanā* meditation is specifically trying to develop. And that's how we get these insights. And the insight, remember, into impermanence, into the psychology of suffering, and into

this quality of not-me-not-mine is liberational. That's what actually liberates us from a delusive idea of what the world is. And it's that liberation which brings us to perfect peace and happiness.

So this *paññā*, of course, is absolutely central to the Buddha's teaching and how to develop it and where to look in order to liberate ourselves. And therefore that also is a perfection that also has to be brought to a point of keen exercise.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you develop your *paññā* and be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Sādhu, sādhu, sādhu.

Vīriya: Effort

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

In this talk on vīriya (effort), one of the ten pāramī or perfections, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the Buddha's teaching on right effort as found in the Noble Eightfold Path and the Satipaṭṭhāna discourse. Drawing on the Pali terms vīriya, vāyāma, and ātāpī, he explains the paradox of 'effortless effort' - establishing a position of objective observation rather than straining to achieve specific results.

The talk illuminates how genuine effort in meditation involves finding the balanced attention described in the Buddha's teaching to the monk Soṇa about tuning a vīṇā - neither too tight nor too slack. Bhante emphasizes that our effort should focus on becoming the 'objective observer' who watches body, heart, and mind with curiosity, allowing wisdom to naturally arise through sustained awareness.

For daily life application, he discusses how right effort manifests through proper intention (cetanā) and mindful engagement with work and relationships. Drawing connections to right livelihood within the Eightfold Path, he shows how intention determines whether our actions create stress or serve as spiritual practice. The talk concludes with practical advice on overcoming laziness through contemplation of urgency and the benefits of mindfulness, making this teaching accessible for both meditation practitioners and those seeking to integrate Dhamma into everyday activities.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

Now, for fear of boring one or two of you, I did this talk at Chrissie's and I forgot how to operate my little recorder, so I just wanted to repeat this talk around effort. It's one of what we call the perfections, which I think you can translate as the seven virtues, but the word *pāramī* just means those things that take you to the other shore, and it's the Buddha's image for Nibbāna to be over on the other side.

The word there is *vīriya*, and you'll get it also in the Eightfold Noble Path where they use the word *vāyāma*. And in the scriptures, in the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse on how to establish this mindfulness we've just been practising, the Buddha uses the word *ātāpī*. So the first two words, this *vīriya* and *vāyāma*, just refer to effort, but this *ātāpī* is really saying a real consistent effort in the practice.

This effort in the practice is really what Zen calls the effortless effort. And what's meant by that is you're not trying to achieve anything. That is really important. What you're trying to do is establish a way of looking at something, and then you have to have trust that this intelligence we have will actually see. It might not work immediately, so you've got to have a certain confidence. So that's the effort.

The Buddha is quite clear about that. These three words come together: this effort, mindfully and with intuitive intelligence. And this intuitive intelligence manifests as curiosity, as a curiosity of a child. It's coming from a place where you don't know. If you're curious about something and you've got some ideas, you tend to see what you're looking for. But whatever we're looking for is something which is not directly obvious to us, or else we'd have seen it.

So, for instance, in our meditation we've just been trying to look at impermanence. Well, if you said to anybody in the street, "Everything changes," they'd say, "So what? Everything, quite obviously everything changes." But in the Buddha's understanding, this change is quite radical. Everything actually disappears and reappears. It moves into potential and then into actual. And it's that, it's recognising that there's death with every moment, every single moment just drops away and then it arises. And this obviously can be experienced, but what it shows us is a discontinuity. That's the point, the discontinuity.

So, for instance, when you see yourself in the mirror, you recognise that this is the same person that you've always known for all your life. And you presume that it's the same person, it's the same body. But we know that the body completely changed every seven years, all the atoms are completely transferred, but we don't see that at all. And therefore we live in that comfortable delusion that this is the body that I've had, and that there's somehow some stability to it. So it's really when we get down to understanding these things, then it brings us up against these real understandings of life as to how it rises and passes away.

Now, the point about this right effort in meditation is that we have to be clear that our effort is not to see this. Our effort is to get into a position where this is seen. In other words, we're trying to get into that position of the objective observer, of that place within us like an observation post, and we're just watching.

One of the examples that I tend to use is the twitcher. So they hide, they're in a hide and they look out through this little window with their binoculars, and they just watch the bird. They don't do anything to the bird, this is the point. They don't do anything, they just watch. And then they go away and write their bestseller. Now that's what we're doing. We're trying to find this little hide within ourselves and we're just watch-

ing. And what are we watching? We're watching our physicality, the body, and how it manifests. We're watching the heart and how it manifests. And we're watching the mind and thoughts. And it's just in the watching that we come to know ourselves. You don't have to try. It's just the watching.

Now, if you try too hard, if something comes in which makes you strain, then there's something else coming into the equation. You're either trying to achieve something or trying to concentrate. That's a bad one. Concentration comes with relaxation.

So there's a story of Sona, who was one of the monks during the Buddha's time. And he'd given up, and he decided that he was going to leave the monastic life and go back to the ordinary lay life. And when the Buddha heard this, he went to see him. And this was the big problem: he was straining and straining. So he talked about tuning a string on a *vīṇā*. So that's a bit like a guitar. It mustn't be too tight, or else you miss the note, and it can't be too slack. And it's just getting that ability to just get the right effort so that your attention is steady. If you find yourself getting tense, then immediately you pull back and relax. If you find you're falling asleep, you wake up and make an effort. And that moment of being relaxed and yet firm is very difficult for us, because we're always on one side or the other.

Now, when it comes to right effort in daily life, that right effort is, I mean, there's obviously some form of achieving there. Like if you're at work, you've got to do a job. If you're at home, you've got to do this and that. So the achieving isn't the problem. The problem is, or if there is a problem, the problem is your intention. What is your intention? So this is where we begin to develop our personalities and our characters.

It's interesting that right there within the Buddha's eightfold path you have right livelihood. So he's saying that what you do in society is of central importance to your spiritual life. Now if you're doing a job simply to get on, simply for status, simply for money and all that, then obviously those intentions are going to drive you in a way which create what we know these days as stress. But if your intention is service, if you take your attention to service, then there's a very different feel to what you do. That doesn't mean to say that you can't ask for proper wages and that you can't go for a job which has high status but which you feel you can do. But it's the intention which is going to create either an internal state of stress or not.

Now, when you put right effort into your work, this is obviously to do with mindfulness. Which is one of these buzzwords that you see these days, mindfulness and stress, we've got mindfulness. Mindfulness is all over the place. So this mindfulness is just doing what you're doing. In Zen, they say when you wash the pots, just wash the pots. It's one of these little famous phrases.

And there was a case of a Zen master who would say this. And he was having breakfast and he was eating his breakfast and reading a newspaper. So one of his students said to him, "Roshi, I just noticed that you are eating your breakfast and reading a newspaper." He says, "When I'm eating breakfast, I'm eating breakfast. When I'm reading the newspaper, I'm reading the newspaper." It depends where you put your attention.

So when you're at work or when you're doing something, make sure you have the right intention for doing this particular piece of work. And you have to keep stopping to reaffirm it because the old intentions keep creeping in. And then you put your attention into what you're doing.

Now, in our meditation, we've found this place of an objective observer. So there's this feeling of a self looking at, this feeling of an observer looking at things. Now that's actually a false place. It's not the final end that we want to get to. But then we think that's what we've got to do in daily life. So you watch yourself doing something and you think that's mindfulness. Well, you can get away with that if you're doing something physical, but you can't have a conversation and observe yourself speaking. You lose the train of thought. You definitely can't add up your bills either.

So it's a case of when that self-awareness comes, it's there, but you keep putting your attention on what you're doing. As you put your attention on what you're doing, the self disappears because you are absorbed into the task. That's your meditation in action. And you know that you've been there because when you come out of it, into that self-awareness, a certain time has passed where there's been no time and there's been no sense of self. Now what makes that an enlightening experience is the purpose with which you went into it, the intention. So this is all included in this idea of right effort.

And that right effort begins with what the Buddha called *cetanā*. It translates as will. And in the standing meditation we came to that point where we could see intentions arise. So just before we sat we noted intending to rise, intending to sit. Now we could have stayed there, we could have kept standing. You don't have to obey an intention. But as soon as you moved, you empowered that intention. And as soon as you do that, you create a conditioning. You've created what in the language is called a *kamma*. You hear this word *kamma*, which normally means your comeuppance, but actually in the original literature it's what you do, it's your action. There's another word for your comeuppance.

So as soon as you've put your will into something, that's it. You can't stop it. That's it. It'll have an effect. It'll have an effect internally, and it'll have an effect externally. And you don't know what's going to happen either way, because it moves into conditions

over which you don't have control. So it's good to know what your intention is, because even if it turns out wrong, at least you feel good in yourself. So you might do something for the benefit of somebody else and they hate you for it. Occasionally happens. But you feel good within yourself because you did it with the right intention. There's that feeling of goodness in you. You can't stop people reacting from their position. So that's the important thing about effort.

Wherever you put your effort, you're going to create the conditioning. So once you begin to know that, then you do bring this mindfulness into your life, because putting in right effort is going to create happiness. Putting in wrong effort creates unhappiness. Simple as that.

And finally, there's this whole business of getting lazy, which is the opposite of effort. And when we do things and we're lazy and you feel guilty, that's good. You should feel guilty. You should be guilty and shameful that you've been lazy. And then you should give yourself a little exercise or something to increase your effort. And one of the things that the Buddha advises to create this sense of urgency, sense of urgency that's not stress, it's a sense of getting on with the job, is to contemplate on the negative side: sickness, old age and death. If you haven't got that long to live, it doesn't matter where you are, you don't know when you're going to go, so better make best of the circumstance you're within.

And the other one is to contemplate the benefit of mindfulness and how it can actually radically change your life, radically change your relationships. And it doesn't mean to say that life gets that much easier, but at least we're here, at least we're aware.

So right effort is really central to the Buddhist teachings. It's right there, right within virtually everything he says, right effort. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated because of your unending efforts towards your liberation, sooner rather than later.

Sādhū, sādhū, sādhū.

06. Khantī — Patience

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 11 min

In this exploration of khantī pāramī (the perfection of patience), Bhante Bodhidhamma reveals why the Buddha declared "there is nothing greater than patience." Drawing from key teachings, he shows how impatience is fundamentally rooted in dukkha — our suffering arises when we cannot accept conditions as they are, constantly wanting situations to be different.

Bhante explains how patience connects directly to the Buddha's core teaching of dukkha and dukkha-nirodha (suffering and its cessation). Every moment of impatience represents suffering — the irritation, anger, and frustration that arise when we don't get what we want or encounter what we don't want. The practice involves cultivating awareness of these arising reactions and learning to bear with them rather than being overwhelmed.

Using practical examples from daily life irritations to challenging monastery situations, Bhante demonstrates how patience requires moving beyond the self's perspective. The antidotes he offers include mettā (loving-kindness), compassion, and contemplation of anicca (impermanence). By putting ourselves in others' shoes and accepting the natural rhythm of change, we dissolve the barriers the ego creates and find peace with what is.

This teaching offers both newcomers and experienced practitioners essential guidance for transforming reactivity into the spiritual strength that comes from patient forbearance.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So the next on the list is *khanti*, which translates as patience, and I've just got three quotes here from the Buddha. "O monks, even if bandits should come and brutally saw you limb from limb with a double-handed saw, should you indulge your hatred towards them, you would not be followers of mine." I once said that to a group, and somebody said the Buddha had a great sense of humour.

"Patience, in force, in strong array, in someone that is, that person I call a Brahmin." A Brahmin was his way of saying somebody who was truly a spiritual, a developed person. Remember in his day there was a little fight going on between the Kshatriyas, the warrior caste, and the Brahmins as to who were the top notch of society. Eastward of

him in Bengal the Brahmins had won really. They were the top of the society. But where the Buddha was there was still that fight going on. It took a few more years before they finally became top dogs.

And the other one is "There's no greater thing exists than patience." I think "There's nothing greater than patience" is probably a better translation. So we have to ask why the Buddha made it so important.

Well, if you go back to his basic teaching which he reduced to a simple three words in the Pali: *dukkha dukkha nirodha*, which just means suffering and the end of suffering. So he's talking about suffering and the end of suffering. When you think, every time you're impatient, you're suffering. So patience is not being impatient. And what is it that makes us impatient? It's not getting what we want and getting what we don't want. And every time that happens, you get irritated, you get angry, you get frustrated. So all that's to do with developing patience.

Once we go back to that essential teaching of the Buddha around *dukkha*, about suffering, about unsatisfactoriness, then you see a lot of our impatience, a lot of our suffering, arises with not being able to accept conditions as they are. It's very simple. We always want them to be some other way. If only. This isn't the way it should be.

Remember, did you ever see Clint Eastwood in *Unforgiven*? Right at the end there's this usual big shootout and he's shot everybody. And the leader of the gang, as he's dying, he said, "This shouldn't have happened." That's what we say: this shouldn't happen, this shouldn't be like this. So we're constantly unable to accept the situation as it is. And that manifests in this impatience, frustration, anything which is that anger and whatnot is a lack of patience.

If you go back to the root meaning in English, which is really good, go back to your Latin school. *Patio, passi, patio, pati, passo* - to suffer. I suffer, *patio*. So we get words like patient, to be patient, passion. So our own word patience tells us that it's about being able to bear, forbearance, patient forbearance, being able to bear something.

If you just consider little times in your life where you find yourself getting just irritable about something, even if a door won't open or a door makes a noise when you close it, you get irritable. And if you look at all these little irritations that come up during the day, it's always because we want it to be something other than it is. This isn't the way it should be. So it's catching that, catching that moment and noting, being able to be aware of the arising of irritation, impatience. And as that arises just to bear with it, bear with it, allow it to pass, and then remind ourselves: this is the way it is, this is the way it is.

And the big antidotes, of course, as usual, is just loving-kindness, compassion. So when somebody irritates you, it's because they're doing something you don't want them to do. You have to wait for that irritation to arise, wait for it to pass. You can do it even while you're talking kindly. You can feel it there in the background. And making that effort to put yourself in their shoes. Put yourself in their shoes.

Even if somebody is purposefully getting up your nose, purposefully trying to get you irritated, even then that reaction of wanting to respond with irritation, with impatience, one tries to just let it arise and always approaching the person with at least a sense of non-violence, of putting yourself in the other person's shoes.

So the antidote is always to accept things as they are and to see it from the other person's position. To do that is to undermine this sense of self. Now one of the ways the self manifests is that it sees the world only from its perspective: this is me, this is my opinion, this is the way it should be for me. And as soon as you deposit your attention outward into somebody else's situation, you necessarily have to lose the barrier which the self always puts up. You can't go beyond the barrier. It's not as though there aren't marking off points, but there's between a barrier and a mark which separates one thing from another. What's the word I'm looking for there? What do you have around a property? A boundary, thanks.

There's usually a boundary and a barrier. Boundaries are passable. You can move in and out of them. But a barrier just puts up a wall. The self always likes to have walls. It likes to be firm. It gives it a sense of strength. And contemplating *anicca*, impermanence. Wanting things to be the way things are. You want it to change before it will change. You want the weather to be better. You want the job to move on. So this impatience, and that impatience is not accepting. In fact, that change also has its own rhythm, its own momentum.

One of the blessings of living in Sri Lanka, at Kanduboda, but just living with the Sri Lankan order, was their attitude to very annoying people who turned up at the monastery. I only remember one person ever being asked to leave - one monk this is - ever being asked to leave. And that's because he had a very peculiar idea of what the Vinaya was. But generally speaking, there was just this patience.

So we had one Westerner turn up who was - he actually told us he was schizophrenic. He probably hadn't taken his tablets. But he was doing the most strange things. I mean, talking to everybody, walking around nude, taking his bath at the wrong time. Everything that you could possibly expect a person to do in a monastery, he did the op-

posite. And everybody complained to the abbot. He would just say, "Oh well, patience and all that," and he just wouldn't ask him to leave. And then of course the time came when he just left anyway.

Now if you consider most times when somebody aggressive, somebody something evil comes into a situation, generally speaking you find the good people fly away. They leave. They won't hang on in there and wait until that negativity has passed. And that's why you get this takeover of evil, because they don't want to bear the suffering of that evil. Because they fight it, of course, they become part of that bad energy. But they won't hang on in there. Always escaping. And that escaping, that wanting to get away from what is irritating and not pleasant and all that, that's the impatience. That's the lack of patience, lack of patience for bad.

So this is one good reason why we should develop patience. It makes you feel much more at ease with the situation, just opening up to it: this is the way it is. Even in our bodies, when the body gets sick, when it gets ill, people don't like that. They're always fighting it. They don't want to have the flu. So they're actually putting this negative thing into their body of not wanting it to be like that. But if you were to put yourself in the position of your body instead of this person who wants to be somewhere else, then you naturally take care of it and it heals the better for it.

So you can understand why this patience becomes a really important virtue in the Buddhist teaching. It's all rooted in unsatisfactoriness, suffering, and the cause of unsatisfactoriness and suffering.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, and I must thank you for your patience in bearing with my little homily. May you be liberated from all suffering through your exercise of patience, sooner rather than later.

Sacca: Honesty

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 10 min

In this DhammaBytes episode on the pāramīs (perfections), Bhante Bodhidhamma explores sacca - the perfection of honesty and truthfulness. Moving beyond obvious dishonesty, he examines the subtle ways we deviate from truth: exaggeration to impress others (rooted in the three conceits of superiority, inferiority, and equality), 'being economical with the truth,' and pretending knowledge we don't possess.

The teaching addresses the challenge of honest reporting in meditation practice, drawing from his experience with Eastern teachers who emphasized authenticity in describing spiritual experiences. He explores the complex territory of 'white lies' - examining intentions behind withholding or modifying truth, illustrated through stories from Sri Lanka about cultural differences in saying 'no' and keeping commitments.

Bhante emphasizes that the most difficult aspect of sacca is radical self-honesty - seeing ourselves as we truly are, which he defines as genuine humility. He presents the Buddhist teaching that when two people meet, six people are present: how each sees themselves, how each is seen by the other, and who each truly is. This perfection of honesty cuts through self-deception and supports clear communication, making it essential for both meditation practice and daily life interactions.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So, just to carry on with these *pāramī*, the next one is *sacca*. The 'c' in Pali is always 'ch' and it translates as honesty, truthfulness.

I think we can pass over telling the great whoppers. I think we've gone beyond that. But Churchill talked about it. Churchill put it as being economical with the truth. But the other dishonesty is to do with exaggeration. And we tend to exaggerate in order to impress people. It's to do with the three conceits. We're either trying to impress somebody that we're better than we are, or worse than we are, or we're equal to them, even though we know we're not.

So that exaggeration that we put about ourselves, there's also exaggeration about the weather, the climate change, the financial crisis, just the way we talk about it, exaggerating it to create some impression. And so long as, I think it's a case of just being aware of what we're saying and what we're doing. It's always to do with right speech.

But there's a point where I think exaggeration leaves the humorous and moves into just that little area of slight untruth. You just have to be careful. I mean, I've occasionally found myself, when somebody's come up with a Pali word, pretending that I know it. It embarrasses me. And then I've got to go and look it up. And it's just because I've got in my head that I know Pali words, and I don't. I've got to get over the fact that I'm not a Pali scholar. And it's happened to me about, well, once I remember distinctly being corrected, and so I'm humbled and made some excuse about it.

So these things slip in and they're coming from that sense of self, basically. So just being aware of where we exaggerate is just slipping into untruth.

In terms of meditation, it can be a real problem because it was funny, when I used to work with my Eastern teachers, they were often all about honesty. It was because Westerners would talk about their experience. And I never really found out whether it was the fact that Westerners were exaggerating or whether it was the teachers who didn't believe that Westerners could attain these experiences. And I remember once saying to Ajahn Sumedho, I said, they think we're spiritual nerds, like we would think of Easterners at one time as being technological twits. And so there was that confusion, but they were always on about honesty, being honest in your reporting.

The next one that is of interest is white lies. These are all to do with intentions. What's your intention in not saying something that you ought to say, or in saying something that is not right, but for some good reason? I think in former times it was very difficult to tell somebody they were dying. You always had to pretend that they weren't actually dying, even though the person probably felt that they were dying. These days people are a bit more open about that, but it's a case of having a good reason for not saying the truth and being clear about it.

But I remember once there was an old teacher of mine from primary school whom I met and he became headmaster of a local place. And the catering service decided to serve TVP, textured vegetable protein, instead of meat. And he didn't tell the staff. And then he asked the staff what it was like, and of course they said it was all right, good mince, very nice meat, and all that. And then he told them. And they were very upset, because they felt they'd been used as guinea pigs. It was all right doing it to the kids.

And it was funny, because he told me with this sense of astonishment as to why they were so upset about it. And it was like he was, in other words, what he didn't realise was that in not telling them, he presumed that they would be prejudiced. So if he'd told them that it was TVP, they'd have eaten it with that critical mind and said, well, this isn't like meat, it doesn't have the same crunch, it doesn't have this, it doesn't have that. And he was tricking them in a way. So he got a bit of flack for that. But it just shows you, it was a good intention in a sense. But from his point of view, there was this lack of trust in the teachers that they wouldn't accept this TVP business.

Now, the one that's usually talked about in the commentaries is keeping your word, actually. That's the one they usually go on about, keeping your word. And I think we often find when somebody asks us to do something, we can be a bit too quick with the "yes, I'll do it." Instead of just holding a minute and saying, well, I'll have to think about it, I'll have to look at my diary or something. And you find yourself saying yes and then kicking yourself for doing it.

And then when it comes to the time to actually help them out, moving house or painting and decorating or something, suddenly you're feeling ill. You phone up and say, "Can't come, there's an elephant's just entered the house and I've got to deal with it," things like that, to get out of this hole you've got yourself in. And then you do it and you're feeling rotten all the time for doing it. And all it took was this moment of just saying, well, I'm not sure I can help or what.

There's a lovely incident of that in Sri Lanka. Easterners, because of loss of face, have it very difficult to say no. I came across this when I was in the *kutī*. I was trying to keep the rule very strictly. It was very difficult to do that. And so I would ask the office to buy me something. I can't remember what the object was now, but let's say it was apples. So I would say to them, can you get me so many apples? They were in trust with my money that I had. They were my *kappiya*, the ones who make it allowable.

Well, if they couldn't get apples, they came with a whole load of oranges. They couldn't come to me and say, there aren't any apples. They had to come with something else. But eventually I got fed up because I was wasting all my money. So I had to give up on asking them to do something.

And there was this Australian monk, now this is really going to make you laugh. So he had turned up in Sri Lanka and he had invited this senior monk to come to Thailand with him. And the senior monk couldn't say no. He can't say no. So he does this shake of the head business. And he bought a ticket, bought a ticket. And it was all arranged to meet at the airport, and he never turned up. And it was just too much for this Australian guy. This was the absolute pits, a senior monk. And I found that constantly in the

East, the inability to say no and giving you the impression they're coming. And then they don't. Or they say they'll do something and then they don't. And I think it's to do with that Eastern thing about losing face and not being shamed, a shamed culture rather than ours, which is more guilt-ridden.

So I think that's an area where you see in the commentaries, it's only discussed, as far as I remember, to do with this keeping your word.

So that gives you some ideas about this quality of *sacca* of truthfulness, being absolutely honest. And I think the most difficult thing is to be honest with oneself, frankly, to be brutally honest with oneself, to see oneself as one really is. And in a sense, that's the definition of humility. In its proper sense, to see oneself as one really is.

And you come across this way of talking about it in Buddhism. I don't know where this has come from, but when two people meet, there are six people there. There's me as I think I am, there's me as you think I am, and there's me as I really am. And the same applies to you. So how we communicate is a problem and it just shows how we have these self images which don't live up to the way other people see us and they see us from their vantage point they put a twist on us and seeing ourselves as we really are would cut through a lot of this stuff that comes up through honesty.

So it's quite a virtue really. Quite a virtue to develop that.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

08. Adhiṭṭhāna — Resolution

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 13 min

In this eighth episode on the pāramīs (perfections), Bhante Bodhidhamma explores adhiṭṭhāna — resolution or resolute determination. Drawing from the Buddha's own great resolve under the Bodhi tree to either achieve Awakening or die, this talk examines how conscious commitment transforms ordinary intentions into powerful spiritual tools.

Bhante explains the crucial distinction between mere desire and empowered intention, showing how our unconscious habits of breaking resolutions gradually undermine our capacity for commitment. Through practical examples from meditation practice, daily life, and relationships, he demonstrates how keeping wise and realistic resolutions strengthens our spiritual development.

The teaching emphasizes making resolutions that are within our actual capacity while maintaining the flexibility to adapt when circumstances genuinely require it. Special attention is given to how this perfection applies to meditation practice, daily mindfulness, and maintaining wholesome commitments over time. This wisdom becomes essential for anyone seeking to develop consistency in their spiritual practice and overcome the patterns of self-defeating behavior that obstruct the path to liberation.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So we're on number eight now of our perfections, our *pāramī*, those that take us to the other shore. It's resolution, *adhiṭṭhāna* — A-D-H-I-T-T-H-A-N-A, just in case you want to know. *Ṭhāna* means position or place, your standing ground, and *adhi* just reinforces it — resolute resolution, enormous resolve.

This is mirrored in the Buddha's life just before he became fully liberated. You remember the story: he left home, finding the household life had become empty because of this problem of meaninglessness. It would have been expressed in those days as constant rebirth — constantly having to come back and do the same thing all over again. The same thing, slightly different story, but always being born, growing up, going old and dying, and that constant thing is reincarnation.

He then went out to try and find an answer to this end of suffering, as he would call it — something hard to bear, unsatisfactoriness, a fundamental unsatisfactoriness. And he tried all that business of developing absorption states, for they would disappear inside. And he tried self-mortification, and it just got very thin. And eventually he had that inspiration coming from childhood, the way that child gets wrapped into something and yet has that curiosity. So that was his inspiration, and he went to sit under this tree, what we now call the Bodhi tree, the fig tree, the religious fig tree. And he made a determination: either to crack this problem or to die.

That was the great determination, and it took him six hours. So it's mirrored in his life as that moment when he'd come to an end and he thought, well, either this is it or what's the point. He was going to sit there until he dropped dead.

This comes as one of the great virtues, and you have to make a distinction between an intention and the intentioned. The English word "intention" has this double meaning of meaning a wish — I have an intention to go — and I intended to do it, meaning that you actually made an act of will. That's why we always make a distinction between the desire that arises and the empowerment of that desire. These are two moments — two moments.

So even in simple things like a cup of tea, it comes up as a desire and nothing happens until you empower it. Normally speaking, it's habitual — we just go and do it. But what meditation, what our mindfulness should do, daily mindfulness, is to make us more and more aware of these little intentions that come. And then there's this power that goes into an intention. That's your will. And it's the will that takes something out of potential into actual.

So long as it remains a desire in the mind, nothing's happened. But as soon as you empower it, something happens: either a train of thoughts or an action or speech. One of those things happens. And that's what we understand as a *kamma*. And the important thing is to know that this is how we condition ourselves, through these intentions.

Now, when an intention becomes, instead of habitual, something that you consciously make a decision about, then you have to be resolute about that. You have to really contemplate why you want to do something and then you do it. And of course there's always a little clause that stops you from going and taking it overboard, except in exceptional circumstance or emergency.

So you might determine to climb a mountain — see that corner there, where's the hill. And as you get up and up and up, you might find that you're getting colder and colder and colder, you haven't put the right clothes on. In which case you have to come down because there's good reason. But if you got up and up and you felt, well, I can't be bothered getting to the top, then that wouldn't be a wholesome reason.

And slowly but surely, by not completing your resolutions for good reasons, you undermine your resolve. You undermine your ability to commit yourself. You never finish anything — these people who say they can't finish anything. So you have to be quite clear when you make a resolution that's what you're going to do.

This comes about also when even inadvertently you say you're going to help somebody and then you decide you don't want to do it. So you're undermining constantly your commitment. In this case, you're undermining your goodwill. And the spiritual life — to do that in the spiritual life is really undermining, because if you say to yourself, "I'm going to sit here for six hours, I'm going to sit here until I become fully enlightened or I'll drop dead or I die," and you give up after half an hour, that's bad news, isn't it?

Having made a rational decision that you are going to sit here for 40 minutes, try to keep it. Even if you're shifting and moving and doing all sorts of silly things, you keep to that resolve. And then there's that lovely feeling of having completed your commitment.

I remember when I first started meditating in the Zen — we were facing the wall, sitting on a bench. I wasn't sitting cross-legged. So it must have been, it wasn't very long I'd started, but the pain was excruciating in the knees and whatnot, really quite painful. But I was determined not to move. I was absolutely, you know, Zen. You bang your head against the wall — that's what it's for. That's why you sit next to the wall.

But I couldn't take it. And just as I gave up, the bell went. Oh, I felt terrible. Oh, never again, I said. Never again will I give up on a resolve. So, be careful.

When you hear of people trying to overcome certain habits, certain addictions around smoking, eating, drinking and whatnot, it's very difficult. And the more you don't keep your resolve, the more you undermine your ability to keep resolve. So you have to really keep to your resolve.

Now, you won't keep to resolve if it's not a wise undertaking. And what we mean by that is that it's something that you actually feel you can do. There's no point in determining to climb Everest. I mean, you've not done any training for it. It's an absolute waste of time. You just keep — like it's a Walter Mitty, isn't it?

So it has to be something that is rational, something that you know you can do, even if it takes just that little bit more effort. But you keep the resolve. And that's, of course, the same with things that are wholesome, too.

After morning chanting here, before we make the final bows, I always ask people to make a resolution for the day. This is more like a general resolve just to live mindfully with a good heart, something very general.

Now the problem with these resolves, of course, we keep forgetting. So, as often as you can during the day, to keep reinforcing that resolve by just saying it, eventually becomes habitual.

When we take vows, such as marriage vows, I think people think that once you've had this big ceremony, you've made a vow, that's it, you don't have to worry about it anymore. But the vow only lasts as long as the ceremony. It might last a couple of days after that. Then you get fed up with each other. So it's a constant. That's why, when I've done these little things for people, I always say on your anniversary, don't just go out and get drunk or something. Actually use it to re-establish the vow. And in that way, you keep reinforcing your commitment to the relationship.

So it's the same with a job. Once you've undertaken a job, ordinary work — if you keep reinforcing your commitment to it, you won't give in to silly things like boredom. There'll be that constant empowering of your effort towards what you're doing.

I had somebody email me just recently, and they had found a way of being alive by doing something new. But having done something new for so long, it became habitual again and they went back into these old patterns of a lack of spontaneity in their lives. What I pointed out to them was that it's your intention and your constant empowering of your intention to be with what you're doing in a completely whole-minded, whole-hearted way that turns it into a spontaneous action again.

So then he wrote back and he said, when I'm playing with my children — and he's got young kids — and he's actually in that communication of being creative with them and all that, then these ideas of being habitual and lack of spontaneity disappear. He said, is that what you mean? I said, yes.

So this comes about by recognising what your intentions are, make sure they're wholesome, and then you just do it. You put yourself into it. And that's one of this business of *adhiṭṭhāna*.

So this *adhiṭṭhāna*, Resolute Resolution, is a real virtue to develop. And it's a case of keeping to your resolve as best you can, making sure it's within your power — don't be ridiculous about results — and to make a determination to do it. Then you always say, save an extraordinary circumstance or emergency. Else you become foolhardy. You push yourself even when the whole situation is telling you that actually this resolve is not working. It's not working anymore. Stop it.

So I can only hope my words of being of some assistance and that by your resolute resolutions you will indeed come to the end of suffering sooner rather than later.

Mettā - Love

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 7 min

Bhante Bodhidhamma introduces mettā (loving-kindness) as the foundation of the brahmavihāra practices, emphasizing its crucial role in balancing vipassanā meditation. He clarifies that mettā is not about generating warm emotions but rather cultivating an attitude of goodwill - training the will to think lovingly toward all beings.

The talk addresses common misconceptions, explaining that mettā practice focuses on intention rather than feeling, with attention directed outward toward others rather than seeking personal emotional satisfaction. Bhante describes the progressive stages of mettā meditation, beginning with those who have helped us and gradually extending to all beings universally, establishing a basic friendship that serves as the foundation for the other brahmavihāras.

He explains how genuine mettā naturally gives rise to karuṇā (compassion) when beings suffer, muditā (appreciative joy) when they experience good fortune, and upekkhā (equanimity) when appropriate. The four traditional blessings offered in mettā practice are explored: safety, health, happiness, and contentment. Using the Buddha's analogy of a mother's varied responses to her four children, Bhante illustrates how mettā provides the stable foundation from which all skillful relationships naturally arise, creating a universal attitude of goodwill independent of personal preferences.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa — Homage to the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened One.

I was going to talk about *mettā* tonight, which is just what we've done, this practice of goodwill. It's something which balances the practice of *vipassanā*. In *vipassanā*, we're trying to find a very objective position to ourselves. We're trying to experience what we normally call ourselves as objective experiences. So when we say the body and we're looking inward, what is it that we're actually experiencing? When we say an emotion, what do we actually mean by that?

So we take this position of the objective observer, one removed. That isn't the final position. The final position is even to get rid of the observer so that we're into a pure state of observing. But the downside of that is the equanimity that we get can so easily turn to indifference. And somehow we have to re-engage with the psycho-physical organism so that the wisdom that we have can actually be expressed. And to do that you

have to drop the wisdom into the heart, the right attitude, and then the attitude will express itself through the rest of the Eightfold Path in right speech, right action, and right livelihood.

So whenever you do *vipassanā*, it really is important to finish with *mettā*, even if it's only a minute, just to bring yourself back into a relationship with the world. And what we're trying to do is to establish an attitude.

So the mistake that is often made is that we're trying to get an emotion going, a loving, sweet, touchy-feely emotion. And that's a disaster. You have to pretend that you're feeling loving. So abandon that. It's useless. The idea is that you're training your will, your will to think lovingly, loving relationship, a loving thought. You've got to be careful with thought, but it's an attitude. It's a position you're taking of goodwill. And eventually the heart will respond. You do feel lovely when you're offering your goodwill to somebody. But then the danger is that you start doing this loving business in order to feel good.

And that's when it becomes corrupted. So your attention is always on the other. Your goodwill is going outwards towards the other as an intention. You'll notice that we turn it also towards ourselves, so that's also another mistake that you're very loving to everybody else but you beat yourself up. That's not a good thing to do either. So you have to offer yourself your goodwill. And in so doing, what you're creating is a basic relationship to all beings. That's what you end up with.

So you start with the particular, which is easy — somebody who's helped you. That's easy because of the gratitude that comes up. And you go through these stages where you're basically opening out, but you're offering the same offerings, so you're not distinguishing. And you're trying to get a universal attitude. Sometimes the word detached is used, but that makes it rather cold.

But it's a universal attitude that no matter who or what — it could be an animal, whatever is standing in front of you, whatever is there before you — whether you like them or dislike them is irrelevant. You still have the same goodwill towards them. And that's *mettā*. It's also a platform from which all the other relationships towards people arise too.

Because when you have that basic friendship towards somebody, you can see that if they fall into misfortune or they fall ill, compassion arises naturally. You don't have to work at it. You just feel compassionate. You have an attitude of compassion. And in the

same way, if a person has good fortune, wins the lottery and all that, you naturally feel joyful for them. And once that basic goodwill is established, these others arise naturally. You don't have to work at it.

And you'll notice that we have these four basic blessings. The one, to be safe. I mean, that's really fundamental to our human life, to actually feel safe. That's what you want from the government. You want safety from outer attack and safety from economic collapse. That's your basic ground. You want to feel safe. So you're offering people safety, but also safety from dangers that arise within ourselves, from our own angers and so on.

Everybody wants to be well, physically well. You want to be happy. And the last one, which I have used to be contented and in harmony with the world, is also translated as well-being, or to have an ease about your living, to be at ease with it. So those you offer. You offer through all these different stages. And in that way, you build up this universal love, which is not dependent on whether you like somebody or not. And that's really what *mettā* is.

And just to leave you with a final example of the Buddha's own way of expressing it, he talks about the mother. So a mother has four children and to one, occasionally, she's a friend, just a friend, talks. When the child gets sick or when one of the children becomes sick, she tends to that child, so that's the compassion. When one of the children has great success, she feels naturally joyful, her child. And when that child leaves home, there's no clinging on. There's an ability just to let the child go. And that's the other attitude of equanimity, which is another topic.

So I hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be fully liberated sooner rather than later.

Karuṇā - Compassion

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 8 min

In this exploration of karuṇā (compassion), the second of the four brahmavihāra or sublime abodes, Bhante Bodhidhamma offers a nuanced understanding of what true compassion means in Buddhist practice. He defines karuṇā simply as "the desire to alleviate suffering" while distinguishing it from its direct enemy of cruelty and its more subtle obstacles.

The talk examines two particularly insidious forms of false compassion: the "do-gooder" mentality that imposes help without truly understanding what others need, and pity that creates distance and superiority over those who suffer. Through practical examples, including the story of well-intentioned charity that collapsed a local economy, Bhante illustrates how compassion without wisdom can cause harm.

The teaching emphasizes the importance of "stepping into the other person's shoes" through imaginative empathy and asking what they actually need rather than presuming to know. Bhante addresses common obstacles practitioners face, including guilt over limitations and the tendency toward self-cruelty when recognizing our conditioning patterns. As one of the illimitables (appamañña), karuṇā can be developed boundlessly throughout life, requiring clear intention and mindful awareness of our motivations when offering help to others.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

I thought I'd choose this word *karuna*, which translates pretty directly as compassion. Our word gives us some idea of how we should develop that virtue. Our word comes from the Latin, doesn't it? *Patio*, which means I suffer. The *com* is with, to suffer with somebody. You have to be slightly careful about that.

The first thing to say is that the direct enemy of compassion is cruelty. Cruelty is the desire to make somebody suffer. Compassion is defined as the desire to alleviate suffering. It's as simple as that. The desire to alleviate suffering - physical, mental, financial, existential. It's the desire to alleviate suffering.

And it's got a couple of very subtle enemies. That's how the commentaries would put it - near and far enemy. So the near one is cruelty. But the one that's more subtle, the one that we don't see, one of them is the do-gooder. So the do-gooder is somebody who's going to do you the good they want to do you, no matter what you want.

It may be that a friend has fallen ill or something, so you think to yourself, well, I'll go and visit. And I don't know whether people do it these days, but they've got some grapes and Lucozade or something. Some soup. And when you get there, of course, they say, "Oh, I've been really sick. I've just vomited all over the toilet. I can't possibly eat it." I said, "Oh, I'm sorry, it must be very bad." He said, "Could you do me a favour? Do you think you could clean the toilet?" And while you're cleaning it, he said, "I came here with soup and I'm cleaning a blooming toilet."

And what compassion is, is of course to stand in the other person's shoes and to ask them what they want. So you don't go there with some pre-set ideas, some set position of how you're going to help them.

There's a lovely case of that, of a charity in Totnes, that decided to collect clothes and send them to Africa, to this place in Africa. When they got there, the tailor trade collapsed. And with it, the local economy. So they had to pull all the clothes back. It was a case of compassion without wisdom.

So that do-gooding, you have to be careful of that. So it's the case of if you see somebody who needs help, your first question is, what do you want me to do? Then, of course, there can be some bargaining. "I want you to give me £100,000." There might be some bit of bargaining going on before. It's not because they ask something you have to do it. I mean, you've also got to take into consideration your own situation. But that's your starting position. You don't presume that you know what the other person wants. And that undermines this more subtle mistake that we make of being a do-gooder.

The other one is a bit more offensive in a way, and that's pity, isn't it? "Oh, poor thing, you must be suffering. I know how you feel." It's coming from this high position. I mean, consider yourself. If you've fallen over, for instance, and you're there with a broken leg, somebody comes, "Oh, poor thing, must be really hurting." All you want to do is call the ambulance. So this pity distances us from the suffering. It puts us, shall we say, slightly above it. It's a conceit.

So, to undermine that, again, one has to slip into the other person's shoes by way of just an imaginative force, like, if I was in that position, what would I want?

So these different positions, they're in us, all of us are a bit of a do-gooder, a bit of cruelty here and there. And it's a case of just recognising that these are conditionings within us. When they come up and if you find yourself blaming yourself, accusing yourself of cruelty and you could have been more sensitive and all that stuff, then you're being cruel to yourself, being compassionate to yourself. There's a case also of being able to forgive oneself and just to recognise these are all conditionings. And you learn

from those mistakes don't you? So the next time we find ourselves in a similar position one remembers that. So then you make the right intention and the intention is to be with the person who's suffering and ask what they want of you.

In that way you can develop this *karuna*. And *karuna*, this compassion, remember, is one of the illimitables. It's indefinite as to how much it can be developed within you. So long as we're alive and breathing, you can develop *karuna*.

So, I mean, this particular time, it's a time of goodwill, isn't it? Often you get charities come. So there's a stepping into the other person's shoes. And then one does what one can. You don't have to give to every charity that comes along. There's hundreds of millions of them. But it's a case of doing what you can for the other.

There's limitations, aren't there? Just limitations. If you feel guilty about not being able to help people, that's ridiculous. You can only do what you can do. You've only got so much power, so much wealth, so much influence. If somebody is dying of a heart attack and you're not a doctor and you don't know what to do, you can't blame yourself for it. All you can do is witness it, is to be a companion in that suffering, isn't it?

So we have to be, there's all sorts of little mistakes we can make around this area of compassion and it's just a case of making that aware of, making that something that we're aware of and making sure that whenever we want to do something for somebody or give some of our wealth towards somebody, that we have a very clear intention in mind. That's all.

Remember that all our conditionings start with intention. Once you have the right intention, at least that's your main karmic line. *Kamma* here means conditioning. So even though the old stuff may come up, you've not actually reinforced it. So that's the point. And just very slowly one shifts, one moves over.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated sooner rather than later.

Muditā - Pure Joy

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

In this third talk on the brahmavihāras (sublime abodes), Bhante Bodhidhamma explores muditā - sympathetic or reciprocal joy. This beautiful quality of the awakened heart allows us to genuinely celebrate others' happiness and good fortune without falling into envy or jealousy, muditā's obvious enemies.

Bhante explains how to cultivate this practice by first counting our own blessings - recognizing the joys, relationships, and fortunate circumstances that have shaped our lives. He guides us in extending wishes for simple but profound happiness: good sleep, health, safety, meaningful work, loving relationships, spiritual fulfillment, and peaceful death. The talk addresses muditā's subtle enemy - excitement and attachment to joyful states - emphasizing that true muditā remains a quiet, resonant joy rather than over-stimulated elation.

Drawing on modern research about neuroplasticity and the body-mind connection, Bhante reveals how cultivating joy literally rewires our cells to receive more pleasure and strengthens our immune system. He shares practical guidance for integrating muditā into daily life - not just formal meditation but spontaneous moments of wishing others well. This practice, when developed, naturally manifests as the subtle 'Buddha smile' of contentment that arises from complete facial relaxation, creating a continuous state of sympathetic joy that benefits both ourselves and all we encounter.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So, this evening I want to do the third of the Brahma Viharas, which is *mudita*. Remember it's part of the Buddha heart, in other words how the enlightened person actually experiences the world, how they connect with the world rather, how they relate to the world.

So one of them is this *metta*, kindness, gentleness, friendliness, all that sort of stuff. Compassion, which is the desire to help. And there's equanimity which we'll come to next week or next time I come. And there's this joy, this *mudita* which is translated as sympathetic joy or reciprocal joy. It's a joy you feel when somebody else is happy.

And its obvious enemy is envy, envy and jealousy. That kills your own ability to enjoy other people's happiness, to share in their happiness. And, well, I'll come to how we can tackle that. But the near enemy, the one that we don't particularly recognize, is this excitement and that comes by — it's always this business of indulging in what — in a joyful state so you're always lifting the energy above what's necessary. One gets attached to it, you see, so that's always a danger with these things. So one has to remain at the level of just resonance, resonating people's joy and reflecting it back to them.

Looking all pretty good at the moment, I know. I was just wondering what you could do if they weren't joyful. That goes to compassion then, you see. At the moment we're presuming that the person is joyful. And so it's a sort of quiet joy. It's a happy, quiet joy. When you start jumping up and down and all that sort of stuff, then it's sort of a bit over the top.

And with this, when you actually develop it within yourself through the practice like *metta*, then you get the same lovely blissful states that you would with any other concentration meditation. And you'll see for yourself if you're just wishing somebody well within yourself, you'll see it just builds up a very pleasant resonance in the heart.

Now remember when you're doing this practice, and we'll come to the actual practice itself in a minute, you're not trying to feel happy. You're not trying to feel anything. It's always the intention — may you be happy, may your happiness increase, may your happiness not decrease. These sorts of well-wishings are given with the intention of helping the other person to be happy. The fact that we then begin to feel happy, we have to take as a happy consequence. That's the karmic result within our own minds of that sympathetic joy. Then if we start doing it in order to be happy, then we get into this subtle enemy, you see.

It's not something that we particularly practice. We're very good at do-gooding — the compassionate bit — but we don't — there's not that much practice. We're mainly miserable and whingeing. That's what we normally practice — bloody weather and it's always raining and the job and all that. We don't — we don't actually unless there's an occasion like a birthday or something, and then because we tend to go over the top.

So you can get right up to what's known as the third absorption, which is a pretty beautiful state. And remember that these things are known as *Brahmaviharas*, the dwelling place of Brahma. In other words, these are the most beautiful states of mind that we can develop. And they're illimitable, remember, which means that the mind, the heart is not like the physicality which is limited by space and by other contingent things. The mind seems to be able to develop these things indefinitely. It's a bit like number. Remember I always say about numbers — no matter how big the number you

imagine, you always add one. So it's like indefinite, there's no end to it. To say infinite is a little bit too definite. We can't say infinite — would be metaphysical — but indefinite gives it that understanding that there's no need ever to stop it. One can just continue to develop these beautiful states.

Now, how do you do it towards yourself? Well, you start — always start with yourself, you see. So, basically, you count your blessings. You count your blessings. And in counting your blessings and all the lovely things that have happened to us in our lives and the present things that now we enjoy, then we can feel glad for ourselves. We feel happy. We feel happy for ourselves. Even though we might be going through a miserable state, it's a case of looking at the glass as usual as half full. So it's actually just reminding ourselves of the joys that we have experienced in life and the pleasures that have come our way. And the fact that we're living now in not, shall we say, a too uncomfortable state. And it's just recognizing that and recognizing that as a blessing.

Remember, because of this self, because especially of Western ideas, we think that we've arrived at this place through my own efforts. A self-made person. I did my own thing in my own time. But actually, when you look, it's because of all the relationships that we've had, of the particular state the economy's in. Everything is contingent upon our particular happiness. So there's a part of us which is, shall we say, to do with fortune in the sense of being in this particular place at this particular time. It's nothing to do with our *kamma*. It's to do with the fact that we happen to be in a fairly fortunate situation.

So one begins to count one's blessings, and then to wish somebody just very banal things, like good sleep. There's a meditator at the moment with me, and because of not good sleep, you can't get the concentration, you can't really get the energy up — you need sleep. So even to wish somebody good sleep, to wake happily, health, safety, fruitful work, loving relationships, a meaningful spiritual life — what you mean by that is that life has some meaning to it beyond the obvious, beyond the job, beyond the relationship. There's some sort of purpose for life which is as it were beyond the normal things that we're doing.

And then don't forget peaceful death. You don't want to die in agony. Nice peaceful slipping away. And then to offer them either a rebirth in the heavenly realm or that they achieve some spiritual depth. So these are the sorts of things that you would be wishing for somebody else in order to increase their happiness. That's what you do. And you do it to yourself.

Remember, you're always to start — I mean, I know that in our *metta* practice, the way I do it is I put the self a bit further along. That's because really to overcome this, often what I find in people is a lot of negativity. They don't want to offer themselves any love. They feel horrible about themselves. So if you begin to feel nice about other people, then you get that nice feeling up and say, oh, me too. I wish I was like that too. So it's sort of turning the offering towards ourselves.

So this particular state, this *mudita*, sympathetic joy, is one of the illimitables. And we develop it by finding blessings that we know will make ourselves and others happy. And then just like we do the metta, you would do that as well. And remember that these things are not — you don't have to do it in a formal way. You don't have to be sitting in a meditation or you don't have to be sitting anywhere. You'd just be on a bus. You'd be driving along and stop at the lights and just wish somebody happiness. It's like it's just cultivating that constant — cultivating that constant relationship within ourselves with others. And of course it affects us and the way we are, and that affects how people see us, how people relate to us.

When your face is very relaxed, you should feel a natural smile appear on your face. Is that right? Would that be a common experience? No. If you relax your face completely, you'll see that there's just a smile. It comes with just that relaxation. You can almost call that the Buddha smile, that enigmatic smile. It's the smile of contentment. And to other people, it might still look grim because it's so subtle, but it's there within you. It's there within you and that's how you greet people, from that position of joyfulness.

So we'll come to that another time perhaps after this talk, but I do want to now talk about the smile. Just a bit of science really. Even a Richter smile, a smile that you don't mean but you just shape your mouth in a smile, even that affects the brain and begins to release this dopamine and the sort of pleasure system within the brain. And this is research that I read about, and as you know research changes, but what they discovered is that every cell in the body has receptors for these different chemicals. And if a person is constantly depressed and down, the cells actually begin to manufacture more receptors for this downer than it has for this joyful stuff. So that when somebody's depressed, even when joy comes up, the body can't feed that back to them because the body still feels depressed. You might say, you see what I mean? So when you understand that every time you make yourself happy, you're actually encouraging these cells to develop these receptors so you get that feedback from the body of pleasure which is resonating with the actual state of mind.

And with that, you see, the body and the mind always act together. I mean, we do that with the breath — just the gentle motion of the breath, beginning to see it as a pleasurable, neutral sensation, really calms the mind. You calm the mind, calms the body and the breath becomes finer, the breath becomes more subtle and more gentle. So the body and mind are very intimately connected and in this way they sort of tumble down into a deeper concentration, or in this sense they begin to resonate this joy, you see.

And the other effect of that is, remember that these things has an effect on our thymus, it seems. That's another thing, which is to do with our autoimmune system. So often when people are depressed, when they're stressed, etc., that's when you get ill. So somehow we can counteract that by just developing this constant state of kindness and joy, just reminding ourselves of our blessings and just letting that smile appear.

So that's this psychosomatic organism that we're living in, that we're actually inhabiting. And when you connect sympathetic joy, love, compassion, but especially I think this sympathetic joy with physical health, then you really want to start doing it. And as I say, it's more like a little practice every day. I'm always amazed at the power of just five minutes a day of joyful thinking and how it can affect your day. And in the end it becomes a sort of memory thing and you just remember to just make an offering of joy.

Like when you meet people, it's there naturally. When you meet a friend and all that, you're naturally joyful. So that comes naturally. But to actually have that sense of constantly developing it, it just becomes habitual. Just like this mindfulness becomes habitual. I mean, that's our problem. There's no problem in establishing mindfulness. The problem is remembering it, remembering to establish mindfulness. So it's a case of just encouraging ourselves to just do these little practices just often throughout the day. And it has this lovely continuous effect.

So that brings to the end my little homily on *mudita*. I can only hope that my words will increase your own sense of joy. May you be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Summing up the Khandhas

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min

In this concluding talk on the khandhas (five aggregates), Bhante Bodhidhamma brings together the Buddha's systematic deconstruction of human experience. He explores how the Buddha analyzes the present moment through the aggregates - rūpa (form/body), vedanā (feeling), saññā (perception), saṅkhāra (mental formations), and viññāṇa (consciousness) - and as process through paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination).

The talk reveals how each aggregate functions: the body experienced through the four great elements, perceptions growing from basic sense contact to complex concepts, feelings as pleasant/unpleasant/neutral qualities, saṅkhāras encompassing all reactions and proliferations (papañca), and consciousness as the knowing quality. Bhante explains how insight meditation works by making these aggregates objects of observation rather than sources of identification.

Drawing connections to the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta, he shows how the four foundations of Right Awareness correspond to investigating these experiential components. The ultimate purpose is discovering the 'unbounded, unshackled consciousness' - awareness freed from identification with the aggregates. This systematic approach to seeing experience as the Buddha taught it provides the framework for genuine liberation from dukkha.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So this is the final talk in our sequence about the *khandhas*, these aggregates. I want to try and bring everything together and see the reason why the Buddha taught in this way. Remember that his main technique was to deconstruct what we experience. He's always pulling it apart, either as a slice of the present moment or as a process. In terms of the present moment he uses the *khandhas* and also the six consciousnesses. Every consciousness we have must have a base, so it's one of the five senses and the mind itself which is the sixth base. As a process he uses dependent origination.

If we were to follow the *khandhas*, we have the first split away from the body itself. Remember when we talk about the body in terms of insight, we're talking about how the mind experiences the body. So that's when we come across these four great ele-

ments. It's not just moving the body, feeling it moving and things like that. The actual makeup of the body itself is how the body is experienced by the mind, and we come down to these really basic percepts which are these four great elements of fire, earth, water and air, which is temperature, pressure, cohesiveness, elasticity and movement.

So that's one type of experience sectioned off from the next thing, which is the intellect about perception. These perceptions begin at a very basic thing, so what we can say is that at all times there's the actual experience of a sensation coming in at one of the sense doors and a representation of it in the mind. That's your percept, and it's from these percepts which are memories, basically your memory, so you don't have to keep seeing blue and remembering blue. It has this memory perception, and these perceptions grow until they become concepts, at which point they're really beginning to move into the fourth category which is the *saṅkhāra*.

But there's an intermediate stage of these immediate percepts. When the mind begins to perceive them as either pleasant or unpleasant, that's where you've got feeling. These feelings are the quality of the actual original stimulus that's coming into the body, so you're perceiving it as pleasant and unpleasant.

Now when you watch the breath, you see you can just feel it as a gentle sensation, but you can also perceive it as something which has a certain pleasantness to it. At that point it's shifting from just being a neutral feeling, a neutral sensation you might say, to something which is taking on a certain value in terms of pleasantness. At this point you're moving into the area of feeling.

So that's another perception going on. There's the perception of the actual sensation that's coming in and an added perception of how the heart's experiencing it, the heart part of us, the emotional part. The other bit that comes into the body, which the body also feels as a perception, is the mind in the body. The mind in the body has this emotional content, and that's where you get your mental feelings from.

So there are those two types of feelings: physical feelings such as when you stub your foot, and emotional feelings such as when you're feeling happy and excited. These are all, in terms of the Buddha, to be classed as feelings whether they originate from the body or the mind. They're just feelings. The important thing is that they're perceived as either pleasant, unpleasant or neutral. So there's no way we cannot live in a non-dualistic world at that level. All our experience is divided into some degree of pleasantness and some degree of unpleasantness.

The next bit is the *saṅkhāras*, and this is where we have included all our reactions to things, all our conceptualizations, all our emotional life, the higher emotional life. The way it's put is *saññā-saṅkhā-papañca*. So the *saññā* is all the perceptual memories you've got at the intellectual level. The *saṅkhā* refers to all the emotional stuff, and the *papañca* is proliferation. So that's how we proliferate through these basic sensations and perceptions. As you know, it gets extremely complicated – concepts like freedom and democracy and things like that. It begins to move into really very complicated areas. But from the Buddha's point of view, you can always draw it down into one of these categories.

The fifth category is cognition. Now cognition, the way I personally experience it, is that the first level of knowing – it's as though, my own way of explaining it is, it's as though all the information is hitting the screen of the television. And that screen is a position of knowing. It's a point where there's an immediate cognition of what there is. Now the reason that this is made a distinction of is because it's to be separated out from the knowing.

Now the whole process of insight meditation is to make these *khandhas* objects. Normally we're in the *khandha*. The *khandha* is our personhood, our personality, our character – it's all included within that, the *khandhas*. In our meditation, we're pushing them away from us to look at them. In that process of making them objects within ourselves, through our meditation, we're actually beginning to discover this other quality which is the knowing. This knowing has certain qualities about it which is the quality of awareness, which is a type of knowing, and this intelligence.

It's slowly, as it were, shifting our location out of the *khandhas* into this knowing, which is the process of awakening. So long as we're in the *khandhas*, so long as we are identifying with an emotion, identifying with a concept, with an idea, identifying with a person – by which I mean these *khandhas*, identifying with a personality – so long as there's that identity, we're in a different location. When we're meditating and we pull back from that and they become objects to observe, we've found a different location. We've moved house.

Remember the image that the Buddha uses about the house builder: constantly building this house, but I found your ridge pole, I've broken you up and smashed you and all that. It's very violent. He's discovered the unconditional *citta*, the unconditional consciousness. That's all we're doing. We're just slowly beginning to reposition ourselves in this other place.

So that's the reason why the Buddha teaches the *khandhas*, because in your meditation you can actually, as you experience things, you can reflect on that. You don't have to go into a blank when you meditate. You can look and then every so often you can reflect upon what you're experiencing and say, well that's the *khandha*, you see, and this is the way that this knowing knows what it knows.

It's one of these paradoxes that the knowing has to pull itself out of the intellect in order to gain its own independence and its own self-knowledge of itself. It doesn't know itself. It simply thinks that it is thought, it thinks that it is emotion, it thinks that it is the body. By making these things objects, it's discovering a different identity. It's that process which we have to keep reinforcing all the time, which is the process of awakening – awakening to a different level of consciousness.

When it comes to the *Satipaṭṭhāna*, the four places where the Buddha says we have to establish this consciousness, this way of looking, there's four of them. The first one is the body, the second one is feeling, so that's your *vedanā*. The third one is your *citta*, that's the word used here, which is your *saṅkhāra*. And the fourth one is looking at the dhamma, looking at what you experience from the point of view of the dhamma. So that's where you get these five different hindrances, the seven factors of enlightenment, and included in that are these five *khandhas*. Perception is presumed all the way through, and the act of cognition is presumed all the way through. You wouldn't know anything without that primary reflection.

These things can be experienced. It's not as though they are abstract ideas. Meditators can actually experience these different things just pulling themselves apart. You can experience an emotion, for instance, against the body and it separates out from the body itself, so you can see this is an emotion, a mental state which is finer, and the body is resonating. The body is actually mirroring it, but normally we experience it as one thing.

You can actually – there are experiences where you can see the original perception, the original feeling, the perception of the feeling and the cognition as a process, as an immediate constant process. So all these things that the Buddha's talking about are not intellectualizations. They're not something that he's arrived at by just thinking about something because it makes sense to us from a thought point of view. If you haven't experienced these, it's absolutely separate, but they can actually be directly experienced.

So it's the same with dependent origination. It's not something that he's intellectualized or conceptualized out of human experience as such. It's something that you can actually see in your meditation.

So remember that the Buddha has two purposes in his teaching, one of which he really stresses. It's the negative side, the bit about suffering, unsatisfactoriness, and how we achieve our misery. And the other part is the end of suffering, just the end of suffering. This end of suffering is called *Nibbāna*, it's called the unconditioned, the unborn. He's got various ways of pointing to it, and he talks about it also, remember, as the unbounded, unshackled consciousness.

Unshackled consciousness. What's it unshackled from? It's unshackled from various things, but it's mainly unshackled from its identity with these five *khandhas*. So that's your purpose in your meditation and the purpose of knowing these various ways, because it's as though in the Buddha's deconstruction of human experience, by looking at it that way, you're closer to seeing what he's actually asking you to see.

Whereas if you were to use, shall we say, a Freudian model, so you'd be looking for your superego, your ego and your id, which is fine – you find things, it makes sense – but would it lead you to liberation? This is the point. So what I would say is if you want to be sure that you're on the path to liberation, the path to awakening, then you've got to start seeing the world the way the Buddha sees it, which doesn't particularly negate other ways of seeing it. They may be complementary, who knows. But we definitely have to begin to see the way the Buddha saw things, and then we begin through our meditation to experience that.

I think that brings my little homily for the evening to an end. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated from all suffering by observing the *khandhas* sooner rather than later.

1. Avijjā - Not-Knowing

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 8 min

In this opening talk on paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines avijjā - often translated as ignorance but better understood as simple 'not-knowing.' Through a vivid monastery story about flies and spiders, he illustrates how our innocent lack of understanding leads to presumptions that create unnecessary suffering.

Bhante explains that avijjā isn't a moral failing but an innocent mistake we all begin with as children, absorbing cultural conditioning without true understanding. This not-knowing creates the fundamental error of identifying with what we experience, leading to the full spectrum of human suffering including depression, anxiety, guilt and shame.

The talk explores how vipassanā meditation works through two parallel processes: developing wisdom that undermines our original mistake of identity, and purification that allows emotional states to exhaust themselves naturally. This dual path leads from ignorant innocence through suffering to wisdom within a purified heart - an immaculate state that reconnects with the world through love, compassion and joy. A hopeful foundation for understanding how awakening unfolds through dependent origination.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

The word I'd like to tackle tonight is this word *avijjā*. It's one of these core words. *Ā* means not and *vijjā* means knowledge, and it's translated unfortunately as ignorance. But the word ignorance has a sort of pejorative feel about it, like you're stupid or you're culpable. But this is just basically not-knowing. I did come across a word in the dictionary and I thought I might use that, but I don't think everybody knows it. So it's this quality of not-knowing right at the beginning.

I mean, what do we know as children? As a baby, what do we know? We don't know anything. And then it all piles in: the culture, the language, the habits of our parents, then the school, and everything just piles in. And is it any wonder that we presume that this is what we are? This is definitely, phenomenally what we are.

But let me give you an example of what this ignorance is, because what it does is it presumes. We've got to be careful here—it's not an evil thing. It's just a simple matter of, well, this must be right.

I had a hut in the monastery I was at. I call it a *kuti*. A hut, unfortunately, doesn't give you the right impression—it was a proper brick-built little building with its own toilet. And one year, somehow these little flies came in called *hopatua*. Tiny little flies. And the disturbing thing about them was that they got through the mosquito net. And when they bit, they left this little pimple that itched for about three days, or it did for me. And it slowly drives you mad, even though you're meditating—it slowly drives you mad.

And I used to regularly evict all the spiders from my room. But then it occurred to me that, no, I need these spiders. They, in fact, would eat these flies. So I allowed the spiders to come in. And I ended up with lots of these spider webs, and some of them were big spiders. And to my horror, the place got more and more filled with these little flies. And it came to a point when I was actually considering leaving and going to another monastery. It was just becoming unbearable.

And there was another monk in the western room, a Canadian, staying at the monastery, been there for longer than me. And he came along one day and I told him, I said, I'm on the point of leaving. I can't handle these flies. And he looked around and he said, "It's these cobwebs. They breed on cobwebs." So I of course immediately evicted all the spiders and burnt joss sticks, and the whole situation became bearable again.

But that for me was a prime example of what happens when you don't know and you presume, and you end up with more suffering than you expected.

So this *avijjā*, this *avijjā* that we suffer from is just a very simple state of not-knowing. And then we move into this position of given knowledge and there's a presumption that this is what we are, what I believe, this is me, this is mine. And it's a mistake—it's just a mistake. And because we begin from that position of not-knowing, from an intellectual or from an understanding point of view, from the heart's point of view we begin from a position of innocence. So it's just a mistake, an innocent mistake.

But unfortunately, it does end up with depression, anxiety, guilt, shame, and all the rest of the whole gamut of human suffering. And at some point, one says, "I've got to meditate." So you end up in a meditation hall trying to get rid of this stuff.

And then the process comes back on itself. The process comes back on itself, where you realize—as you go deeper and deeper into yourself, you're getting close to the original mistake, which is to do with an identity, an identity of being a human being. That's what we think we are. As we undo that, there are two processes going on.

The process of *vipassanā* is a process of understanding where the mistake lies. So that's why we're looking at this business of impermanence, the business of how we relate to things by way of grasping or owning, wanting and identifying, and how we have

a deeper identity with what we're experiencing. And by undoing that, we're beginning to understand what we really are. But the other process that's going on is that we're having to deal with all these emotional states that come up. And we begin to realize that by just allowing them to express themselves as mental states, as emotional states, they're actually exhausting themselves. That's why we come off the dream, because it's through dreams that they develop.

And so these two processes—of the understanding is undermining this original mistake, and the process of purification is undermining and going back upon the product of that mistake, even though it was done innocently. So the end process that we're moving towards is a point of understanding, which we call wisdom. And from the heart's point of view, the purification takes us back to the beginning of that innocence. But it's now not an ignorant and not-knowing innocence. It's now a wisdom within a purified heart, an immaculate heart. And that's the end of the process when we reach death.

So the process that we're going through, or have been through, is from a point of ignorance into a mistake which has caused us problems. And we undo those problems and come to a point of wisdom. From the heart's point of view, we've innocently made a mistake, and we have all the problems that come from that mistake, including guilt and shame and all that. And then as we undermine that, we return to a purified heart. This purified heart is then an energy, a form of energy, which then reconnects with the world. And that reconnection we call love. And that love has its various forms of compassion and joy.

So we should be hopeful. We should practice with joy, knowing that there is an end to this process. So I hope my words have been of some use to you. May you be fully liberated sooner rather than later.

2. Nāma-Rūpa: Body-Mind

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 7 min

In this teaching on paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines nāma-rūpa, the body-mind complex that marks our entry into existence. He explains how nāma (mind/name) and rūpa (form/body) represent two distinct yet interdependent energies, with the mind arising multiple times within each material moment.

Using practical meditation examples like watching the breath and experiencing pain, Bhante demonstrates how vipassanā practice involves deconstructing our experience to distinguish between bodily sensations and mental interpretations. He illustrates this with the example of eating pizza—how the tongue provides mere sensations while the mind creates concepts, memories, and emotional reactions.

This separation reveals a crucial insight: we cannot find a substantial 'self' in either component, yet body and mind remain intimately connected—physical sensations trigger mental reactions, and mental states produce bodily responses. Understanding this interdependence forms the first two insights in vipassanā meditation and establishes the foundation for investigating the insubstantial nature of human experience. This teaching provides essential groundwork for deeper exploration of the Buddha's analytical approach to awakening.

So carrying on with these words, look at these two words called *nāma* and *rūpa*. *Nāma* refers to mind and it comes right through to our language through Latin, *nomen*, *nat*—the word name actually comes from the word *nāma*. So it's basically referring to the mind. And *rūpa*, actually its definition is really more to do with form, appearance, but basically it's the body. And it's understood that these are two different energies, two different forms of energy we can say. So that in later works it was said that in one material moment the mind arose 17 times. So there were 17 consciousnesses within the arising of one particular material moment. But we needn't worry too much about that.

It begins in the dependent origination as you know. As we go through it, the first of coming into this life is this *nāma-rūpa*—there's a split there, it's the body and mind. And in terms of the process of insight, in terms of the process of awakening, remember that the Buddha's main technique is this process of deconstructing what we are. It's looking at our experience and trying to find out its components to see whether any of these components or parts actually constitute anything real, anything substantial, something that doesn't arise and pass away basically.

So the first thing in our meditation is to make this distinction between this is the body, this is the mind, and to see them as two very separate perceptions. So when you're watching the breath there's the rising and falling of the body—the abdomen is rising and falling, that's physicality—and the actual naming of it rising and falling or the seeing of it is to do with the mind.

When you actually look at the breath a bit more closely, you may find that the mind is also constructing the whole process. So there's an image of the stomach in the mind for a start. If you're watching it there, if you're watching it at the nostrils, it's the nostrils. And there's also this whole idea that something's rising and falling. So where does that come from? It comes from the mind actually contacting the body and through its own processes, feeling that rising and falling process. But actually what's coming from the body is just sensations, just sensations.

So it's when you look at pain, so you might feel discomfort in your sitting. What part of it is the mind and what part is the body? So as you contact it and you're saying, pain, pain, the very word pain is coming from the mind. So as you go into the pain, you begin to discover its various constituents. It might just be heat, it might be pressure, it might be some other things. So you recognise that the pain is a mental construct. What the body is giving is just sensations. And when you react to pain, you're not reacting to the body, you're reacting to your concept about what the sensations are. So it's that breaking up of our experience to trying to find out whether there's anything substantial. Where's the self? When I talk about me, where is it?

When we're eating, you see. So to make a distinction between the actual taste coming from the tongue and the delight that arises in the heart. Most times when we eat, it's just all one experience. So as you put the food on your tongue, there's sensations arising. But then somehow when these sensations come into the mind, the mind immediately distinguishes it as pizza or something. But actually the taste has nothing to do with pizza. The taste is either salty or tomatoey or whatever it is. But it's not pizza. The mind says it's pizza. I mean, it's seen it, of course, but I'm just saying if you hadn't seen it and just put it in your tongue, then the mind would recognise these things as pizza. It's coming from its own memory bank.

But more than that, it's reacting. So I don't know about you, but if I eat pizza, I feel delightful. It's just a natural occurrence. Because in the past, I've always had this pizza and it's always made me delighted. It's very simple. But the delight is nothing to do with the pizza. It's to do with my relationship with the pizza. If I didn't like pizza, I wouldn't feel happy.

So it's making that distinction, it's actually pulling things apart that we begin to realise that this whole experience that we're having is not a me, it's a construct, it's a compendium of things that we put together into a concept, an actual experiential concept, and then we make the mistake of taking it as me.

Now there are two distinctions to be made. Once we've separated out this body and mind, once we've become clear that there is the body which is offering sensations, full stop, that's all it can do, and this is the mind which is interpreting it and reacting to it and has a relationship with it, it's then recognising that there's some relationship going on, that the one arises dependent on the other.

So when you put food on the tongue, the mind reacts. If you don't put food on the tongue, the mind doesn't react. It just doesn't happen. When the mind moves, the body moves. So as soon as you get an angry thought, there's something happens in the body. It reacts with heat. As soon as you have a fearful thought, it reacts with certain sensations, a wobbliness or a weak at the knees or nausea or whatever.

So it's also catching that relationship between the body and mind that they are two separate things and yet you cannot actually separate them because they're both firing off the other at the same time. And this insight is the beginning of the process of investigating this human phenomena to see whether there's anything actually substantial within it. So in terms of the process of insight through the vipassanā these are your first two insights and it's this what raises the curiosity to go into it more deeply.

So nāma-rūpa, this body and mind, are really the beginning of your practice. That's what you're asked to do. The beginning of your practice is to make this very clear distinction in ourselves.

I can only hope that this little homily has brought amazing insight. May you be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Salāyatana, Vedanā, Phassa: Six Senses, Contact, Feeling

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 12 min

In this third installment on paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the next three links that operate automatically once we have a body-mind complex (nāma-rūpa): the six sense spheres (salāyatana), contact (phassa), and feeling (vedanā). He explains how the six senses—including the mind (mano) as the sixth sense—create distinct spheres of experience (āyatana) that cannot interfere with each other. The teaching explores how contact arises when object, sense base, and consciousness come together, leading to the crucial formation of vedanā—our automatic categorization of experience as pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. Drawing from the Majjhima Nikāya, Bhante illustrates how we can only know attributes of things, not things in themselves, through our physical and psychological processes. Using practical meditation examples like working with pain and itching, he demonstrates how mindful attention can deconstruct our usual perceptions, revealing the impermanent, process-based nature of experience. This understanding helps practitioners recognize the three characteristics of existence and see through the illusion of a controlling self, as these automatic processes arise from past karma rather than present volition.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa — homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

Last time we tackled this *nāma-rūpa*, the body-mind complex. And we said something about *āyatana*, I think. So I just want to do the next three links, because that completes the part of the dependent origination that we don't actually have control of. It's automatic.

Once you've got a body and mind, you have these senses, and there are six senses. So there's the five that we know of and the mind itself. When Buddhism talks about the mind itself, it uses a special word, *mana*. And it's really talking about that bit where whatever stimuli are coming in through the senses, somehow it's being put on a screen and it's being collected. But it also refers to the stuff that comes up in the mind itself as memory and emotion.

So the idea is that the senses themselves have not only a base on the retina, and we know also in the brain, but also in the mind itself, which is separate from the brain. And this word *āyatana* is a sphere, so you can't have one sphere interrupting with another. So you can't hear through your eyes. Now I know there's such a thing as synesthesia where people smell numbers and stuff like that. But that's happening elsewhere. Actually on the sense base you can only see through the eye, full stop. And this word *āyatana* is a sphere of experience. So people who are blind simply don't have the sphere of experience of colours and sights. And it's an important word because when he's describing Nibbāna, just as an aside, he uses the word *āyatana*. It's a sphere, a sphere of experience.

And they talk about the inner and outer. So the outer part is the actual object. And the inner part is the sense base. So there's an object and a sense base which, as you know, arise on the retina or at the eardrum. But it's still based upon the object from outside. So, in this sense, Theravada is a sort of qualified realism. It doesn't deny that things outside us exist. But what it says is we can only know what we know through our physical and psychological processes. So it's a sort of, you could almost call it a qualified idealism as well, that all you can know is what your consciousness knows, and it can only know what it receives through the senses. So you can't know things in themselves, you can only know the attributes of something. And that's quoted straight from the Majjhima Nikāya: Each of the five faculties owns a different sphere and none of them partake of the spheres of another. And they have mind as their support. Without the mind, the ideal is easy. Simple as that.

So then we have this next step on dependent origination which is the contact. So this is the point, the Buddha here is describing the point where we come to know something. So the body and mind and the five senses are the instruments with which the contact is made. And for this contact to happen there has to be an object. It has to be a sense base and there has to be consciousness. Now this consciousness, this *viññāṇa*, remember is the same consciousness that we get in the five *khandhas*, the five heaps, which is that basic act of cognition.

And it's obviously a very complex thing because it not only picks up say of this chair — it not only picks up the colors and the shape of the chair but it also understands what it is the chair so there's other things going on in the mind which eventually lets you know that a chair is there and it's to be sat upon. And that's all part of that process. But it begins at a very simple base of the photons hitting the eye.

And when they talk about that, when the scriptures talk about that at the actual five sense basis, that's where the mind contacts matter and it only knows it, it would seem, in these four ways: earth, water, fire and wind. I always get the sequence wrong. So earth is the sense of pressure, of weight, things like that. Water is congealing magnetism — it's what draws together, it's what keeps, it's what turns wheat into dough. Sometimes in the breath you can feel it — you feel like an elasticity and that's the water element. Fire is heat, of course, and here remember that photons would be considered a fire element. And wind is movement.

So picking up on those qualities, the mind then forms a concrete picture in the mind of what it is. So we know that, don't we? It's amazing how all that's happening at the eardrum is this tapping. It really is, it's just a tapping and yet it's taken in and it turns into a sound. It's quite remarkable.

And then when we get that, I should have also mentioned that of course when it comes to emotions, that's a physical contact. Emotions manifest in the body as feelings, as this contact. And at some point there's a definition of what we're experiencing as either pleasant, unpleasant or neutral. At that point it becomes *vedanā* — feeling.

So what *vedanā* is, is a perception of the hedonistic value of what you're experiencing, whether it's pleasant, unpleasant or neutral. So it doesn't change what you're actually experiencing, it's just your perception of it, an internal decision as to whether it's pleasant or unpleasant. And you can't stop living in that dualistic world. So the world is always going to be experienced either as pleasant or unpleasant. And even when we say neutral, when you really go into the neutral, the neutral feelings, you find it splits one way or the other into pleasant and unpleasant. So you can't go beyond that. That is given. That's a given. And it gives it a feeling coloration to what we're actually experiencing.

So let's take for instance in the sitting you might get pain in the knee. As that sensation comes into consciousness we begin to realise it's pain. So pain is a feeling that we are now experiencing as unpleasant. It's an unpleasant feeling. Now forgetting the next stage, which is usually a reaction or resistance to it, let's just go straight into it, supposing it's not a pain that you have any problem with.

So now as you bury your attention into the pain, it's as though you flip, it's as though you go from a barrier of whether it's likeable or unlikeable into just pure feeling, pure sensation. And at this point, you begin to experience pain as sensation and you can deconstruct it. You can say, oh, there's a bit of pressure there, there's a bit of heat there. And at that point, your attention, your consciousness has come right slap bang up against matter.

And in your meditation, you can play around with that. You can, at one minute, perceive it as pressure, as pressure and heat. And next minute, by just pulling back off, you can see this clicking in as pain. And just to be able to play around with that sometimes.

Like an itch. An itch is a sort of funny thing because it's neither pleasant nor unpleasant unless you scratch it. But as you go into it, it's quite, you go beyond the idea of an itch into these very sharp little pointy sensations.

So, remember that the whole idea of splitting up our, or of experiencing our, what we experience in this way, in this sort of deconstructed way, is to undermine the idea that this is a self, that this is some body. And what we begin to realize is it's just this process that happens in time. And once it's perceived and gone, that's it. It's finished. The process begins again. And there's nobody there. You don't need somebody to create pain in the knee. You can just bang it on a chair and the pain will arise. And pleasant feelings arise, unpleasant feelings arise, in meditation especially, and you haven't called for them, they just arise themselves.

And it's that sense of not being in control of these things that mirror back to us that maybe this isn't me, not me, not mine. So that brings us really to the point of dependent origination, which is a given. And that's also, remember, when we say it's a given, it's also something which is the product of the past. It's a product of what's happened in the past. So there's your *kamma* coming in in this present moment.

Now, not entirely dependent, because as you know, your eye base, the retina, is dependent on your genetics. You can't say that's my personal *kamma*, because that's been brought up through generations. If you haven't got good eyesight like me, you're just stuck with it. That's not because in the past life I was poking somebody's eyes out. So this whole thing becomes quite complicated. But in a sense, to complicate it is sometimes to miss the point. Because what liberates us is seeing these three characteristics. So when we see the impermanence of it, we see it as a process. And when we see it as not me, not mine, because we're distanced from it, because it's become an object of attention, that's what liberates us. That's what liberates us.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

4. Taṇhā Upādāna Bhava — Craving, Grasping, Becoming

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 10 min

In this fourth talk on paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines three pivotal links that explain how we create and perpetuate suffering. After contact (phassa) and feeling (vedanā), we encounter taṇhā — craving or thirst that manifests as both wanting and not-wanting. This is followed by upādāna (grasping), where the sense of 'I' emerges and suffering truly begins, and bhava (becoming), where the will (cetanā) creates kamma through the act of becoming a self.

Bhante explains that while taṇhā remains merely potential — a movement of resistance or indulgence in the mind — it becomes suffering only when the self-identity enters through upādāna. He emphasizes the crucial gap between vedanā and upādāna, where taṇhā offers practitioners the opportunity to recognize unwholesome desires and let them pass away rather than falling into identification.

This teaching provides essential insights for both formal meditation practice and daily life awareness. By understanding this sequence — 'wanting, I, get' rather than 'I want, I get' — practitioners can develop the mindfulness needed to interrupt the cycle of saṅkhāra (volitional conditioning) formation. Bhante emphasizes that recognizing this process allows us to gradually transform our personality by choosing wholesome responses over habitual reactive patterns.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāśambuddhassa namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāśambuddhassa namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāśambuddhassa

So just to continue the words that the Buddha used in dependent origination. We went through the first parts which are basically to do with how we enter into every moment with this ignorance, this not knowing, and it creates these saṅkhāras which are the conditions that we end up manufacturing through this misunderstanding. And there's the given—there's consciousness which is that point of cognition and the body-mind complex and those two, remember, work on each other. The Buddha said they're like two sheaves of hay leaning against each other; the one can't arise without the other.

And then we have what the body and mind, what the constituents are, the *nāma*, the *saḷāyatana*, the six senses, and with that we make contact. This contact has an object, it has a sense base, and it has that consciousness we're talking about. And then we give it

a tone colour, a feeling colour, whether it's pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. So that's what you enter each moment with, as it were. That's your given, that's your *vipāka*, that's the product of past action.

Now, this is where the ignorance now strikes again, as it were, underneath the whole problem and produces a certain relationship to what we find as pleasant and unpleasant, and that's your *taṇhā*. So this *taṇhā* is translated as craving, which is sometimes a little bit too strong for these little desires we have. But we include things like addictions and compulsive behaviours in this *taṇhā*. And some people translate it as lack, a sense of lack, like you've got a big hole, you've got to fill it up. A thirst, another translation you'll come across. But the usual one you get is craving.

And what that is telling us again is just what our relationship to something is. And the relationship, remember, is always based on this wrong understanding of seeking happiness in the wrong place, perfect happiness. So that's your *taṇhā*. And that should become pretty straightforward when you meditate, because when something comes up, you'll see your reaction. And remember, it's not always craving in a sense of wanting something—it's not wanting something, too. So you get resistance and indulgence, resistance and indulgence. So that's your hate-love dichotomy of life.

And it's at this point that the duality begins to hurt. We live in a dual world in the sense that it's a multi-complex world, but as soon as we enter into it with this duality of wanting-not-wanting, then it becomes a very unpleasant place for us. In meditation we're able to see that quite clearly.

But the next step, *upādāna*, is the point where we lose it, where we actually drop into that desire. That's the becoming of a self, that's the self, the I. And the Buddha actually calls the *khandhas*—remember, the five *khandhas* that we talked about, which are the body, perceptions, feelings, these conditional volitions and consciousness—he called them the *upādāna khandhas*, the grasping *khandhas*.

And the thing about this *upādāna* is that once you enter into it, the I, the self becomes, and that's the point of suffering actually. The *taṇhā* in meditation we can see is just a desire in the heart, wanting and not wanting, but so long as it's an object, so long as we're quite distinct from it, it's not actually *dukkha*, it's not suffering. The suffering comes with the self, with the identity with that wanting. It's a very lovely little subtle point to grasp. And once the I has gone in there—I have actually seen it, this sucking into an object—but it's very difficult to stop. Then the impulsion, the pushing into that wanting, a power.

While it's *taṇhā*, while it's just desire, it only remains potential. Nothing's happened. It's just a movement in the mind of resisting or indulging. But nothing's actually happened. But as soon as the I gets in there, then as I say it's very difficult to stop the next one, which is *bhava*, the becoming. It's at this point that the will comes in and that's your *cetanā*. And the Buddha says your *cetanā*, your will which is a power, is your *kamma*, meaning your action—not your *kamma* in the common ordinary sense of that word that's used in English meaning your comeuppance. *Kamma* here is an act. And the act is the becoming of a self again. So *bhava*.

So every time we fall into the I and do something out of the position of an I, we're becoming. And that of course is the world of *saṃsāra*. So these three words the Buddha tries to capture that whole business of how we create suffering and how we continue to create suffering and the process that we go through.

And you'll see that it's the opposite of language. Language normally say, "I want, I scream." But actually, I scream, want, I. And as soon as you get I, get. And that's it. That sequence—to see that sequence is to see more and more clearly where the escape is. If there was no desire before the I, then the escape would be really exceedingly difficult because you'd have to catch this identity extraordinarily quickly. But because between the *vedanā*, what we like and dislike, and the I, there lies this potential that we call *taṇhā*, the craving, the wanting, the not wanting, it gives us that—if we can see that—it gives us that gap in our experience.

And that's really where we can begin to change ourselves, because when we see that *taṇhā*, this craving, call it that, is unwholesome, we can let it pass away, we can let it drop away. And in so doing, remember, it's undermining a habit of craving. And that is what our *saṅkhāras* are, our conditional, volitional conditioning. It's like these huge circles, they're little circles within this greater circle of dependent origination, all bits feeding off each other.

And there are times when we can see that the desires that come up are actually wholesome. They might have a touch of I in it, but the point is that they're wholesome. And by actually putting our will into that, then obviously that's changing our personality.

So those three little links are where the Buddha explains how we carry on creating these *saṅkhāras*, these volitional conditionings based on this ground of not knowing, of ignorance, of delusion. So not only in meditation but in daily life, as soon as you see that "I want" come up, that wanting come up, if we can just stop at that moment and

just catch the craving before we do something, that's where we've got the power to change ourselves. Every time we miss it, we're either reinforcing an old conditioning which may be unwholesome, or starting a new one, which may also be unwholesome.

So it's a case of bringing this type of mindfulness into virtually everything we do. And in this way, we slowly change ourselves. And I think one of the things we come across is the power of these old desires. They're very, very strong, much stronger than we think they are.

So, that's it. I hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be fully liberated from all your *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*, sooner rather than later.

Paṭicca Samuppāda: Dependent Origination to Saṃsāra

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 9 min

In this concluding talk on paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the final links of the twelve-fold chain: bhava (becoming), jāti (birth), jarā-maraṇa (aging and death), and the resulting suffering of soka, parideva, dukkha, domanassa, and upāyāsa (sorrow, lamentation, pain, grief, and despair).

Bhante presents two complementary interpretations of this foundational teaching. The traditional three-life view, found in Buddhaghosa's Visuddhimagga, sees avijjā (ignorance) and saṅkhāra (volitional formations) as karmic inheritance from past lives, with viññāṇa as the relinking consciousness that carries conditioning between lifetimes. The present-moment interpretation understands each link as occurring within immediate experience, where every moment contains its own arising, duration, and passing away.

The talk emphasizes that both understandings point toward the same goal: liberation from saṃsāra through the development of wisdom (vipassanā) and virtue (sīla). Bhante explains how mindful awareness of our intentions allows us to abandon unwholesome actions while cultivating wholesome ones, while insight practice cuts through the fundamental delusion that perpetuates the wheel of dependent origination. This integration of ethical conduct and wisdom forms the heart of the Buddha's path to ending suffering.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa —
Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

We were doing all the words to do with the *paṭiccasamuppāda*, dependent origination. Some people translate that, remember, as interdependent origination. And we've been through the *avijjā*, the words we did was *avijjā*, *saṅkhāra*, *viññāṇa*, *nāmarūpa*, *saḷāyatana*, *phassa*, *vedanā*, *taṇhā*, *upādāna* and *bhava* and they translate or are translated as ignorance, intentional activities or volitional conditionings, consciousness, mind and matter, sixfold sense base, contact, feeling, craving, grasping and becoming.

And then we're going through just the last bit which is *bhavapaccayā jātī*. So there, in a sense, it's a bit of a repetition because the *bhava*, the becoming, is then described as the *jāti*, *jarā* and *marāṇa*, so birth, ageing and death. *Jāti*, birth, *jarā*, ageing, *marāṇa* and death. And the rest of it, *soka*, *parideva*, *dukkha*, *domanassa*, really all the Buddha

is saying that this leads to the whole gamut of human suffering. It translates as sorrow, lamentation, pain, grief and despair. So people have tried to make some sense out of the order of that, but it's not. I think he's just saying, look, when you behave like this, basically you're creating misery, and that's about it.

Now, what we have to do this evening is just recognise that there are two interpretations to this particular teaching, dependent origination. The traditional one is to do with three lives. So when we are born, we come into this life with the first two parts, the *avijjā*, which is your basic ignorance, your basic delusion, and all the conditioning that you've gained from your previous lives. And remember that, really, that's your *kamma*. So the mental states, the potential mental states that you're born with, the seeds that are already there within consciousness, within the mind, are your *kamma*. That's what you're born with into this present life. This is the three life theory.

And then you pass through this life, turning this wheel. And remember, we're not always turning the wheel. When we're asleep, there's no *paṭiccasamuppāda*. And so it's not as though it's always there. But every time there's an act of volition, which is based on greed, hatred, or this essential delusion, then the wheel turns. And what it's doing is, it's reinforcing conditioning. And you may even be starting some new stuff. Why not? Well, we're at it. If we're going to create misery, we may as well get in there and have a good go.

And this leads us to this *bhava*, which just means this continuous becoming, translated also as *saṃsāra*, the world of ever going on, no end to it. And then when we die, then that process of being born, growing old and dying starts again. So the last bit in a future life is really saying that this wheel of dependent origination is just going to keep going, just going to keep going. So those are your three life theory, which is your traditional one. That's the one you'll get from Buddhaghosa in his book, *The Path of Purification*. And in that particular teaching, the *viññāṇa* that they're talking about right at the beginning there, that consciousness that we were relating to, is the relinking consciousness which moves from one life to the next. So it's an actually specific definition of that *viññāṇa*.

But as we mentioned before, there's also a present moment understanding of this teaching in which the *avijjā-saṅkhāra* is the platform upon which every moment is sitting. It's sitting on the delusion, this misunderstanding, and all the *saṅkhāras*, all these volitional conditionings, as conditionings ready to be activated given the right stimulus. So they're often referred to as those conditionings, the set conditionings they lie there as potential. Then with every moment there arises the potential again of some action.

And if it's arising out of this base, if it's arising out of that base, then you get this turning of dependent origination. In which case, the *jāti jarāmaṇaṃ* is referring back onto this present moment, that each moment has a beginning to it, it has a process to it, and it has an end to it. So the wheel as it were, these three wheels are turning within themselves. So there's this basic wheel of delusion feeding into the conditioning as a potential, then there's this active feed down into this already present potential conditioning of the actions we are doing, and this produces, in every moment, a beginning, a middle and an end. And that's, in short, the understanding of *paṭiccasamuppāda* as a present moment experience.

So it's up to you, really, which one you put the accent on. In terms of traditional teachings, they would emphasise the three lives. But in terms of our practice, our daily practice, and what we're trying to do is escape this wheel, then I think it makes more sense to see it as a moment-to-moment experience. But that's not to deny the three-life theory, because, of course, when we do die, all those conditionings are carried over onto the next life. And that's really where our *kamma* is.

Often we think of *kamma* as something coming at us from the outside, but actually it's the inner part of ourselves because that's where we experience suffering. Just because somebody shouts at you, you stupid bald-headed monk, heaven forbid, then heaven forgive them. Just because somebody shouts at you doesn't mean that it hurts you, you know, sticks and stones hurt my bones and all that. But how we react to that is our suffering, our *kamma*.

And the whole of the Buddhist teaching, as far as I can see, is about putting an end to this dependent origination. That's your *saṃsāra*. All the teachings are about trying to bring that to an end, undercutting it and remember that the undercutting has these two sides. First of all through action so by constantly noting our intentions, letting go of those that are undermining us, unwholesome, leading to more suffering and reinforcing those that are not, that are actually leading to virtue, there is that active change.

But underneath that there has to be this *vipassanā* which is cutting into the basic delusion which is creating the whole problem. So remember the growth of wisdom and the growth of virtue must run concurrent in the spiritual life. You can't have the one without the other.

And that, I think, brings to an end my small dhamma bites, my little discussions on the dependent origination, *paṭiccasamuppāda*. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated sooner rather than later.

Another Model of Paṭicca Samuppāda

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 14 min

In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents a transformative perspective on paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination) that reveals the path from suffering to liberation. Beginning with the traditional twelve-link chain—from avijjā (ignorance) through saṅkhāra (volitional formations) to jarāmaraṇa (aging and death)—he demonstrates how this process operates moment by moment through our sensory contact and reactive patterns.

The Buddha's profound insight that 'suffering itself is the cause for the end of suffering' forms the heart of this teaching. Through yoniso manasikāra (wise reflection), we develop saddhā (confidence) that naturally leads to kusala kamma (skillful actions). This creates a positive spiral: gladness arises, deepening into pīti (rapture), passaddhi (tranquillity), and sukha (happiness), providing the foundation for samādhi (concentration) and vipassanā (insight).

Bhante explains how investigation into the three characteristics—anicca (impermanence), dukkha (unsatisfactoriness), and anattā (not-self)—leads to gradual disenchantment with seeking happiness in conditioned phenomena. This process culminates in moments of liberation that mirror the ultimate freedom of Nibbāna, slowly undermining the āsavas (mental outflows) that bind us to suffering.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa (x3)

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened One.

I want to make one more talk devoted to Dependent Origination, really looking at another model. If I go through the model, then you'll see that it offers a slightly different perspective.

Remember that we begin with this *avijjā*, ignorance. We start from the platform of not knowing, but this not knowing produces a certain delusion. A delusion is the wrong way of looking at something. Because of that, we've created in the past these *saṅkhāras*. *Saṅkhāras* are basically all our habits. The important thing is that they've been produced by an act of will. In other words, we produce them. We don't particularly produce what we see - it's just natural to the body, natural to the sense base. But what you do with what you see is within your power.

These two things - the fundamental not knowing, the delusion, and the habits - are running concurrently beneath every moment. Then within every moment you've got to have this basic trilogy. The first one is the potential of cognition, which is the primary act of knowing, and this doesn't happen unless you've got a body and mind. The two lean against each other. Because there's a body and mind, you've got your six sense bases. There's your basic human being, and it's through that that you make contact with the world.

That's your first active moment - contact. There has to be an object, there has to be a sense base, and there has to be that act of cognition. From there you've got your basic sensations, and then we divide the world into what we like, what we don't like, and there's an area of neutrality. But if you look at that more closely, it always shades off into liking and not liking. That's what we might call the basic duality of the world, but that's not suffering.

It's at the next point that these *saṅkhāras*, these volitional conditionings, begin to rise in the form of desires, and that's your *taṇhā*. There's another word in Pali, *chanda*, which means a good desire, such as desire to meditate. But *taṇhā* is a word specific to those desires which arise out of delusion.

Out of that, the next moment is that moment of identity, self. That's the point actually where you start suffering - the point where you identify with what it is you want. As soon as you've done that, it's almost impossible to stop the energy going into that process which is going to make it come out of a potential desire into some form of action, and that's your becoming, that's your *kamma*. As soon as you act, there has to be a beginning of the action, the middle section, and the end of it. That's your birth, aging and death.

That's your fundamental dependent origination rolling on every so often. Not all the time. It's only when it's activated through this desire. It obviously doesn't happen when you're asleep. It doesn't happen in neutral actions either. But that doesn't mean to say that the fundamental delusion isn't there. That's running constantly underneath every moment of our lives.

All this produces suffering. The Buddha says, *dukkha* - that's the *dukkha*. The Buddha says that it's because of suffering that we seek the end of suffering. That might be pretty obvious, but it's because we don't want to suffer that we begin to seek the end of suffering. So suffering itself is the cause for the end of suffering.

The way this comes about is through three things. First of all, wise reflection. The Buddha is very keen on this *yoniso-manasikāra* - that every so often you actually look back upon your actions and work out what we've done which is harmful to ourselves. In a sense, that's the action of conscience. Interestingly enough, there's no word in Pali for our word conscience, but that's another talk.

This wise reflection brings about a certain confidence. That's what we mean by this faith, this confidence. It's through the confidence that we begin to act in skillful ways. As soon as we do that, it takes away all the guilt, all the shame, all the remorse from our lives, and there's a natural gladness that arises. There's a natural peacefulness in the mind. With this peacefulness there comes a deeper peacefulness of a rapture. It has also a certain calmness to it, and you'll see that some of these qualities are part of the seven factors of enlightenment. This produces a certain contentment, a certain happiness.

When you've got that emotional base within the mind, concentration arises naturally. It's easy. What empowers this is the desire to want to know. Even when something horrible is happening within us, even when we've got a depression, as soon as you turn towards an investigation towards that mode, that interest, immediately you can feel that at another level, or a part of it, or beneath it, there is this very subtle joy. That joy is actually mirroring the liberation, the detachment from the mental state that we're experiencing.

With that concentration and with that investigation, there arises the knowledge and the insight - the one moves into the other. This knowledge and insight is always into these three characteristics - *anicca*, *dukkha* and *anattā* - because these are manifestations of our delusion. With those little insights, there are classic insights which lead to these paths and fruits. They're cut-off points because you can't fall down from that. It's like when we reach the age of six or seven, and Father Christmas can't exist anymore. You can't go back to believing it. It's not possible. You've got to kid yourself. You can't go back to that open belief that Father Christmas is going to appear from Lapland with Rudolph.

What happens is, just like with Father Christmas, you become disenchanted with that. You don't believe in it anymore. That's your disenchantment. That's a really beautiful word for it because we tend to be enchanted by the world, bewitched by the world. It's this knowledge, this understanding which undermines that bewitchment, that enchantment.

These moments of bewitchment and enchantment don't have to be huge, fantastic insights. They're just little understandings that keep coming to us all the time. What's happening is there's a slow movement in consciousness, a slow movement in the way we're

seeing the world. This begins to accumulate, this begins to grow. It manifests in the way we feel about things, the way we respond to things rather than react. It manifests in the heart as compassion, love, sympathetic joy. These are all qualities that arise because we're undermining that fundamental delusion which is causing this root selfishness where we can only see the world from the way that we see it and for our own benefit.

As soon as that disenchantment comes, all the emotions around bewitchment disappear. That's your dispassion. That's where the heart's beginning to really cleanse itself. It's at these little moments that we experience these liberations. That liberation is the quality of freedom that the Buddha talks about, which is the essential feel of *Nibbāna*.

We get little insights like that. *Nibbāna* itself is a technical word. It refers to the final end. It's phrased as path, fruits and *Nibbāna*, but that doesn't mean to say that we can't get a little inkling as to what it is to be liberated from these desires. All that takes us to what's known as the destruction of the outflows, the *āsavas*, which will be my talk next week.

You've got this wheel of dependent origination constantly turning, and then slowly there's an awakening of "Hey, I'm suffering." As soon as that recognition comes up, then there's the desire to escape it. It's through this reflection, it's through faith, it's through good action that the faith begins to arise that the path that we're on is actually leading out of it. This leads to a natural gladness which leads to a deeper state of rapture, which is that interest, which is wanting to know how to get out of this. But that must be matched with calmness.

Then there comes this general happiness with things, and it's within that atmosphere that the concentration easily grows and with it this investigation. It's in the investigation that these knowledges and insights arise.

As soon as we see something, we become disenchanted. For instance, it's like when you overeat, and then afterwards you feel bloated, you feel heavy with it, and you have a little reflection. You say, "Well, this is caused by overeating. So the next time I see food, I'll go a bit more gently on it." There's all these little gross examples, but as you become disenchanted, more and more subtly within the way you observe your own psychology, you see every time there's an indulgence there's always an aftermath of dissatisfaction. It's really beginning to feel the dissatisfaction which leads you to the end of it.

So long as when the dissatisfaction comes up you keep going back to another pleasurable state to hide it from ourselves, then we're not actually seeing the suffering. Unwittingly we keep pounding this, we keep pounding the beat round and round - it's de-

pendent origination. It's really catching the aftermath, the effects of indulgence, which makes us want to stop indulging. That's part of your knowledge and insight that brings about the disenchantment with the world as a place we can seek happiness.

Which, remember, is not a denial of the pleasures and joys of life. It's that wrong relationship of thinking that this is true happiness. That's what leads us to this lovely place where we're enjoying things, but there's that dispassion. Remember, the English word "passion" is quite lovely because it comes from the Latin meaning "I suffer." That's the liberation. That's the feeling of liberation. Slowly through this, we're undermining these *āsavas*, which I'll talk about next week - these outflows.

That's looking at dependent origination as a joyful process, or at least the process out of which we can find our liberation. I can only hope that my words have been of some assistance and that you will struggle against the old habits and release yourself from the pain of suffering sooner rather than later.

1. Indulgence

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min

In this opening episode of a series on the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (SN 56.11), Bhante Bodhidhamma introduces the Buddha's first discourse after his Awakening. He reads the sutta's opening sections, explaining how it was preserved by Ānanda and the circumstances of its delivery to the five ascetics at Isipatana Deer Park in Vārāṇasī.

The talk focuses on the first extreme the Buddha warned against: the pursuit of sensual happiness in sensual pleasures. Bhante clarifies that the Buddha wasn't condemning pleasures themselves, but rather our psychological pursuit of happiness through them. He outlines five consequences of this attachment: psychological dependency and addiction, frustration when denied, grief when lost, underlying anxiety about loss, and boredom due to pleasure's inbuilt obsolescence.

This teaching offers practical insight into our relationship with sensual experiences—from simple pleasures like food and nature to complex attachments to people and possessions. Bhante shows how these attachments create the very suffering (dukkha) the Buddha identified, making this ancient wisdom directly relevant to modern life and our consumer culture.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened.

To begin these little homilies on the scriptures, I suppose the obvious one to start with is what's known as the first discourse, the one in which the Buddha begins the turning of the wheel of the law. I'm going to read it out, just the main bit. It's not that long a discourse. I'm going to read out just to the point where it gives us the full layout of his teachings.

"Thus have I heard. On one occasion the Blessed One was dwelling at Baranasi and the Deer Park at Isipatana. There the Blessed One addressed the monks of the group of five thus: 'Monks, these two extremes should not be followed by one who has gone forth into homelessness. What two? The pursuit of sensual happiness in sensual pleasures, which is low, vulgar, the way of worldlings, ignoble, unbeneficial, and the pursuit of self-mortification, which is painful, ignoble, and unbeneficial. Without veering towards either of these extremes, the *Tathāgata* has awakened to the middle way, which gives rise to vision, which gives rise to knowledge, and leads to peace, to direct knowledge, to

enlightenment, to *Nibbāna*. And what, monks, is that middle way awakened to by the *Tathāgata*? It is this Noble Eightfold Path, that is, right view, right intention, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right concentration, and right mindfulness. This, monks, is that middle way, awakened to by the *Tathāgata*, which gives rise to vision, which gives rise to knowledge and leads to peace, to direct knowledge, to enlightenment, to *Nibbāna*.

'Now this, monks, is the noble truth of suffering. Birth is suffering. Aging is suffering. Illness is suffering. Death is suffering. Union with what is displeasing is suffering, and separation from what is pleasing is suffering. Not to get what one wants is suffering. In brief, the five aggregates subject to clinging are suffering. Now this, monks, is the noble truth of the origin of suffering. It is this craving that leads to renewed existence, accompanied by delight and lust, seeking delight here and there. That is, craving for sensual pleasures, craving for existence and craving for extermination. Now this, monks, is the noble truth of the cessation of suffering. It is the remainderless fading away and cessation of that same craving, the giving up and relinquishing of it, freedom from it, non-attachment. This, monks, is the noble truth of the way leading to the cessation of suffering. It is the noble Eightfold Path.'

So that's the opening of the discourse. He goes on for a couple of more pages where he goes into it just a little bit more. He extends it, basically. What I mean to do is just go through it over a period of time and hopefully just say a few words as to how this understands the meaning of these different phrases.

The first thing to begin with is that the one that it begins with, "thus have I heard." I'm presuming that you don't know anything about the scriptures, so I'll start with the very basics. After the Buddha's death, the enlightened monastics got together and convened a first council, which is up in Vulture's Peak, which you can still visit, right there near the ancient city of Rajagaha, the king's city, which is now called Rajgir.

The one person they were depending upon was Ananda because Ananda had spent the last 20 years of the Buddha's life with him as his attendant. He was a cousin, but the thing about Ananda was he had this phenomenal audio memory and basically they were depending on him to remember what the Buddha had said, what the talks the Buddha had given. The story is that when the Buddha died he'd only attained the first level of attainment, one called the *Sotāpanna*, the stream entrance, and there are four to go—another three to go rather. He put in a lot of effort trying to become fully liberated because the *Arahants* had made this rule that nobody would come to the meeting unless they were fully liberated. So he struggled and struggled and struggled,

and the night before this whole meeting was going to take place, he worked all the night and could see that he wasn't going to make it. He could see that. It was getting a bit desperate towards the end of the night, at least it was my interpretation.

Anyway, he lay down to have a rest. And it was on the point of the standing position to the lying position that he went through the rest of the processes of enlightenment. And when he hit the pillow, that was when he'd attained the full liberation. That's the story that surrounds Ananda. So they let him in, and what happened was they would ask him to relate a discourse, they would question that discourse, and slowly but surely this whole set of talks were laid out. All these things, remember, in those times were learnt off by heart, so they were pretty set pieces. You can see from this it's formalised.

All the scriptures begin with "thus have I heard" because it refers back to Ananda's memory of what the Buddha taught. Not to say the other people there didn't make suggestions and whatnot, but basically that's how the scriptures came about. He says that in a sense he couldn't have heard this because he wasn't there at the time because the Buddha was only talking to his five companions, but "thus I heard" must also mean that which came to him and which the Buddha had approved of in some way or other. Because by the time the Buddha died, all these scriptures were being learnt off by heart. They were all set pieces really.

So this talk is given after he became fully awakened and wondered who he could pass this on to, if you remember the story. He remembers his first two teachers and then he learns or begins to realise they both died, either through his superpowers or he learns that they both died. So the next group of people that he thinks about passing this on to were the five companions whom he'd abandoned, whom he left out of despair when he came to the end of those self-mortification exercises.

And so he goes to find them. The distance from where he was liberated, Bodhi Gaya, all the way up to Sarnath, which is on the Ganges right up there on the Ganges just outside Varanasi, present-day Varanasi, that's a heck of a long way. So it must have taken him quite a while to get up there. When he finally finds them, he approaches them and they're a bit disappointed in him. They basically try to ignore him. But as he comes close, they see that something's changed about him. So they offer him a seat. During this whole talk, in another discourse, which relates it in a slightly different way, he's constantly saying to them, "Have you ever heard me talk like this before? Have you ever heard me say something like this before?" And by the end of this first talk, they're pretty convinced that he's had some sort of major breakthrough. In fact, by the end of this talk one of them enters into the level of a stream entrance.

So that's the opening part here. "Thus have I heard. On one occasion the Blessed One was dwelling at Varanasi, which is present day Varanasi, in the deer park at Isipatana, and there the Blessed One addressed the monks of the group of five thus."

Now he goes on to, there are these two extremes that should not be followed by one who has gone forth into homelessness. Now, in the commentaries, it says that when all these scriptures are addressed to monks, you can take it—I forget the term for that in English, where you use one part to refer to the whole, like "all hands on deck." Anyway, here, what he means is anybody who follows the Dharma. So it should be said, for us it's all meditators. These two extremes should not be followed by one who's gone forth into homelessness. That can be taken also to mean anybody who's entered into the spiritual life, into a spiritual way of thinking about things. These two extremes should be avoided.

So the first one is the pursuit of sensual happiness in sensual pleasures, which is low, vulgar, the way of worldlings, ignoble and unbeneficial. I just want to go into that for this particular session.

Remember that he's not talking about pleasures itself. It's always about the pursuit of sensual happiness in sensual pleasures. The pursuit of sensual happiness. So, first of all, there are sensual happinesses, such as eating and whatnot. In fact, this can extend to anything which comes in through the six senses, whether you're listening to the radio, anything from sex, drugs, rock and roll. It doesn't really matter what it is, it's the whole gamut of human pleasure in the sensual world. He's not saying there's anything wrong with that. He's saying it's seeking happiness there that's the problem. Seeking happiness in sensual pleasures.

And there are consequences to that seeking happiness in sensual pleasures, and if we keep those things in mind then whenever you are enjoying a sensual pleasure one has to be careful of that overlay of seeking happiness in it which is forming the attachment to it, which is trying to make a sensual pleasure something which we are becoming psychologically dependent on. So in other words, to go, for instance, in nature, just to go walking in the country and to enjoy the country is one thing, but then when you find that during a whole set of bad weather you can't get out to the country and you're feeling depressed, then that's telling you something about your relationship to the country. See what I mean? So it's that relationship that he's saying is low, vulgar, the way of worldlings, ignoble and unbeneficial.

There are five consequences that arise from that attachment. The first one is the whole psychological dependency which at worst is addiction. So anytime you have that psychological need for something, then that is pointing out to us where our dependency lies. And that's the suffering. It's got to be fulfilled. There's a lack. There's a thirst there for it.

The second one is frustration when you don't get it. That's another sign. You're getting angry because you can't have what you want.

The third one is grief that you've lost it. If you have something and then you lose it and you can't go, then you feel sad about it and grieve. If it's somebody close to you, it also refers to the attachment we have to human beings. They're also part of the sensual world. So when they die, when they fall ill, misfortune hits them, the grief we feel is something else. That's not to be confused with sorrow and compassion. That's another thing, though. But that sense of personal loss, the hole that's left in our hearts, for instance when somebody dies, that is the measure of attachment.

And this underlying constant fear of loss—that's the anxiety. So once you're dependent on something, whether you like it or not there's always going to be that underlying sense of anxiety because we know it arises and passes away. Sometimes it's not going to be there. So our society, which has become so sophisticated, and we have this awful weather like this, there's an underlying anxiety that, you know, the electricity is going to go or the heating is going to stop or people aren't going to get their food because it's not being distributed. These things that we take so much for granted under extreme conditions point to our anxiety about these things, about loss.

And the fifth thing, which is really I think the true psychological motivation for our consumerism, is boredom. So boredom comes about because of the inbuilt obsolescence of pleasure. In other words, you can't keep getting the same buzz from the same thing. So even if you put the sweetest most beautiful chocolate in your mouth, the next one is not going to make it. You've got to have a different type of chocolate. Or you've got to leave it for a long while and then go at it again. So that inbuilt inability for the same sensual pleasure to keep giving you the same buzz comes back to us as a feeling of boredom with it. And that boredom can of course get really very strong, can move to a real aversion with something which was once giving you pleasure.

And the whole of consumerism is not simply giving you pleasure because pleasure is pleasant. It's also because people are constantly running away from boredom. So they're always looking for something new. What's the next thing on the menu? What's the next thing that's new? It's the real underlying power because we are much more motivated to move away from pain than we are to move towards pleasure.

So these five things, when you contemplate it, they bring home why the Buddha thought that the pursuit of sensual happiness in sensual pleasure which is low, vulgar, the way of worldlings, ignoble and unbeneficial. He hasn't got a good word for it at all.

So hopefully that will give you something to reflect upon, especially as we approach Christmas with the food and all that. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated from all desire for seeking happiness in sensual pleasure, and achieve that enlightenment, that pure happiness of *Nibbāna*, sooner rather than later.

Self-Mortification

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 14 min

In this second episode exploring the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (SN 56.11), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's teaching on self-mortification as one of the two extremes to avoid on the spiritual path. Drawing from the Buddha's own six-year experience with severe fasting and other ascetic practices, he explains how these physical austerities were believed to reduce bodily desires and lead to liberation.

Bhante extends this teaching beyond its historical context of physical mortification to encompass psychological patterns of self-hatred, repression, and constant self-judgment that plague modern practitioners. He explores how this inner self-mortification manifests as depression, despair, and neurotic behaviors, and how it can be mistaken for humility. The talk examines how different personality types—those prone to indulgence versus those prone to aversion—relate differently to rules and moral guidelines.

The discussion culminates in understanding true renunciation as the Middle Way alternative to both indulgence and mortification. Rather than punishing ourselves, we learn to recognize attachment and gently let go, feeling the healing pain of release rather than the destructive pain of self-hatred. This approach transforms our relationship with desire from one of battle to one of wise understanding.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhasa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhasa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhasa — Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened One.

So we're going through the first discourse. It's known as the first discourse that the Buddha gave. It obviously wasn't done in this way. He was probably just in conversation with the five companions. But later on it got systematized into this, formalized into this discourse. And it's the basic platform of all the Buddha's teachings, the Four Noble Truths, Eightfold Path.

Last week we just introduced it and we talked really about the whole problems of this sensual pleasure business. Remember he says, "Monks, these two extremes should not be followed by one who's gone forth into homelessness." Remember what we mean by that is somebody who's gone into the spiritual life. What to? The pursuit of happi-

ness, sensual happiness in sensual pleasures, which is low, vulgar, the way of worldlings, ignoble and unbeneficial. So he hasn't got a good word for it, for indulgence of any sort, especially around Christmas.

And then there's now the second one, the pursuit of self-mortification, which is painful, ignoble and unbeneficial. Now in those days there were those teachers who taught these blissful states what we now call the *jhānas*, which the Buddha felt were very worthwhile because they develop beautiful mental states. The one about, for instance, *mettā* — if you keep developing that then your whole mind is suffused, your whole heart is suffused with this good will. So you didn't see any problem with that apart from the usual attachment that one gets with beautiful states of mind. It's like when you walk in the country, you get attached to it and you want to go out there again.

But the other thing was this self-mortification and the understanding — even which predates the Buddha — was this whole business of desire. This wasn't something specific to the Buddha, the fact that desire was the cause of suffering. It was there in some understanding or other. Even Socrates said it. Socrates said desire is the cause of suffering. So the whole idea was that this sensual pleasure, which was the world — the world — somehow if you want to be liberated from the world, one other way to do it would be to reduce the appetites of the body. So one obvious way is to fast.

So this is what the Buddha did. One of his main exercises was to fast. In fact, it seems to be the main one that he did. He said he got so thin he could hold his spine through his stomach. He tried that. And the whole idea was that by reducing the appetites of the body, you necessarily reduced your desire for them.

Now, have you ever done a fast, a 10-day fast? Well, what happens is the first three days are pretty awful as the body detoxes itself. But then suddenly, you get into a very nice place and you don't feel hungry. And the reason is the body starts eating itself. You're actually dying. But you never feel hungry. You feel very light. Very light, it's fantastic really. And you can understand why people make a habit of it, and why it became such a thing in yoga to do long fasts, because it is very purifying. And your appetite is simply reduced. Somehow it's just not there. You just don't feel hungry after a while, and the body feels very light.

Other mortification exercises were to sit next to a fire and suffer the heat. You'll see them even today in yoga, in India, with their arms withered still held up in the air, never pulled down. And it's all to do with trying to get rid of the body almost. It's seeing the body as something which is hateful, to be despised, to be got rid of, to be conquered.

There's some negative feeling towards the body, and of course we get it through Christianity as well, and especially through its judgments around sexual activity. There's something impure about it.

So this was the practice of the time, and again it was all to do with rebirth. It was all to do with liberating the *atta*, the self, from the body. This is the way you did it — you stopped it from seeking happiness in the body. And one way to do it, of course, is to make the body painful.

But I think we can stretch this a bit more, like last time I was talking about the psychological consequences of indulgence — the boredom, the grief at loss, etc., etc. Here, what we find is all the stuff that Freud really understood about repression and about self-hatred and about self-judgment. Because to me, all that comes into that negative part, which actually is making us suffer. And it's ignoble, meaning that it's not on the path and it's completely useless. So that's his phrase — remember, it's painful, ignoble and unbeneficial. There's absolutely no reason to do it.

So I think we can stretch this, or at least I prefer to do this, to stretch it to all this business around self-hatred, around repression, around that area where we're constantly judging ourselves, putting ourselves down. So it's not just a physical thing, it's a mental thing. And when we do that, of course, when we really suppress stuff that we don't want to go near, we know it leaks out in other ways in other sorts of neurotic patterns of behavior and stuff like that. And if it's more of a conscious thing, this constant self-judgment and doing ourselves down — "you're no good, you're useless, nobody loves you" and all that sort of stuff — it leads to depression, doesn't it, leads to despair.

So it's absolutely a waste of time to do that. And when we see the danger of that sort of self-hatred, that's when the meditation works for us, because we turn around upon it, we name it, we actually acknowledge what we're actually doing to ourselves. That's the point. And in so doing we're pulling ourselves out of it, we're finding another position.

And remember that it's never getting into the head of it, never getting into the talk of it, or the speech of it, or trying to argue with it, or trying to make it see another point. It's always about sinking into the heart and feeling the self-hatred that we have towards ourselves, the self-judgment, and just being there with it, the unforgiving nature that we have sometimes towards ourselves, our unkindness towards ourselves, and just to stay with that and wait for it to pass, and to recognize it as just another mental state. Not me, not mine.

That's the important thing. See, every time, remember, we identify with this stuff, it's actually harming us. We're actually telling this very state of mind to do us harm. Every time we have these thoughts like, "you're useless and no good," "I am useless" — see, the I, how do you get out of that? There's no escape from that. You are the one who is useless, who is horrible, whom nobody can possibly love and all that sort of stuff.

So remember that that's also mortifying ourselves. And that's often can be confused with humility in its more subtle sense. We think that we're being humble by doing ourselves down, by always undermining our self-esteem. Sometimes we can mistake that for a sense of humility — "this is the way I really am" — but in fact it's just another form of self-hatred.

Now one of the interesting things about these two types — the type that is self-indulgent and the type that is very self-hating — is that it comes out in the way that we look at rules and regulations. So those people who tend to be self-indulgent are very easy with rules. And if anything, they become lax. It moves that way. Whereas people who are very self-hating, who have this problem with an aversion, an aversive type personality, get very tight around rules. It's like a prison. And they can't distinguish, for instance, the moral law from rules and regulations of society. It's very difficult for them to make that distinction. It's all to do with rules and regulations.

I remember Douglas Bader, the war hero, the guy who flew all the planes and then crashed and smashed his legs up. So I remember him saying something along the lines that, because he constantly broke rules, he said something along the lines that rules are like chains to idiots or fools, but to the wise they're guidelines. And when we are, if we tend to be the sort of person who is very tight around themselves, always self-criticizing, always criticizing themselves, they use rules in order to protect themselves from their own criticism, because every time they break a rule they get the guilt. They get the guilt about having done something, and then again it reinforces the feeling of "I'm horrible, I'm terrible."

So there's a lot of ramifications around this whole business of self-mortification. Now I've really stretched this because I don't think the Buddha himself was thinking about that when he wrote this. I think he's in his own time, in his own place, he's really talked about these practices that were going on at his time.

Now then he goes on to say that without veering towards either of these extremes, the *Tathāgata* has awakened to the middle way, which gives rise to vision, which gives rise to knowledge, and leads to peace, to direct knowledge, to enlightenment, to *Nibbāna*.

So, one of the virtues that we have is renunciation. Now, renunciation isn't self-mortification. We're not trying to punish ourselves. What we're trying to do is trying to find out where the attachment is. So when you walk into the kitchen and you think, "I'll have a biscuit," see? So if you just bring out the biscuit and hold it in front of you, and just feel the attachment, and then say, "Well, I won't have it now," and put it back in the tin — now that sort of renunciation would be the middle way. You're not doing it out of self-hatred. You're doing it to let go of attachment to biscuits.

I mean, one of the things I put to people is just choose your best TV program and get your biscuit and your cup of tea and just sit there and just don't turn it on. And just be there knowing that the football match is on, knowing that the next episode, which is the crucial episode, is next. And it's just feeling that desire and letting it go, which is the whole thing about desire is the problem, attachment is the problem, and it's just letting go. So that would be the middle way.

When it comes to this business of mortification, you are in a sense not feeding into the appetite to the body. You're doing outwardly what self-mortificators would seem to be doing, but for a completely different reason. You're not punishing the body. You're not thinking that this is going to somehow get you a better rebirth or whatever — or it might, because you're letting go of attachment. It's more in the sense of seeing that attachment is actually suffering, and every time you feed into it, it creates more suffering. So by renouncing it and by feeling the pain of letting go — the pain of letting go, that's a healing pain — that finally undermines this whole business of attachment.

So then he goes on after this to go on to the middle path. So that's another little homily. So that's his opening statement. That's the platform of his whole teaching. It begins by this statement: "Monks, there are these two extremes which should not be followed by one who's gone forth into homelessness. What to? The pursuit of happiness in sensual pleasures, which is low, vulgar, the way of worldliness, ignoble and unbeneficial, and the pursuit of self-mortification, which is painful, ignoble and unbeneficial. Without veering towards either of these extremes, the *Tathāgata* has awakened to the middle way, which gives rise to vision, which gives rise to knowledge, and leads to peace, to direct knowledge, to enlightenment, to *Nibbāna*."

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated sooner rather than later.

The First Noble Truth of Dukkha

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 12 min

In this exploration of the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (SN 56.11), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the First Noble Truth of dukkha (suffering/unsatisfactoriness). Drawing from the Buddha's first teaching after his Awakening, he explains how birth, aging, illness, and death are inherent aspects of existence, while emphasizing that our suffering comes not from these facts of life themselves, but from our relationship to them.

The talk addresses the daily experiences of dukkha: union with what is displeasing, separation from what is pleasing, and not getting what we want. Bhante Bodhidhamma offers practical guidance on moving from discontent to contentment by distinguishing between genuine needs and sufficiency versus greed. He concludes with an examination of the five aggregates (pañcakkhandhā) - form, feeling, perception, mental formations (saṅkhāra), and consciousness - explaining how clinging to these ever-changing aspects of experience creates suffering.

This teaching provides essential foundation for understanding the Buddha's core insight into the nature of existence and offers practical approaches for developing contentment and letting go of attachment to impermanent phenomena.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So, we've got this Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta, turning of the wheel of the law, and having told us that the way to happiness was not through seeking happiness in sensual pleasures — remember it's not a denial of sensual pleasures — nor is it the pursuit of self-mortification, or punishing the body.

And he says he's awakened to the middle way that gives rise to vision, which gives rise to knowledge and leads to peace, to direct knowledge, to enlightenment, to Nibbāna. And then he says, what, monks, is the middle way awakened to by the Tathāgata? So it is this Noble Eightfold Path: right view, right intention or right attitude, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, right concentration. And this is what leads to peace and so on and so forth.

Now he repeats that, so I'll come back to that. But then he tells us about the noble truths. Now this, monks, is the noble truth of suffering. This is the first noble truth. There's four of them. So there's the noble truth of suffering, the cause of suffering, the fact that there is an end to suffering, and the path leading to that end of suffering.

So here he's telling us what the noble truth of suffering is. The first noble truth: birth is suffering, aging is suffering, illness is suffering, death is suffering. Union with what is displeasing is suffering, and separation from what is pleasing is suffering. Not to get what one wants is suffering. In brief, the five aggregates subject to clinging are suffering.

Now books are written on this, but I'll do a little five-minute commentary. So the first four — birth, aging, illness and death — this of course refers to, goes back to the mythology around his awakening, where as a young man in his middle twenties, he comes across the person who's very sick, a very aged person, and a corpse. I mean, that's how it's put. But basically, somewhere in his mid-twenties, he woke up to the fact that what was waiting for him was sickness, old age, and death, having been born.

But he puts in here birth, so birth of course is suffering. I know that maybe with some caesarean sections the baby doesn't suffer that much, but even so there is suffering. So it's just part of the fabric of life, this suffering.

So here, remember, there's not only just the basic suffering, the *dukkha*, there's the *dukkha dukkhata*, which means the suffering of sufferings. So he's always making a distinction between the facts of life, which are the sickness, old age and death, which is painful, but the suffering is our relationship to it. So always remember that it's not as though he's denying that there is pain in life. He himself of course never overcame physical pain. He died in pain from some sort of gastroenteritis.

So that's the main thing. And these things are really something to contemplate. It's good to do it once a day. Just remind ourselves there is sickness, old age and death. You don't have to get morbid about it. It's just there is sickness, old age and death.

So every morning after puja, at the end of the puja, before we do the Karaniya Sutta, the Metta Sutta, the sutta on loving-kindness, people send me names of people who are either extremely sick or they're dying. So every morning I read out this list and the list changes and it's just a nice reminder, a grounding.

Then it's more to do with our daily life, so there's the union with what is displeasing is suffering. In other words, being with what you don't like is a pain. That's all he's saying. It's very simple, very straightforward, and it's to do again with our attitude to

those situations, those people, those places where we find ourselves, where we don't want to be. So remember, it's not the people, it's not the places that are causing the suffering, it's our relationship to them.

And then there's the opposite, separation from what is pleasing. So not being able to get your coffee when you want it, your tea, not being able to find your friend or somebody you're close to. So separation from what you love, from what you're attached to, is suffering. So again, it's not the coffee that's causing the suffering or the friend who's not there or the fact that you can't get out to the countryside at this particular time. That's not the suffering. The suffering is to do with our relationship to it.

So those two are the opposites: union with what is displeasing and separation from what is pleasing.

And then finally, in a sentence, not to get what you want. So I'm sure you've come across this phrase: to want what you get more than you're always getting what you want. So wanting what you get moves us towards contentment. This is the way it is. And the more we're content with the way things are, the less there is this desire to want to seek happiness in the pleasurable things of life, just to be contented.

So the positive side of "not to get what one wants" is discontent. The negative side is discontent. And if we turn that sentence around itself and just begin to appreciate what we have, to develop a certain gratitude for it, then this contentment rises.

And my last little reminder with the tip of the day, which of course you all read, went on about this business of need and sufficiency and greed. So how do you know what's sufficient? That leads to contentment. What is sufficient?

And I suggest in this that don't come back on it from greed. Don't look at all the things you greed for and then come back to what you think is sufficiency. Start from the point of view of what you really, really, really need in order to exist. Considering, for instance, the disasters we've had last year like the flooding in Pakistan and the flooding in Australia. So what would you grab and take with you which you think you need? Now that's your basis. Once that's clear, then you can begin to move up into this area of sufficiency.

So what we need is clothes. It doesn't matter whether it's rag clothes or just a cloth. But then, of course, we live in a society and you need certain clothings for certain jobs and relaxation, and so on. If you start from that base of what you need, then it's easier to get to a more realistic sufficiency, that's all.

And then finally, this statement: the five aggregates subject to clinging are suffering. Books are written on the five aggregates. The five aggregates is the way the Buddha splits our human experience in the moment for the purpose of showing us where suffering lies.

So obviously there's the body. There are feelings both caused by the body and the mind. In the body, there's perceptions, and feeling and perception always rise together. Then there are these *saṅkhāras*, so these are your conditionings, and this is where you'll find will. It's here in the *saṅkhāra* that there's suffering created or undone. And then there's cognition, that which knows. So you're aware of what it is you're aware of. It's an act of cognition.

So these five *khandhas*, remember, are there with the Buddha. The Buddha after enlightenment still had his five *khandhas*. So it's this business of the process of desire, the process of attachment to them, using them, using these five *khandhas*, which is the body and mind, in order to seek some sort of permanent happiness.

And when we look at what we mean by happiness, I think you'll normally come down to a pleasant, beautiful state of mind. And of course, if you associate real happiness with beautiful states of mind, then it's a no-go, isn't it? Because it keeps changing. And if you could stop the world and say, "This is it, I don't want to move on," then you could use the body and mind to reach this wonderful state. But you can't.

So as soon as you recognize this process of impermanence, then you stop seeking this permanent happiness in the world. And that's what makes you let go of things easier. So when you're in a state of happiness, you're happy. And then after you finish, you remind yourself that's it. It's never going to rise again. You're never going to get the same party. It just doesn't happen.

So that's your first noble truth. This is the noble truth of suffering: birth is suffering, aging is suffering, illness is suffering, death is suffering. Union or association with what is displeasing is suffering. Separation from what is pleasing is suffering. And not to get what one wants is suffering. In brief, these five aggregates subject to clinging are suffering.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be fully liberated, having perceived most deeply the problem of suffering, from all suffering, sooner rather than later.

Second Noble Truth: The Cause of Suffering

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 14 min

In this exploration of the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (SN 56.11), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the second of the Four Noble Truths: the arising of suffering through taṇhā (craving). He clarifies that not all desires are unwholesome—the desire to meditate or help others leads to liberation—but specifically addresses wrong desire based on misunderstanding.

The talk explores three types of craving: kāma-taṇhā (craving for sensual pleasures), bhava-taṇhā (craving for becoming), and vibhava-taṇhā (craving for annihilation). Bhante explains how our constant 'selfing' process creates renewed becoming (bhava) and how this psychological mechanism drives saṃsāra. He distinguishes between natural appetite and indulgence, showing how awareness of desire—rather than identification with it—prevents suffering.

Drawing on meditation experience, he illustrates how the objective observer position in vipassanā practice reveals our true nature beyond the physical, emotional, and thinking selves. This insight practice, he explains, places us 'in the presence of Nibbāna,' offering a direct path to understanding the cessation of this constant becoming process.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened One.

So we're struggling our way through the *Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta*, which is the turning of the wheel of the law. We call it the first discourse—not that it was actually what he said first, but it contains the platform of all his teachings. It's basically telling us that the middle path is not one of indulging in the world nor of exercising severe mortifications.

He then goes on to explain these four noble truths: the truth of suffering, the origin of suffering, the cessation of suffering, and the path leading to the end of suffering. We're up to the second part there, and this is how it reads from Bhikkhu Bodhi: "Now this, monks, is the noble truth of the origin of suffering. It is this craving that leads to renewed existence, accompanied by delight and lust, seeking delight here and there. That is, craving for sensual pleasures, craving for existence, craving for extermination."

Now, I'll go through that again. Some of Bhikkhu Bodhi's translations are a bit heavy. I'll give you alternative translations which I think make a little bit more sense. "Now this, monks, is the noble truth of the arising of suffering"—in other words, how does suffering arise? Origin for me is a little bit too strong, because the original cause is ignorance. But how do we experience the arising of suffering? Where does it begin? And it is this craving. On dependent origination, it's the word *tanhā*, which translates as thirst, craving, sense of lack.

So this craving that leads to renewed existence—we'll come to that in a minute—accompanied by delight and lust. You have to take that as meaning both the emotional pleasures we get out of life and the physical pleasures. Lust is a bit too confined a word really. It's delighting in sensual pleasures, seeking delight here and there.

What the Buddha is suggesting is that our lives are constantly a movement towards what is pleasant, trying to escape what is unpleasant. In finding something pleasant, we form an attachment to it, we indulge it. Remember, there is an inbuilt obsolescence with pleasure. What made you excited yesterday is now boring. Your boiled sweet has to have a different flavour—you just get bored. So this business of seeking pleasure here and there, you see, and it's desire which is the mechanism, the first mechanism that comes.

I think the best place you can see this is when you eat. Having prepared yourself a meal, just sit there for a moment and catch your relationship to that meal. A part of it will be ordinary appetite—that's a desire, but that's a good desire because it wants to nourish the body. But the other desire is seeking happiness in sensual pleasure, seeking delight in sensual pleasure. And that's indulgence.

You have to be careful with this English word "desire." Not all desires are bad. The desire to meditate is hardly something which is unwholesome—it leads to liberation. The Buddha himself desired to go on alms round to get some food. When people asked him a question, he desired to answer it. So you've got to be careful with desire. It's a specific desire—it's a wrong desire, it's a desire based on wrong understanding, which is seeking happiness in the sensual world.

So he says this is the reason for the arising of suffering—this desire. You can call it the psychological reason. Actually speaking, if we're aware of desire, you see, we're not actually suffering. It's when we identify with the desire that the suffering is felt. That's on dependent origination—that's the grasping of it. Anyway, that's perhaps a little too detailed for such a short talk.

But he points out that we've got to observe desires as they come. It's in knowing a desire to be unwholesome and in waiting for it to pass away that we decondition that desire within the heart. When we see a desire which is wholesome, if we empower it, then that's the conditioning which will grow in the heart. So in the Eightfold Path you'll see we move from selfishness to generosity, hatred to love, cruelty to compassion. It's done by recognizing a desire as unwholesome, not reinforcing it, not acting on it. When you see one that's good, then you act upon it. In this way you change yourself. Very simple—the mechanism is very simple, but it's not easy, of course.

Now he says "renewed existence." Existence is every time a self arises—it's a becoming, a constant state of becoming, of a making of an I. When you're asleep this isn't happening, see. As soon as you wake up, you say, "Oh, here I am." The I has arisen. And it says, "Got to get up and got to get some breakfast." This I is constantly recreating itself through its actions.

Now he's translated it as existence, but actually the Pali word *bhava* is better translated by "becoming"—constant state of becoming. If that state of becoming is driven by wrong understanding, that's what we mean by *saṃsāra*. *Saṃsāra*, the world of constantly onward going, the rotation, the day in and the day out, the moment in, the moment out—that's what we mean by *saṃsāra*. So I think it's better translated by "renewed becoming."

So then he posits what these cravings are. The first one is the one we've discussed, which is the craving for sensual pleasure. Sensual pleasure—he's including here everything, all the joys and happinesses that the world has to offer us. He's talking about sensual pleasure meaning all the joys and pleasures of life. It's the desire—it's the wrong desire for them which is the problem. The wrong desire manifests as an indulgence, it manifests as compulsive behaviour, addiction, it manifests as frustration when you don't get it, and so on. So then you know that's a wrong desire.

But then he says craving for—he translates "existence"—craving for becoming. So we're constantly trying to create the future. Constantly—that's the whole business of planning: what I'm going to do tomorrow, what I'm going to do next year, what I'm going to do when I'm retired, what I'm going to do when I'm dead. He's constantly trying to work out the future, you see. So this desire to constantly become, become, become. Most of us do that because if we're not becoming, we must be dying.

Now, then he also says, of course, craving for—here he translates it as "extermination," but I slightly prefer the usual word, which is annihilation. So that's, at worst, suicide. Life gets so horrible, so unbearable, for one reason or another, that one wants to get rid of the self, and that's suicide. But we also do it in little bits and bobs, you see.

When we're a bit bored, a bit depressed, you think, "Oh, to hell with it," and you launch yourself onto the sofa or couch and fall asleep. So you block out for a while. Every time you do that, you're self-annihilating.

That's one of the causes why we feel in meditation, but also in daily life, the dullness and the lethargy sometimes comes up. That's because we've pushed all this stuff down through sleep. Sleep's a great suppressant. Often you wake up and you are feeling better. But actually you've pushed stuff away, you see. So that's this idea of seeking, craving for non-existence, you see. Craving—that's better actually—craving for not becoming.

Although you have to be careful here because the enlightened person is no longer in that state of creating this self. Remember, when the Buddha was enlightened, he didn't disappear. He kept being a human being. But he didn't suffer from this, you see.

So this creating of a becoming is to do with a self. The self isn't an object, it's not a thing—it's a process. So the self is always changing depending on what it happens to be doing at the time. If you were to define yourself, you might define yourself variously as a friend, by your profession, as a mother, a father—the definition of self keeps changing, see. A sociological self, an existential self. I've got a list of selves somewhere that somebody wrote—there's about thirty of them. But I mean, that can't be exhaustive, because every time there's a self, there's a type. So it's "selfing"—that would be a better word. It's constant selfing, and that arises out of a wrong relationship with the world, with the body, with the heart and mind, where you're saying, "This is me."

So the liberation is when that sense of "this is me" disappears, but there is still that awareness. The Buddha is awareness within the world, but not of it. That relationship has been broken. Therefore, it's impossible for that person to suffer.

Now, in your meditation, when you become the objective observer within yourself, and you're observing maybe some physical pain or something, or you're observing an emotion—you're feeling it, feeling an emotion, you see an image—all these things have been objectified. They're an object to you. So whatever knows has extracted itself out of this body, heart and mind, see? And when you're in that position and you come out of it, just reflect a bit. What was it like being there?

It's very different from being a physical self like when you trap your finger in a door. See, for that one moment you are the finger as a physical self. It's very different from being an emotional self when you lose it and you find yourself swallowing about or getting angry. They're different from a thinking self when you're lost in thought. It's another position, isn't it? Something else. There's no thought, there's no emotions, and there's no body when you're the observer, when you're the feeler, is there?

Now, if you haven't experienced that, then you have to come here and do a week's retreat. Because that's what the Buddha says: when you are mindful, and he's talking about this level of mindfulness, you are in the presence of *Nibbāna*. You're in the vicinity of *Nibbāna*. So we're very close to it.

So that's basically how he phrases the noble truth of the arising of suffering. It is this craving that we have that leads to renewed becoming, accompanied by delight and lust, seeking delight here and there. That is, craving for sensual pleasures, craving for becoming, and craving for annihilation.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you, by your clear understanding of desire, liberate yourself from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The Eight Worldly Conditions

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min

In this DhammaBytes teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines one of the Buddha's most practical teachings about navigating life's inevitable ups and downs. The eight worldly conditions (aṭṭha lokadhamma) - gain and loss, fame and disrepute, praise and blame, pleasure and pain - constantly affect our lives, but the Buddha shows us how our relationship to these experiences determines whether they lead to suffering or freedom.

The key difference between the 'uninstructed worldling' and the 'instructed noble disciple' lies not in what happens to them, but in their understanding. When we recognize that all conditions are impermanent, bound up with suffering, and subject to change, we can experience life's pleasures without attachment and face life's difficulties without despair.

Bhante Bodhidhamma offers practical guidance on applying this wisdom - from enjoying a meal without greed to losing wealth without devastation. He emphasizes that this teaching doesn't ask us to become emotionless, but rather to develop the right relationship to our experiences. Through gentle reminders of impermanence and the cultivation of non-attachment, we can find the middle way between indulgence and suppression, leading to genuine freedom from the endless cycle of elation and dejection that characterizes unreflected living.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So we're now moving on to the next piece of scripture where we're in the section on the tribulations of an unreflected living. If you remember last week we talked about these two darts, how we make suffering for ourselves by our reactions to things. So this particular part of the scripture is really talking about the vicissitudes of life, the eight worldly conditions.

I shall read it and then we'll see what we can make of it.

These eight worldly conditions keep the world turning round and the world turns round these eight worldly conditions. What eight? Gain and loss, fame and disrepute, praise and blame, pleasure and pain. These eight worldly conditions are encountered by an uninstructed worldling and they are also encountered by an instructed noble disciple.

What now is the distinction, the disparity, the difference between an instructed noble disciple and an uninstructed worldling?

Venerable Sir, our knowledge of these things has its roots in the Blessed One. It has the Blessed One as guide and resort. It would be good, Venerable Sir, if the Blessed One would clarify the meaning of that statement. Having heard it from him, we will bear it in mind.

That means us.

Listen then, and attend carefully, I shall speak.

Yes, Venerable Sir, they replied, and the Blessed One spoke thus.

When an uninstructed worldly monk comes upon gain, they do not reflect on it thus: This gain that has come to me is impermanent, bound up with suffering and subject to change. They do not know it as it really is. And when they come upon loss, fame and disrepute, praise and blame, they do not reflect on them thus: All these are impermanent, bound up with suffering and subject to change. They do not see them as they really are. With such a person, gain and loss, fame and disrepute, praise and blame, pleasure and pain, keep their minds engrossed. And when gain comes, they are elated. And when they meet with loss, they are dejected. When fame comes, they are elated. And when they meet with disrepute, they are dejected. When praise comes, they are elated. And when they meet with blame, they are dejected. And when they experience pleasure, they are elated. But when they experience pain, they're dejected. Being thus involved in likes and dislikes, they will not be free from birth, aging and death, from sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair. They will not be free from suffering, I say.

But when an instructed noble disciple comes upon gain, they reflect it thus: This gain has come to me. This gain that has come to me is impermanent, bound up with suffering and subject to change. And so they will reflect when loss or so forth comes upon them. They understand all things as they really are and they do not engross their minds. Thus, they will not be elated by gain and dejected by loss, elated by fame and dejected by disrepute, elated by praise and dejected by blame, elated by pleasure and dejected by pain, and having thus given up likes and dislikes, they will be freed from birth, aging, and death, from sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection, and despair. They will be free from suffering, I say.

This is the distinction, the disparity, the difference between an instructed noble disciple and an uninstructed worldling.

Clear?

So what's the Buddha saying here? These things are pretty obvious, some of them are pretty obvious to us. So there are these eight worldly conditions: gain and loss. Well I mean we've just been through this growth in the economy for eight years and then suddenly it collapses. And while it grows nobody thinks this is going to end. It's like this is going to go on forever. And then suddenly it all collapsed. Everybody's in a tizzy. Poor old Prime Minister Brown's chewing his fingernails. It's like a catastrophe. Nobody thought it would come to an end.

Fame and disrepute. Well it might not be disrepute. Just a loss of fame can be a disaster. A couple of weeks back, there was a program on Tony Hancock, the 1960s comedian. And he was famous, and he loved his fame, and he loved being famous. And the new comedy was coming in, all that satirical stuff. This was the week that was, and then Monty Python. And so he became the old hat. And so he began to lose fame, and he became despairing about it. He tried to make it in Australia, failed, committed suicide. Desperate. It gets worse if you disrepute, of course. If you're one of these MPs who got caught up in all that, and they thought they were getting away with it, some of them thought they were actually obeying the rules and regulations, and then suddenly a couple of them find themselves in jail. What a way to go. See, so at one point they're elated, life's wonderful, the next minute they're despairing.

Praise and blame. We all like to be praised for what we do and when we don't get it we don't feel good. It's worse of course if they blame. We had a meditator here just recently who seems to be in a real toxic atmosphere at work in IT. Everybody's blaming everybody. He just finds it so difficult in a blame culture. Instead of saying something's gone wrong, how did it go wrong? How can we stop it going wrong in the future? It's much easier to say, he did it.

When I was in Sri Lanka, there used to be this bird. I think it was a sea bird. I never actually saw it, mainly because there were so many trees around. But as it flew over, it used to say, "he did it, he did it." And I'd be sitting there saying, "no, I didn't, honestly, I didn't. It wasn't me." Nobody wants to be blamed. "He did it."

And then, of course, there's pleasure and pain. Well, we all know about that. When we're enjoying life, when we're enjoying food, all that sort of stuff, and we're elated by it. And then of course when we're sick, when we're ill, when we don't feel well, when we can't eat and we want to eat and all that, you just get dejected. You're miserable. So you can see how it works.

Now what does he mean? You have to be careful here. What does he mean by elated and dejected? And then he goes on to say of course that the instructed person does not become elated. So you have to be very careful here because if you say to yourself, well

this is a great meal, and then you say to yourself, it is subject to change, it's going to finish, I'm not going to enjoy this at all. Then the whole of life becomes miserable. At one time you were enjoying things and then it did get miserable, but now it's all miserable. So you have to be very careful what the Buddha is saying here.

What he means by elated of course is that sense of indulgence, that sense of whoopee, that sense of over excitement in things, and of course this underlying presumption that it's always going to be like this. That's the problem. So it's not a case of not enjoying things. The Buddha experiences and enjoys the taste of food but he does not greed for it.

Now that distinction as we've said before is very difficult for us, but at least we can stop this big depression at the end of things when things go wrong by just this gentle reminder to ourselves that everything changes. What's his little phrase here? That is impermanent, bound up with suffering and subject to change. The suffering comes because of our relationship to what we're enjoying.

So he's saying that when an instructed noble disciple, they remind themselves about this. They understand things as they really are. It does not engross the mind. So in other words, you're not caught up in it. You're not deluded by it. So you have to be slightly careful about that, or else life becomes miserable.

And the other thing is not to be afraid of pleasure just in case you indulge and then you get all the misery, because that fear then stops you really enjoying things. So when it comes to something that you say in advance that you know you're going to enjoy then it's just putting in that right intention, just getting that right relationship.

So if for instance great wealth comes to you because you played the lottery or something, heaven forbid you play that, and you've got all these millions of pounds come your way. So that's great wealth. Now what would you do with it? What they say is that people who get this enormous amount of money, they are elated for one year and that's it. Then they get really depressed and it goes back to ordinary horrible life. So it's a case of if wealth comes to us by whatever means, it's having the right relationship to it. It's using it for our benefit and the benefit of others. And that's where you get your joy.

Do you remember that win from the lottery? It was quite a while ago now, but it was an ordinary fellow. And when he got his win, he divided it all between his family and friends. Do you remember that? I think everybody went, "you know, I must be a fool, I must be an idiot." And he said, I think it's something about, "there's no point in me

being happy if others around me aren't." It's something of that nature. And that was a lovely interconnectedness. So he was happy in the right way. He didn't fall. His mind did not become engrossed.

So what he's saying is that this is actually seeing impermanence. So to see impermanence is to change our relationship to things. There's a lovely phrase that I continuously repeat to myself: there is nothing in the world worth holding on to. It's not only worth holding on to because if you do, like he says, it causes suffering, because it disappears, but because you're not holding on to actually anything. You think you're holding on to something but it's actually in a continual state of change while you're trying to hold on to it. And grasping that fact is a liberation. You can release the grip.

And he's given up likes and dislikes. Now it's not as though when you put food on your tongue you can't say I like this. That's not the problem. It's preferences. So if somebody says, how do you like your tea? Are you one of these people that says, "well, I just leave the bag in for two seconds, shake it about a bit, only a drop of milk, and only one, two or three grains of sugar, no more?" And if it doesn't come up as you have it, it's no good.

Now I had an old friend of mine who died recently, about a year or so ago, and I went to visit and he's got a very elderly mother, about 90. And she says to me, "will you make me a cup of tea?" Oh no, I said, would you like a cup of tea? She says, "yes I would. Make it very weak." I said, okay. So I went out and I made this tea and I brought it back in. And she said, "oh this is ridiculous, it's too weak." I said, how do I know how weak you want it? And she was really upset, so I took it out and made another one. "It's too strong, oh my goodness." She had this sort of, whatever she meant by weak, I never really figured out.

So there's somebody who's suffering because of preference. So if you're the sort of person who says, "well, as it comes," ah, you've liberated yourself from a lot of suffering around tea. Just as it comes. And that's all the Buddha's saying.

Now, how do we do it? Well, he gives us here the technique to do it. He says, any time gain or fame or praise or pleasure comes your way, you just gently repeat to yourself, "this is impermanent, if I don't get it right, it's going to be bound up with suffering and it is itself subject to change." That's it.

So if somebody gives you a gift of a crystal glass, say thank you very much and very quietly say to yourself, "any moment this could be broken, this could break," and when it breaks you just say, "oh look it's broken." What's the problem? It's the same way. You buy something like one of these iPhones. They cost a bit. You buy one and then you say,

"this could disappear, this could be stolen." So you leave it by mischance somewhere, and it's stolen. It's gone, that's it. What's the problem? And then out of the goodness of your heart, you say, "may the person who has it be to their benefit. I give it to them freely." But I'll still call the police.

So you're just having to let go of things. Yes, that's right. If you've stolen this, please keep it out of a gift. Receive it as a gift.

So this little bit here, the Buddha is just looking at our experience of life from these eight worldly conditions. So there they are: gain and loss, fame and disrepute, praise and blame, pleasure and pain. I can only hope this little reading and my amazing commentary has been of some use and that you will drive yourself hastily to liberation sooner rather than later.

Thank you very much.

Clinging Causes Anxiety

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

In this teaching on the human condition, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines how clinging (upādāna) to false notions of self creates anxiety and mental agitation. Drawing from the Buddha's analysis of the five khandhas (aggregates), he explores the four ways we mistakenly identify with form: seeing form as self, self as possessing form, form as in self, or self as in form.

The teaching reveals how our attachment to the body as 'I am the body' or 'I have a body' inevitably leads to suffering when the body changes through aging, illness, or injury. This process of identification creates what the Buddha describes as 'agitation and a constellation of mental states born of preoccupation with change.' Bhante explains how this same pattern applies to all five aggregates - form, sensation, perception, saṅkhāra (mental formations), and consciousness.

The discourse then presents the liberating alternative: how the noble disciple who practices non-clinging experiences non-agitation even as the body and mind naturally change. This teaching offers essential insight into paṭiccasamuppāda (dependent origination) and provides practical understanding for meditation practitioners working with the reality of impermanence and the illusion of self.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

So we're carrying on with the Buddha's words by Bhikkhu Bodhi. Now this bit here takes us into a slightly difficult realm. Remember that we are reflecting on the human condition, the tribulations of living. And this one is termed here as the anxiety due to change, but we'll see how we go anyway. Remember that when it says monks, it's standing for all listeners.

So, listeners: "I will teach you agitation through clinging and non-agitation through non-clinging. Listen and attend carefully and I shall speak." So first of all we have to understand what he means by clinging. So those of you who remember dependent origination, it's the point of identity. Very simply, you see ice cream, the desire arises, want, then the I comes in, and then get. So that's your process, mental process. The perception and the feeling arising when you see ice cream, the desire, then the identity, I want, and then I get. Now what the Buddha's talking about is the point of identity.

So we're talking about what is this I? What do we mean when I say I? That's what he means by clinging, and he's saying it causes agitation as we shall see. "Yes venerable sir," they replied. And the Blessed One said this: "How is there agitation through clinging? Here the uninstructed worldling who is not a seer of the noble ones and is unskilled and undisciplined in their dharma, who is not a seer of superior persons, and is unskilled and undisciplined in their dharma, regards form as self, or self as possessing form, or form as in-self, or self as in-form." Clear? It does get a bit... you have to understand the language, you see.

So by form he's translating here what we mean by the body. It's not just the body, it's how we experience the body. So it's feelings and sensations in the body. Actually at a more basic level it's these—if you remember those four great elements described in a descriptive way as earth, water, fire and wind. What we talk about is sense of pressure, sense of gravity and all that, all the stuff around heat and lack of it, sense of fluidity, elasticity, that which conjoins like elasticity and movement. So in Buddhist psychology, in fact in ancient psychology, all our perceptions arise from that basic percept of the way we experience things. So for instance seeing would be a fire element. So anyway, he's talking about the body.

And now he says, you see, now these people who don't know, who don't know the truth from untruth, and they're undisciplined, they don't practise *dharma*—dharma means here a righteous way—they say that form as self. So in other words, I am the body. I am the body comes out most clearly to us when the doctor says you've got six weeks to live. Then you know I am the body. Why? Because the agitation arises, the fear, the despair, etc. If you didn't think you were the body, what's the problem? But it's the identity, I am the body, which is the problem.

Now I remember I was with a friend once and we were... he said something which was about Buddhism and whatnot. And I said to him, "Well, you know, we aren't the body." And his father blurted out, "Oh yes we are!" That was it. End of conversation. He was dead in a year. So this I is a very... it's a very impermanent thing.

So that's what he means when he says form as self: I am the body. Self as possessing form: so I have a body. So we'll often say things like "I have one leg shorter than the other," as you say. So you have parts. Like "I have a big nose"—I'm not talking personally here. So I have a big nose, you have parts of your body. So we have a dual relationship to the body. We sometimes think I am the body, sometimes think well I have it.

Then there's form in self, so the self is something slightly separate and the form is within it. The body is within it. So the self is much bigger than the body but somehow the body is in it, it's part of its definition. So for instance, I am the body, I am the mind, I am feelings, etc. So there's a big self and the body is just part of it, but it's still I. So that's the point.

And then there is the self as in forms. So it's as though we think of ourselves, this little feeling of a self, which happens just an inch or so behind your forehead, doesn't it? You don't feel the self in your knee, do you? Or in your big toe? When you're looking at me now, where's the sense of self coming from? I'm looking at you. It appears, doesn't it, just behind your forehead? So the self is in form: me, I as I experience myself, I'm up here in my head inside the body. So we have all these different ways of feeling myself, of experiencing this so-called self.

Now when we identify with something—I am—there's a presumption that this is what I always am. I am the body. Now if we say I am the body, the Buddha goes on: "That body of his, that body of theirs, changes and alters. With the change and alteration of the body, their consciousness becomes preoccupied with the change of the body. Agitation and a constellation of mental states born of preoccupation with the change of the body remain obsessing the mind. And because their mind is obsessed, they are frightened, distressed and anxious. And through clinging, they become agitated."

Correct? He's not telling us anything that we don't experience. I mean, you look in the mirror and there's a few more wrinkles there and you get very agitated. A few more white hairs and you get very agitated. No hair is even more terrible, it's awful. So you can imagine the terror when I was 21 and I was looking in the mirror and I saw this gleam through my hair, you see, and I thought, what the hell is that? And as I did that, I said, there's a hole! There's a hole! And my father thought it was a hoot. But it never occurred to me that I would... I'm supposed to miss a generation. I forgot my mother was bald. No, that's not true. But somehow, I always remember that moment, you see. Terrible agitation. Terrible.

So there we have this sequence. We've got the sequence of I am the body, and at various points in our lives, we realise that this body is not what we thought it was. It's moved on. And that's what brings us this preoccupation with the body. So if you wake up in the morning and you always wake up with a bad back, that's fine. If you wake up in the morning and you've got a pain in the stomach, you get very worried, you've got to go to the doctor because you haven't had that one before. And because of this agitation, a constellation of mental states born of preoccupation...

I mean, just think of how upset you can get if your body's ill when just you wanted to go on holiday. How angry you are that you can't run as fast and you missed that bus because you stubbed your toe the other day. There's all these agitation comes up when we realise that the body has changed. It can be a change which is continual, a continual aging process, or it can be something which only lasts for so long, as when we're ill.

And so this agitation and a constellation of mental states born of preoccupation with the change of form remain obsessing the mind. And because the mind is obsessed, they are frightened, distressed and anxious. Through clinging, they become agitated. So in other words, he's saying it's the way we define ourselves that's the problem. The body isn't the problem. It's the relationship that we've developed to the body as it being me, or I am in the body, and therefore I'm supposed to control the body, or the body's in me. It doesn't matter what relationship you have to the body. I possess the body. It won't follow your command. And that's your problem. That's our problem.

So that's the body. Then he goes through the five *khandhas*. So if you remember the five aggregates, there are all those acts of perception, basic perception, all the sensations and feelings, then there's all what we call the *saṅkhāra*, which are—I'll come back to in a minute for those of you who've forgotten—volitional conditionings, and acts of cognition where we know what it is that we are experiencing.

Now the Buddha divides the human experience into these five because he wants to point us to where the suffering arises. The suffering doesn't arise in the body. Pain arises in the body, pleasure arrives in the body, not suffering. Perceptions may be unpleasant or pleasant, but it's not suffering. Feelings can be pleasant and unpleasant, but they're not actual suffering. The suffering comes about because of our relationship, and this is in our *saṅkhāra*. That's where we have developed our habits of wanting and not wanting. And cognition is neither here nor there. Cognition is just that point of knowing. Like you know you're sitting on a mat.

He says that all of these suffer from the same thing because of this clinging. So just the final one, I'll read the final one: "With the change and alteration of consciousness, their consciousness becomes preoccupied with the change of consciousness. Agitation and constellation of mental states born of preoccupation with the change of consciousness remain obsessing their minds. And because their mind is obsessed, they become frightened, distressed and anxious. And through clinging, through identity of one sort or another, they become agitated."

So agitation there refers to all the negative mental states that arise because of this delusion about who we are.

Then of course as usual we always get the opposite. So it is in such a way that there is agitation through clinging. Now, "And how is there non-agitation through non-clinging?" So here the instructed noble disciple who is a seer of the noble ones and is skilled and disciplined in their dharma, who is a seer of superior persons and is skilled and disciplined in their dharma, does not regard form as self—he doesn't think the body is me—or self as possessing form, I have a body, or form as in self, or as the self is in the body, in the form.

"That form, that body of theirs, changes and alters. Despite the change and alteration of that body or form, their consciousness does not become preoccupied with the change of form. There is no agitation and constellation of mental states born of preoccupation with the change of form, and it does not remain obsessing their minds. And because their mind is not obsessed, they're not frightened, distressed or anxious. And through non-clinging, not false identity, they do not become agitated."

And then he goes through all the *khandhas* again, you see. And then finally he says, "It is in such a way that there is non-agitation through non-clinging."

I can only hope that the words of the Buddha have been of some assistance and that my commentary has helped a little bit, and that you will use it to deepen your understanding about the human condition and wend your way gently to full liberation sooner rather than later.

Mahākassapa Explains the Cause of Conflict

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min

In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores a profound discourse where Venerable Mahākassapa explains the fundamental causes of human conflict to the Brahmin Āramadaṇḍa. The teaching reveals that kṣatriyas fight with kṣatriyas, brahmins with brahmins, and householders with householders due to attachment, adherence, fixation, addiction, and obsession with sensual pleasures.

Mahākassapa, renowned for his ability to elaborate the Buddha's cryptic teachings, demonstrates that ascetics fight with ascetics for the same reasons - but with views and opinions rather than sensual objects. Bhante explains how this ancient wisdom applies directly to modern conflicts, from parliamentary debates to personal disagreements.

The talk offers practical guidance on transforming our relationship with both material desires and ideological positions. Rather than complete renunciation, the teaching points toward holding perspectives lightly - understanding the difference between having views and being enslaved by them. This shift from rigid 'rightness' to flexible perspective can dissolve the righteousness that fuels interpersonal conflict.

Drawing on the social context of the Buddha's time - the emerging caste system, merchant class, and ascetic movement - Bhante shows how these timeless insights about attachment and the roots of dukkha remain profoundly relevant for finding peace in our contemporary world.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and fully self-enlightened one.

Carrying on from where we were, the next section Bhikkhu Bodhi calls "the world in turmoil." It's really about conflict, as to why we create conflict.

Before I read this, there's a character here called Venerable Mahākaccāna. There were certain disciples of the Buddha and he would give them a title because of their special qualities. For instance, Sāriputta, who was probably his closest disciple with Moggallāna, he called him the general of the Dhamma, such was his understanding of the teaching. Now Mahākaccāna had the title which ran something like "one who is

greatest at saying in detail what I have said cryptically." It's just a couple of words in Pali but in English you have to explain it. This takes us to how the Buddha actually used the methodologies for teaching.

His usual thing would be just to explain something and then add a metaphor or simile. He would normally follow the usual thing of saying what you're going to say, explaining it in detail, and then telling people what you just said. That's the normal approach — if you give a speech, that's what you normally do. He would always add a simile, not always, but generally speaking, he would add a simile or some metaphor at the end of his explanation because some people understand better with imagery rather than an intellectual approach.

But often he would be asked a question and he would just give a cryptic statement and disappear. You get the idea that maybe he's got a lot of people and they're all asking questions. He just says a sentence or two and leaves it at that. The people who were baffled would go and ask the elders. Mahākaccāna was one of the more usual ones if he was around because he had this ability to really pull things to pieces for them.

Mahākaccāna didn't seem to be part of the inner set of the group of monks that generally were around the Buddha and it seems that he would live — he would go back to where he came from, which was at that time a place called Avanti. Avanti was south of the Ganges.

The Buddha, if you know your map of India, he would hang around Varanasi — modern day Varanasi, which in those days was called Benares — and he would wander up north to where his people lived, the Śākya, and then he'd wander over towards Delhi, across the kingdom of Kosala, and he'd even go almost as far as Delhi to people like the Kulus. He's got a big area, if you can imagine. He's walking all the time. He's not taking a bus or something. He's walking all the time. He covers this quite large area.

But he never seems to go towards Bengal, towards Calcutta way. He seems to be always on that side. It's mainly to do with the people who supported him and probably his family connections because his people, the Śākya, came under the king of Kosala. They were vassals in medieval feudal terms. They were vassals of the king of Kosala. So this ruling caste would have known each other.

The other thing to remember is that the caste system that's there today was being strengthened around the Buddha's time. We're talking 2,500 years ago. It's becoming much more defined. For instance, towards Bengal, present day Calcutta, the Brahmins

had ascended to the chief caste, but this still hadn't happened where the Buddha was. Often the Buddha makes little side remarks about these Brahmins: "a true Brahmin is this and this and this."

There was still the Kṣatriyas or the Khatiyas as they're called in Pali were still the ruling caste — it was the old warrior caste. So there's the Brahmins who were the priestly caste, but they would hold jobs, they were courtiers, they owned farms. The Khatiyas were the soldiers and the rulers. Then there was the agricultural people, the people who owned land, the Vaiśyas. Well, here they're called householders, because at that time I don't think they'd actually gone into Vaiśyas and then Śūdra. I don't think that comes up in the scriptures. You've got basically the Brahmins and the ruling caste and then what's known as the householders. They would have covered quite a large group of people.

At this time, the people who were coming forward who weren't a particular caste were the merchants because of the change, because of the growth of kingship, which was fairly new, and the huge merchandise that was beginning to cross northern India all the way up to Afghanistan and even the Silk Road I think was operating by then over to China. All that was beginning at that time and there were these very nouveau riche, the new rich people who were the merchants.

Just keeping that in mind, then we have these questions. And there were these ascetics, the *samaṇas*. This was basically a movement which must have begun not much earlier than the Buddha's time and then of course carried on — of men mainly and women who would leave society completely and just live out in the forests and would come in for alms round, for food.

It would seem that one of the big entertainments of the day was to go to the local shrine, a park which would also be a shrine, on a full moon where they would listen to these debates between these ascetics arguing against each other. This is the discourse that he's called "the origin of conflicts."

So the Brahmin Ārāmaṇḍa approached the Venerable Mahākaccāna, exchanged friendly greetings with him and asked him, "Why is it, Master Kaccāna, that Khatiyas fight with Khatiyas, Brahmins with Brahmins and householders with householders?"

"It is, Brahmin, because of attachment to sensual pleasures, adherence to sensual pleasures, fixation on sensual pleasures, addiction to sensual pleasures, obsession with sensual pleasures, holding firmly to sensual pleasures that Khatiyas fight with Khatiyas, Brahmins with Brahmins, and householders with householders."

"And why is it, Master Kaccāna, that ascetics fight with ascetics?"

"It is, Brahmin, because of attachment to views, adherence to views, fixation on views, addiction to views, obsession to views, holding firmly to views that ascetics fight with ascetics."

Now, obviously he's given us all these words which are different ways of looking at our relationship to the sensual world. Sensual world means anything that you experience. It's not just eating, sex, drugs and rock and roll — it's the whole thing. He talks about attachment. Attachment, remember, is a psychological dependency on something which we presume we will be unhappy without. That's what we've done. If you say for instance, "I need a car, I need a cup of tea at 11 o'clock" and if the cup of tea isn't there, well, it's misery, isn't it? That misery is caused because we form some sort of psychological dependency on an object. "I can't live without you" — that's what you say when you're in love, isn't it? "I couldn't live without you." You obviously don't want the other person to die. So that's that sort of attachment.

He talks about adherence — to adhere. It's a stickiness, isn't it? Adhesive. It's a sticky object. You get stuck on things. You can't get it off. It's like this flypaper. Once you've got it in your finger, you just can't get rid of it. So that's the feel of attachment. You're stuck to it and it's stuck to you.

Fixation. Something that's a fixation is stuck in the mind, isn't it? It's a fixer; you can't get rid of it out of your mind. Sometimes you find yourself constantly thinking about something. Remember, these adherences and fixations and everything he's talking about has a positive side of wanting, but remember it also has the negative side of bringing up anger, frustration whenever somebody is taking what you want. And there's always that underlying fear of losing.

Sometimes, if somebody loses their job and they've got a mortgage, then it becomes this constant thing in their mind about how are they going to pay the next mortgage.

Addiction gives us an idea of being enslaved, isn't it? It's an enslavement to something, an addiction. You really can't stop doing it if it gets that bad. And then there's an obsession with it. That again is a mental, emotional thing. These words just give us a different angle on what it is that we suffer from when we form a wrong relationship with the sensual world. And of course holding firmly — he won't let go.

By using all these words, Mahākaccāna is actually showing us that he's thought about the Buddha's words, the Buddha's teaching, and he's seen it from all these little different angles.

When we find ourselves — maybe you found yourself having to see some of the Olympics — and if you haven't got to work or if your iPlayer isn't working, then you get this fixation about it, making sure that you can find a clip somewhere on YouTube.

When it comes to ascetics fighting ascetics, he says that this is the same thing, but it's with attachment to views, adherence to views, fixation, addiction, obsession, and holding firmly onto views. So views and opinions. You've only got to listen to these parliamentary debates if you really want to waste your time. You can see that they have all these things — they're attached to them, they're adherents, they're fixated on views, they can't see another person's point of view, they're addicted to always talking about it, obsessed by them, holding on.

How can you live, especially in a modern democratic society, without having a view or an opinion? That's a problem, isn't it? We have to understand that it's not the view or opinion which is the problem, but how you relate to it. "I'm right, everybody else is wrong" — so you're in conflict immediately.

One word that I personally like is perspective. If you have a perspective on, say, the economic situation, so you have a perspective, then that does allow you to see another person's point of view, another person's perspective. In so doing, of course, you're able to at least embrace that understanding, bring it close to you, so that there isn't always this negativity, this conflict that you may find between yourself and somebody having another point of view.

If you can, every time you hear yourself saying, "Well, I think" and "I feel," and you hear somebody else say that, then you have to say, "Well, that's an interesting perspective. Would you like to hear mine?" And then try to open them out of it. It sometimes sucks the anger out of the righteousness — oh boy, righteousness — out of the situation.

So that's the origin. This Brahmin is asking, why is it that these people fight against each other? Why is it that these ascetics in those days, but these days everybody, fight each other in terms of views and opinions? It always comes down to this business of this relationship we have with what we have.

What we have to ask ourselves is, is that really necessary? Can I enjoy life without this grasping, without this hand-aching hold onto things? Of course you have to practice that. Once you, or once we've understood that, there's a case of practicing it. Every time you find yourself holding it, just talk to yourself: let go. Let go. And see if anything happens. When they kick you out of your house, then you might... There's only certain things you can let go of. It's the relationship. It's this wrong relationship we have with it.

It's worthy of contemplating that and worthy of making it a daily intention in the morning just to catch oneself getting caught up in things — even the simple things. Somebody offers you a cup of tea — how would you like it? Are you one of these people that says, "Two sugars, a little smidgen of milk, stir to the left," or are you "as it comes"? What liberation that is — completely open to any cup of tea which approaches you.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and that I've been able to explain this reason as to why we're getting conflict and that this will surely lead you very quickly to your complete liberation sooner rather than later.

Thank you very much.

Envy and Niggardliness: The Cause of Conflict

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 13 min

In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines a profound dialogue between Sakka, ruler of the devas, and the Buddha about why beings wish to live in peace yet end up in conflict. The Buddha traces the root of hatred and enmity back to envy (issā) and niggardliness (macchariya), which arise from our fundamental tendency toward liking and disliking.

Following the chain of paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), Bhante explains how liking-disliking leads to desire, which arises from thinking, which itself springs from papañca—elaborate perceptions and notions. This psychological process reveals how our misunderstanding about where true happiness lies drives us into acquisitiveness and the inevitable conflicts that follow.

The teaching offers practical guidance for meditation and daily life: catching the mind at the moment of liking-disliking before it proliferates into craving and conflict. Through Right Awareness of these mental movements, we can remain equanimous with discomfort and avoid the internal resistance that creates suffering. This fundamental shift in understanding allows us to find genuine peace rather than seeking happiness through accumulation in the sensual world.

Namo tassa bhagavato hara-hatto samma-sambuddhassa Namō tassa bhagavato hara-hatto samma-sambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Harahato Samma Sambuddhasa
Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So we are continuing with the human condition and there are two pieces here that Bhikkhu Bodhi has chosen for us. This is Saka the ruler of the devas. In the scriptures the devas, these gods coming from different realms, would often approach the Buddha. Saka is the ruler of a particular heaven, a happy one, and he asked the Buddha: "Beings wish to live without hate, harming, hostility or enmity. They wish to live in peace. Yet they live in hate, harming each other, hostile and as enemies. By what fetters are they bound, sir, that they live in such a way?"

And the Blessed One replied: "Ruler of the Devas, it is the bonds of envy and niggardliness that bind beings, so that although they wish to live without hate, hostility and enmity, and to live in peace, yet they live in hate, harming one another, hostile, and as enemies."

This was the Blessed One's reply, and Saka, delighted, exclaimed: "So it is, Blessed One, so it is, fortunate one. Through the Blessed One's answer, I have overcome my doubt and got rid of uncertainty."

Then Saka, having expressed his appreciation, asked another question: "But sir, what gives rise to envy and niggardliness? What is their origin? How are they born? How do they arise? When what is present, do they arise? And when what is absent, do they not arise?"

"Envy and niggardliness, ruler of the Devas, arise from liking and disliking. This is their origin. This is how they're born, how they arise. When they're present, they arise. And when these are absent, they do not arise."

"But, sir, what gives rise to liking and disliking?"

"They arise, O ruler of the Devas, from desire."

"And what gives rise to desire?"

"It arises, ruler of the Devas, from thinking. When the mind thinks about something, desire arises. When the mind thinks of nothing, desire does not arise."

"But what gives rise to thinking?"

"Thinking arises from elaborate perceptions and notions. When elaborate perceptions and notions are present, thinking arises. When elaborate perceptions and notions are absent, thinking does not arise."

This evening you experienced all that in your sitting.

So if we take this apart, you'll see. Saka, he's come with this problem. He's asking, well, why is it that everybody does want to live in peace and we all end up killing each other? So he says, through envy and niggardliness.

So it goes back to this original problem of greed. And greed, remember, acquisitiveness is a better word. Now remember that the fundamental problem is that believing ourselves to be human beings full stop, our desire for happiness drives us to seek happiness in the phenomenal world, in other words in what we experience. So once you're into that search you begin to accumulate. So the more money you've got in the bank the safer you feel. Now if somebody's got more, see, then you're envious.

And just to make a small distinction between envy and jealousy. So you can say to somebody, "Oh, I envy you," and they're rather proud of that. They're very happy that you should envy them. But if you say to somebody, "I'm jealous of you," that stings a bit,

doesn't it? So there's something added to envy that turns it into jealousy. And it's a hatred, isn't it? You not only envy yourself, you're hating them for having what they've got.

And that niggardliness means that even when somebody wants a bit of what you have, you're not going to give it under no circumstance. So as soon as you're into acquisitiveness, as soon as you're into holding something, you're into a conflict. You can't not be in conflict once you're grasping something, once you're holding something tight. You've got to obviously defend it from enemies, because remember, just as we're envious of others, they happen also to be envious of us, which means they want what we've got.

So therefore you can see as soon as we have this wrong understanding as to where happiness is to be found, we think that it's to do with accumulation of some sort: accumulation of money, of objects, of friends. "These are my friends, my family." Then you're always immediately into some sort of conflict. Hence they live in hatred, harming one another, hostile and as enemies.

Now, when he asks, what's the cause of this? The Buddha goes right back to the fundamental position of liking and disliking. What's the cause of envy? Liking and disliking. Now liking and disliking refers to that point on the Buddhist psychology called *dependent origination* when we experience something as pleasant or unpleasant.

So we're always, as soon as we experience something, we're always shifting it to one side or the other. We always find it nice, pleasant, or we find it not nice, not pleasant. So we live in a world of that fundamental duality. There's an area in the middle that we call neutral, but if you look at that closely enough, it just shades into what's likeable or shades into what's not likeable. So that's our fundamental experience of life.

All beings have that. Even the mole, who is now again attacking our lawn, knows what is likeable and what is unlikable. And I definitely don't like the mole. But my heart goes out to it, feeling it from its position.

So this liking and disliking, now there's nothing wrong with that, because then he asks, well, what is the cause of that? So what happens after this liking and disliking? So it's desire. So that's the next thing, desire.

Now what we mean by desire, you've got to be careful here. It's a desire based on wrong understanding. It's a desire which is coming from the misunderstanding as to where happiness is to be found. So what we get from that desire, often it's translated as craving, which is a bit strong really. But it's basically wanting what's likeable and not wanting what's unlikable. So immediately you're into an internal conflict. You're either

holding on to something and pushing whatever is away that's a danger to you, or you're resisting something which you don't like. So already we're beginning the process of suffering, we're beginning the process of hatred.

Once we got that he asks what gives rise to desire. So now here he talks about thinking. When the mind thinks about something. So, there you are in your posture, and suddenly you're in Acapulco. It's just arisen, the desire to get away, the desire to be on holiday. Off you go. Or you remember something, something somebody said to you today which has irritated you. So off you go. "How could you? Who do you think you were?" It's come from a thought.

Now, it says what gives rise to thinking. So now we come to a word which is difficult to translate in the Pali. It's *papañca*. Papañca just means proliferation. So it's a proliferation arising from a particular conditioning, and it's because of these elaborated perceptions and notions that all these things come.

So if we were to go back on that instead of starting with the hatred and stuff that Saka is asking about, here we have these conditionings within us and they're dormant. They're like programs in a computer, and then a button is pressed and a thought comes up. Some idea comes up. This idea is grasped by the mind and it's worked on. But what's driving it is either this desire, the desire either to get rid of what's unpleasant or to indulge what is pleasant.

So it's just another way of talking about the dependent origination, the psychology of the Buddha. So obviously the way out of that is to catch it at the moment of liking-disliking. So if we can be aware, if we can be awake and see the mind changing, determining something as likeable or dislikeable, there's not a problem because we can stay aloof from that and that's your position in meditation.

So when you're sitting here like this and say a pain comes or discomfort comes, to catch it at the point of discomfort, there's not a problem. But as soon as you relate to it as not wanting it, then you're in conflict with it.

Now I'm not saying, we're not saying that if something really hurts that you can't move, but generally speaking, as soon as we get a little discomfort, off you go. Just watch yourself watching TV. Just catch yourself constantly shifting and moving as the body just feels slight discomfort, off you go. And it's this inability to be at peace with, equanimous with what is discomfort that is creating all this resistance in the psyche. And so whenever something taps into that off you go, hatred and all that stuff.

So this is why we live in hate, harming one another, hostile and as enemies. So it's a case of catching it right at the beginning where the liking and disliking arises and then just catching that wanting, not wanting, and then just allowing that to pass away. And that's how you remain at an even keel.

When something is wholesome, of course, that's not a problem. When something is to our benefit, coming from the heart of goodwill and all that, then we should empower it. That's not a problem. It's those things which are based on not liking, those things based on a wrong desire, seeking happiness in the sensual world. Real happiness, that is.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you, by your careful discrimination, exit from all suffering sooner rather than later. Thank you very much.

Detailed Sequence Leading to Conflict

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 14 min

In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's profound teaching on dependent origination (paṭicca samuppāda) through what he calls 'the dark chain of causation.' Using the relatable example of ice cream on a hot day, he traces the psychological steps from initial pleasant feeling through craving (taṇhā), pursuit, gain, possessiveness, and niggardliness, ultimately leading to defensiveness and conflict.

Drawing from the Buddha's detailed analysis of how we create our own suffering, Bhante explains how each link in this chain reinforces the next, creating a vicious cycle that can escalate from simple desire to 'clubs, weapons, conflicts, quarrels and disputes.' The key insight is recognizing where to break this cycle - right at the beginning with craving itself.

The talk offers practical guidance on how to interrupt this process through Right Awareness, noting thoughts without suppression, and redirecting attention back to the heart. Bhante emphasizes the importance of diligence (appamāda) in this practice, sharing humorous personal anecdotes about the challenges of maintaining awareness in daily situations. This teaching provides essential understanding for anyone seeking to comprehend how our mental formations create dukkha and how mindful awareness can lead to freedom.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa (three times). Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened.

So Bhikkhu Bodhi keeps choosing some nice juicy passages for us. This one here is taken from actually one of the main discourses on dependency, the wheel of dependent origination, which is the Buddhist psychology as to how we cause problems in ourselves. So I'll read it through first and then we'll take it from there. It's called "The Dark Chain of Causation."

Thus Ānanda, in dependence upon feeling there is craving. In dependence upon craving there is pursuit. In dependence upon pursuit there is gain. In dependence upon gain there is decision making. And in dependence upon decision making there is desire and lust. In dependence on desire and lust there is attachment. In dependence upon attachment there is possessiveness. In dependence upon possessiveness there is niggardliness. And in dependence upon niggardliness there is defensiveness. And because of

defensiveness various evil, unwholesome things originate: the taking up of clubs and weapons, conflicts, quarrels and disputes, insults, slander and falsehood. What a miserable outcome!

So if we go through this, you see, what he's doing is he's showing us the round of how things create this cycle, this vicious circle, and just things get worse unless we see where we have to pop it, where we have to actually break that cycle.

So feeling—feeling here always arises with perception. So feelings are either pleasant or unpleasant and we tend to rate our happiness according to our feeling. I mean we say "I feel happy," so that's one of the big mistakes, but I won't go into that. So we have a feeling of happiness and because of this, craving arises. Craving here means—it's a strong word really, for a specific word *taṇhā*, which means desiring something which is not wholesome for us, which is not skilful for us. We don't really have that word in English. The word "desire" doesn't give us that meaning, so they tend to translate it with this "craving," but of course that's a bit strong. Although it can be a craving, obviously—it can be an addiction.

So, dependent upon this craving, there's pursuit, which means we go and get it. So let's take a very simple thing: ice cream. So, as you're walking down the street on a hot day, which happens occasionally in this country once a year, you might see a sign for an ice cream. So the seeing of it, the perception of it brings a memory and it brings a feeling tone to that memory. And you say to yourself, "Oh, I'd like an ice cream." So that business of "I'd like an ice cream" is the craving, is wanting it.

Now once you've done that, of course, you go and buy it. You're on the path into the shop to get yourself an ice cream. That's the pursuit. In dependence upon the pursuit, there's gain. So you get in the shop, you buy it, and there you've got it. You've got your ice cream.

In dependence upon gain, there is decision making. So now you happen to be with a friend. You want the ice cream, right? And you've bought—you're about to buy the ice cream, and you're going to decide whether you should offer your friend, whether you should offer to buy an ice cream for your friend or not. This is a big problem. Whether it's their turn to offer you the ice cream. So there's all these little machinations going on in the mind. So then there's decision making.

And upon this decision making, there is desire and lust. Now what does he mean by that? It means that when we're going into a shop to buy this ice cream with a friend, we're buying it for ourselves. And we may feel reluctant to have to buy one for our friend. So it creates a disturbance within us.

In dependence upon that desire, dependence upon that becomes an attachment. So now the attachment is basically saying that it's pointing out this psychological dependency on ice cream. So because ice cream brings us this happy feeling and that's how we define our happiness—"I feel happy"—then we become dependent on it and that's what attachment means.

In dependence upon attachment, there's possessiveness. That's pretty straightforward. It's mine, right? You hold on to it, you get fist cramp. And then in dependence upon possessiveness, there is niggardliness. You're not going to give somebody else a lick of your ice cream. It's for me.

And then in dependence upon niggardliness, there's defensiveness. So now your friend says, "Go on, give us a lick." "No, get off!" See? And then they say, "Well, I gave you one when I had an ice cream." And then there's a big fight. And before you know it: clubs, weapons, conflicts, insults, slander and falsehoods. Good God, there's no end to misery.

So now, then you have to take this back again because this whole process has reinforced the original feeling. See? So now the next time you see ice cream, there's an even greater desire for it because there's an even greater psychological dependency on it for happiness. See? So there you've got your rounds, and this is the vicious circle.

So all he's saying is if you look at, if you are aware of this process within ourselves and actually that is causing us problems, then you have to go to where you're going to cut the circle. And you cut the circle right at the beginning with the craving. So when you see ice cream and you get this addiction for it, this almost overwhelming desire to get it, you see, then you have to just stay still. See? And just allow it to pass. Keep walking, keep walking past the shop. See? Just keep going, just keep going.

And when the craving goes, some of that attachment's gone. When some of that attachment's gone, some of the possessiveness has gone. When some of the possessiveness has gone, some of the niggardliness has gone. When some of the niggardliness has gone, then the defensiveness has gone. When the defensiveness has gone, there is no more taking up of clubs and weapons, conflicts, quarrels and disputes, insults, slander and falsehoods. Get it?

So this is the Buddha trying to explain in detail how we create problems within ourselves. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May, through your lack of niggardliness, come to achieve the great end of niggling—no, come to complete end of niggardliness, which is of course nibbanic bliss, sooner rather than later. Any questions around niggardliness?

The main thing is to see that the processes in the mind that we call thinking and imagining are actually what's causing the problems, and as soon as you can stop that—you have to be careful, remember that's not suppressing anything. When you see some thought going on and on, you see, and you stop it, you see.

If it's stopped with aversion—"I don't want it"—or if it's stopped with fear, then that's suppressing. In other words, you've got this underlying, unexpressed attitude, and it keeps coming up into the mind as a constant thought, thought pattern, obsessive thought pattern, and you push it down. You push it down with aversion or fear. So that's suppression. And that, of course, is negative mental energy on top of mental negativity.

But if you note the thought, you see, and you accept the thought for what it is—so that's the noting—so "this is niggardliness," and you just turn away back into the heart, you see, you've not suppressed anything because the problem is here in the feeling. And if you open up to that and let it express itself as pure feeling, then that is the process of therapy. That's the heart healing itself. It's just letting go of this turbulence. See?

Once you've understood that, you see, then you get in the habit of doing it. And of course, everything cools down. See? But it's the habit, you see. So, for instance, you might have, I don't know, this business of when somebody says something that's upset you. And you've just battered it—"That's the way they are." And then tea break. And then lunchtime. See? And then by evening you're stabbing them and clubs and all that. And it's just built up through the mind. So even though they've only insulted you once, you've had them insult you a hundred thousand times. No wonder you want to kill them.

So it's actually getting right there with the thought, knowing the thought for what it is, staying with the heart for a little while, and then putting the attention elsewhere. And that's the process. Unfortunately, if we're not diligent—so that's the Buddha's favourite, one of his favourite words, *appamādo*, right?—we're not diligent, and before you know it, it starts off again. You've worked hard to get rid of all this anguish and hatred and fear and then one moment it's all fired up again through the mind. So it's just that constant effort, constant effort.

"It's not easy to always nip it in the bud when the craving starts. Perhaps it would be anywhere in the cycle."

Well, once it's gone off—well, I think once it's shot off and you're right there holding your club, then you've got to stop. Well, then you've got to stop, you see, and catch the heaviness of the mood in the heart, you see. So if you're driving, you see, and you're getting cheesed off with this guy going so slow in front of you. See, so if you don't watch it, you're trying to overtake them all the time. You're shooting ahead.

It was funny, a few weeks ago, I went to see the treasurer, Rob, who lives in Shrewsbury, and for some reason, he plied me with two very strong coffees. Okay, so I've got this energy. And I end up at Morrison's for a cup of tea. And I walk in, and I'm stuck in this queue, and they are all old—well, they're all octogenarians. They're all these old people. And they're in front of me, and there's these two women, and they're taking hours over deciding what to have, you see. So I can feel this energy. And I try to go past them. "Do you mind? Moving the queue." And I start off—I know, I know, this is it! You see, one has to always be alert to one's...

I blame the coffee, of course. It was amusing. Well, this is why—yes, I stay here. I surround myself with people who don't push me. Exactly, yeah. Yeah, I get first in the queue here. It was amusing, actually. Yeah, it was funny. Very good.

So should we have some tea?

09. Power

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 25 min

In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's teaching on power and its potential for both liberation and destruction. He contrasts the unwholesome power driven by greed (lobha), hatred (dosa), and delusion (moha) with the wholesome spiritual power of the Iddhipāda — the four bases of psychic power including desire (chanda), energy (vīriya), heart (citta), and investigation (vimamsa).

Drawing fascinating parallels between the Buddha's temptations and those of other spiritual figures, Bhante explores how our fundamental delusion of selfhood creates the drive to control others and our environment. He addresses the psychological roots of political oppression, examining how dictators maintain power and why non-violent resistance ultimately succeeds where violence perpetuates suffering.

The talk illuminates how we unconsciously wield power in relationships through emotional manipulation and control, often disguised as love or care. Through practical examples, including the difference between being 'in authority' versus being 'an authority,' Bhante shows how to recognize and transform our own power dynamics. He concludes by exploring the Buddhist understanding of identity ('I am' versus 'there is') and how releasing false identifications liberates us from the compulsive need to control, opening the heart to genuine compassion and interconnectedness.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa, namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa — homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So we are carrying on with the human condition. This is the last one of this particular section, which is called "A World in Turmoil":

"Greed, hatred and delusion of every kind are unwholesome. Whatever action a greedy, hating and deluded person keeps up by deeds, words and thoughts, that too is unwholesome. Whatever suffering such a person, overpowered by greed, hatred and delusion, his thoughts controlled by them, inflicts under false pretexts upon another by killing, imprisonment, confiscation of property, false accusations or expulsion, being prompted in this by the thought, 'I have power and I want power,' all this is unwholesome too."

So this is one of those really pointed things as the Buddha talks about his power.

Have to be careful here about power as such. If we look at our own history, our own psychoanalytic history, you find Freud thought that our main problem was pleasure, the pleasure principle. And then one of his students, Adler, thought it was power. And another one, Frankl — I just looked these up on Wikipedia — thought it was meaning, which is rather interesting actually. Our search for meaning was the driving force in our lives.

So here you have three driving forces: pleasure principle, wanting to be happy for heaven's sake; power, power gives us control; and then meaning — why are we alive? Where are we going? Why were we born? All that.

It's interesting to note that in the Buddha's history, in the Buddha's process, his main problem seemed to be around pleasure. *Māra*, the evil one, sent his three daughters. One was sensual pleasure, sexual pleasure, and boredom. That was his problem, you see. If you compare that to Christ, Jesus Christ, remember he was taken to the top of the mountain by Satan and given power over all. His was a power complex. Very interesting, huh? The contrast between those two great spiritual leaders.

Then you get all sorts of ideas about power. Even, say, Nietzsche, who had such an influence on the Nazis and people like that, that drive of will to power, the will to be the best you could be, that's another one, isn't it? Driven by the idea of being the best. And then you get people like Schopenhauer, I think, the will to live, just to be alive. I mean, we come across that when our lives are in danger — you just want to be alive for God's sake.

So there are all these types of power. When it comes to the Buddha's teachings, we have a positive power. They're called the *iddhipāda*, the paths of power, accompanied by the effect of will. One of them is desire, intention. So remember, you can have a desire to become liberated from suffering. Unless your will is behind it, unless there's a real power, nothing's going to happen. You're going to sit there dreaming.

And there's energy. So it's a real — what the Buddha's saying is, to progress spiritually, you've got to have a real energy, a real power behind that energy. And then there's the heart. Your heart's got to be empowered. There's got to be a real inner desire to become liberated. And then finally there has to be this quality of investigation. Because our problem fundamentally is delusion and misunderstanding somewhere. So we have to search within our lives with the way we think, what we do — where are we going wrong, how are we creating problems for ourselves. So that has to be really empowered.

So these are all the positive sides of power. But I think here of course the Buddha is saying that there is such a power which is driven by greed, hatred and delusion. That's obviously we talk about something else.

And then he says it is "whatever suffering such a person overpowered by greed, hatred and delusion, his thoughts controlled by them, inflicts under false pretext upon another by killing, imprisonment, confiscation of property, false accusation and expulsion. Being prompted in this by the thought, 'I have power and I want power.'" So obviously that's a completely different form of power. That's a power which is coming from control, isn't it? Of getting what you want at the expense of anybody or anything, even the earth.

To understand that we have to go back to this basic idea of the self itself and who we think we are. So remember that our essential delusion is a problem of identity, of who we are. And having defined ourselves as human beings, you see, this is a big problem because now we're searching absolute or real happiness as a human being. In so doing, we have a relationship to the world of making sure the world, through the body, through the world that we can find happiness and that we want to control the world, you see.

So you either control it by getting rich. That's one way of trying to control it. Fame. Being famous is a lovely feeling. Being loved, even though it's not a real love. People drop you as soon as you're not making up the right songs. So fame is very flimsy, but it gives you a feeling of being wanted. And you have a control over your fans. And then, of course, there's just naked power. Just power. And we have lots of examples in our own history of that.

Machiavelli was the one, wasn't he? Machiavelli was the Renaissance thinker who said, if you want to be a good ruler, forget love — fear. Fear was the way to keep control. And of course, if you look at just around the world, the dictators we have still, this terrible thing going on in Syria. So all these are people who've gained power and who gather support for their power by making sure that everybody has a little share of the goods. That's how you get your support, isn't it? So if you're a dictator, you want to make sure that your army gets exactly what it needs and what it wants and your soldiers have a good night out. And then they've got something to lose, in which case, of course, they'll be right behind you. And they definitely don't want the opposition to win, because they will take power. See, that's the awful thing.

If you compare, for instance, what's happened in Burma, or, well, take Burma just for an instance, where the opposition has been non-violent. See, because it's been non-violent, eventually, even though it's caused sacrifice — that's the problem with non-viol-

ence, it demands sacrifice. After all the killing, eventually the military, the dictator, begins to give way. It's the same with India, with Gandhi and the British. It's a non-violence and eventually it just gives way, even though there's sacrifice. But when you're into some violent revolution, such as what's happening in Syria, then of course you have many more deaths actually because of that. Because it's two people facing each other with the desire for absolute power. Both sides want to destroy the other. There's not going to be much chance for peace if you're going to do that. If you look at South Africa and the whole way that Nelson Mandela was seen, towards reconciliation. But there has to be, this is the problem, there has to be that sacrifice. Most people don't want to do that — they'd rather just go for the enemy and that's the end of that.

So power in terms of our lives — so really we have to see where is it that we're exercising power in this bad sense, trying to control people. We can do it very cleverly, by hints and by emotional blackmail, you know. "I will not love you unless you give me everything I need." And there's just naked power, money power, you know.

Just to investigate our relationships and the way that because we depend on these relationships for happiness, see — not to say that there isn't a true love there. It doesn't negate the fact that there is a true love there. It's just that there's another bit which is about this relationship is for me. Am I you? And that's where you get the power. That's where you want the control.

So parents definitely love their children but they also want to be able to tell their children what to do. Not so much for the benefit of the child but for their benefit. So the worst case is, you know, when somebody — I remember seeing a program where a parent, she'd failed to become the violinist that she wanted to be. And so by every means she could, her daughter was going to be this great violinist. And of course it was just messing the daughter up. So it's an imposition, you see, an imposition of her desire on the other.

So this is where power causes us problems in our lives. And eventually, of course, we might end up doing exactly what the Buddha says here, "inflicts under false pretext upon another, killing, imprisonment, confiscation of property, false accusation and expulsion." Terrible.

So I hope my words have been of some assistance and that overcoming all temptation to control, to control, to have power in a bad sense, you will achieve full liberation from suffering sooner rather than later. Thank you very much.

Any comments on that? Any ideas?

"Some sort of clarification about the difference between *tanha* and *chanda*. Is it the delusion and the ego identification which is the problem which turns something neutral into something bad?"

Yeah, yeah. The word *tanha* that you've used is a specific meaning. It has a specific meaning of a desire which is unwholesome, unskillful. The word for a desire, generally speaking, is *chanda*. So that's the word they use in those paths to power that I was talking about. So the desire to become liberated, that would be considered wholesome, I think. And one has to empower that desire — you want to really, you want to really need that, you're seeking for liberation from suffering. So that's *chanda*. *Chanda* is something else — *chanda* is the will. So that's the power, that's power, you see.

So for instance you can intend, but nothing may happen. So you can intend, for instance, "well now we'll intend to have a cup of tea." But if it's not empowered, you'll just be sitting here still intending till tomorrow morning. So the power is what takes something out of potential into an actual. And that's an actual, that's a force. I mean, I can intend to move the chair, but unless I actually put energy into it, it's not going to happen. So that's the power there.

Now, power itself is completely neutral. What makes it wholesome and unwholesome is the attitude driving it. So if you want to make somebody suffer, you'll use your power to do that. If you want to make somebody happy, you'll use your power to do that.

And then there's also just generally speaking two types of power that we can wield. We have the word "authority." So you can be "in authority over," so to be in authority over somebody you inspire fear. But you can also be "an authority" whereby you inspire respect. If you're somebody who people think is an authority, like when you go to the doctor, hopefully, you think it's an authority. They've got to be right. So there's that. There's a completely different sort of relationship there, you see.

Most positions have a bit of both. To have a bit of power with being an authority is often necessary to get done what you need to be done, what needs to be done, you see. But you can see there's a distinction there between two types of power that's often invested in us. And remember that dictators only arise because people invest them with power. And it wouldn't happen if people didn't give them the power that they had. Take Cameron, for instance. We've given him power for five years. So that's that.

And going back to your original point about the self — well the self remember is in the Buddhist terms, it's a relationship. When we say "I am," when you finish off that sentence, that's telling you something about yourself. So it could be something like, "I

am depressed." So now this is me, I am depressed. See, once you identify with something, there's no escape, is there? What are you going to do? I am depressed. See, I mean, what we're learning here is that we see depression as something outside the I, outside this observer. So it's more accurate to say, "there is depression."

Now that liberates, that liberates me from suffering the depression. It doesn't take away the depression — the depression still remains a depression — but now I can find another identity which is no matter what, no matter that there's a feeling of depression, I'll carry on doing what I need to do, see. It won't hijack my life.

So and then there are definitions like "I am an electrician, I'm a teacher, I'm a doctor." So when these are taken away from us then of course you get depression. I mean once you lose your job and you say "I am," but if you take the I away and say that there is an action of being an electrician or whatever it is, then there's not that identity, you see. So if it goes away, you still don't lose that sense of self-esteem. That's the point. If your self-esteem is based on your job and your job goes, then you lose your self-esteem. You feel diminished by it.

It's the same with watching these Paralympics. These people, some of them have had really bad accidents, suffered greatly, but you can see they've all regained a lot of their self-esteem, which they might have lost through becoming disabled. Because before you said, "I am a fully able person," and now you've got to go around saying, "I am disabled." That's a loss of something, isn't it?

So that's what the self is — the self is when you complete the sentence "I am," right? Hey, there's a problem. If you check — if you take that "I am" away and say "there is," there's a completely different relationship.

It's the same with a lesser sense of identity which is "I have," see. "I own." Owning objects, if you think about it actually, you can only use an object — you can't in any absolute sense own it. I mean legally you might say "this is my car," but when the thief takes it it's his — it's not yours anymore. You still go around saying "somebody's stolen my car." But that's just a legal fiction.

It's like something that you might, I don't know, you might get some precious glassware or something like that, you see. And it's "my glassware," you see. It's something that you possess. If it breaks, of course, a lot of suffering. But if you already see it broken — when it breaks, well, it's going to break anyway. I saw it broken. It's like getting a different relationship with things so that when they disappear, it doesn't hurt. Or it doesn't hurt so much.

"Self-remembering is then something which is opposite to self-identifying."

Well, self-remembering is, yes, I mean, self-remembering — dissociating ourselves from — yes, but you have to be careful with that word. Primarily it's a dissociation to get away from the wrong relationship. But then you have to re-engage with the right relationship. See? So you might say, for instance, you might dissociate yourself from somebody's suffering. And you might say, "well, that's their *kamma*. What's it got to do with me? It's their *kamma*." But then you've got to re-engage and recognize that we're all in this together. And there comes that compassion and a desire to alleviate suffering.

I always like to tell the story of when I was in Thailand and I went to visit this monk and there was a cat and it was playing around with a mouse which was already dead. And I just said to him, I said, "didn't you stop that? It's a fat cat. You know, it's a monastery cat. It's a fat cat. I said, didn't you stop that?" He said, "no." He said, "it's cat *kamma*, mouse *kamma*." See? So I said, that is...

And funnily enough, very shortly after that, I was sitting on a bench with a few monks, and this cat jumped out and caught a bird. Well, this monk, as quick as lightning, got up, gave this cat one hell of a smack, picked up the bird — it was already dead, the lungs had been punctured — and held it up beautifully by the wings and chanted, "all compounded things arise and pass away," you see.

So obviously this monk didn't think that it was cat *kamma* and bird *kamma* entirely. The fact that he was aware of it was part of their *kamma*. There's the engagement, there's the connection. Whereas this monk had completely dissociated — it was all there like it's not my problem. Whereas this other monk was completely engaged, you see. And that's this right attitude.

So that's why at the end of every sitting that we do with *vipassanā*, we do the *mettā*, because that re-engages us properly.

"But how do we know which one we have to dissociate?"

Well, the compassion is the right one. Because that's, in a sense, to create a dissociation without the connection is creating another barrier.

And a barrier is a sign of the self.

Now a barrier is not the same as a boundary. So if you take the seashore, one minute it's the sea and the next minute it's the land. It's a boundary, you see, but it's fluid, it's easy. But if you take a cliff, that's a barrier. Now as soon as you create barriers, you're isolating yourself. If you say this is not my business, all the problems of the world are not my business, then remember the world has no business taking any of your prob-

lems as their business. So if you go along and say to a doctor, "Well I'm really ill, I've got this pain," the doctor says, "It's not my business." Do you know what I mean? It works both ways, you see. And that produces a sort of callousness.

So there has to be that recognition, and when you realize—when you go deeper and realize our interconnectedness—then you realize that everything we do has an effect on everything else in some way. The ripples of every action we do just goes completely out and then completely back, you see. So this is reinforced even with physics, ordinary science, the theory of chaos, where small conditions, given supporting conditions, will grow. So the usual example to give is a butterfly flap in South America, given supporting conditions, becomes a storm in North America.

So if you take that on the positive side, even to make a small gift towards, shall we say, some problem in the Middle East, may eventually be just that condition that brings about peace. You don't know, you see. When you begin to see the world as this interconnectedness, this interdependency, then of course the barriers break down.

See, the Buddha, when he was fully liberated, he could have just sat there, couldn't he? I'm happy. But it's funny because the first thought that comes into his head is "Who can I teach this to?" So there's a natural outflow from wisdom. Wisdom in action is compassion. You simply—it doesn't work the other way.

Saṃsāra: Onward Going

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this exploration of saṃsāra, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's teaching that the cycle of existence has no discoverable beginning. Drawing from suttas that use striking similes—comparing the length of time beings have wandered through countless rebirths to all the grass and trees in Jambudīpa, or grains of sand in the Ganges—he illuminates how beings remain 'hindered by ignorance and fettered by craving.' The talk contrasts Eastern cyclical concepts of time with Western linear progress, exploring how the mind constantly projects futures and clings to the past. Bhante discusses the Buddha's radical solution: becoming disenchanted with saṅkhāras (formations), developing dispassion, and ultimately finding liberation. He draws fascinating parallels between Buddhist consciousness teachings and modern physics, suggesting that manifest reality emerges from what he calls 'Nibbānic consciousness'—the pure awareness we touch in mindfulness practice. This teaching offers both philosophical insight into the nature of existence and practical guidance for meditation, showing how observing thoughts and sensations connects us to primordial awareness.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So we're coming to the end now of this section on the human condition. And it's not been a happy time. Remember I did happy times last year on the blessings that come to us in the lay life. So they're up on the website if you want to make yourself happy. If you want to lift your heart.

So now we're actually going to a bit of... He's ended this chapter with part of it which is called Without Discoverable Beginnings. So some of it's interesting to us from a philosophical or theological point of view. But there's other stuff in it. And I'm hoping that over the next two weeks we'll actually finish this chapter. So I'll read it as usual and then we'll see how we go.

So the Blessed One said this. Listeners, this *saṃsāra* is without discoverable beginnings. A first point is not discerned of beings roaming and wandering on, hindered by ignorance and fettered by craving. Supposing a man would cut up whatever grass, sticks, branches and foliage there was in this Jambudipa and collect them together into

a single heap. And having done so, he would put them down, saying for each one, this is my mother, this is my mother's mother. The sequence of that man's mothers and grandmothers would not come to an end. Yet the grass, sticks, branches and foliage in this Jambudipa would be used up and exhausted. For what reason? Because, listeners, this *saṃsāra* is without discoverable beginning. A first point is not discerned of beings wandering and roaming on, hindered by ignorance and fettered by cravings. For such a long time you have experienced suffering, anguish and disaster and swell the cemeteries. It is enough to become disenchanted with formations, enough to become dispassionate towards them, enough to become liberated from them.

So *saṃsāra* is just the world of onward going. It's just a way of saying that. The world just keeps turning and turning. Jambudipa is the apple rose country, and that's what India was called at that time, Jambudipa, the apple rose country.

Now, I'll just read the next one because the next one just balances this. Monks, this *saṃsāra* is without discoverable beginning. The first point is not discerned of beings roaming and wandering on, hindered by ignorance and fettered by craving. Suppose a man would reduce this great earth to balls of clay the size of jujube kernels—that's very small—and put them down saying for each one, this is my father, this is my father's father. The sequence of that man's fathers and grandfathers would not come to an end, yet this great earth would be used up and exhausted. And for what reason? Because this *saṃsāra* is without discoverable beginnings. A first point is not discerned of beings roaming and wandering on, hindered by ignorance and fettered by craving. For such a long time, listeners, you have experienced suffering, anguish and disaster and swell the cemeteries. It is enough to become disenchanted with all formations, enough to become dispassionate towards them, enough to be liberated from them.

So the first thing is, that this idea of no beginning, this is very strange for us because in the West we see time as progress. God began something here and off it went and it's going to end up over there. And our idea of progress is that it's going somewhere. Actually, the whole point of the universe, the whole point of creation by God is that it comes to an end, and then there'll be the big judgment, and some go to heaven, but the point is, we have this idea of progress, right?

So even in our society now, on a materialistic level, we presume that technology will progress, we presume that science, everything is going to progress better and better and better and better and better, and at some point the universe is going to come to an end, right? The Big Bang is going to be exhausted, and that's the end of that. But just as an aside, you'll notice that even though our technology and our science is quite unbelievable, our moral behavior remains much the same as caveman. I mean, there's not

much difference between what happened at the beginning of the dawn of human consciousness and what's happening now. And this is because of greed, hatred and delusion.

Now in the East and in fact before Christianity—Judeo-Christian civilization—it would have been the same for the Greeks and the Romans. The idea was much more cyclical so time revolves. And of course you can see that in a sense that every day the sun rises and the sun sets and there's this cyclic. And when you get the idea of a cycle there's no beginning, there's no end, it just keeps going on and on and on. So it's a very different idea about what time is, you see.

Now, what was horrific to the people in the Buddha's time was that there didn't seem to be an end to it. That this was what was in store. Every life, every time you ended a lifetime, depending on your beliefs, some people believed your next life would be determined by your good actions, by what you did or what you didn't do. Some people believed it was just fate. So next lifetime, you ended up as a pig. And that was it. And then the next lifetime, I'd be human again. And for some people, it made no sense at all. For others, there was some idea of progression. That one went on and then went into higher realms. There was, of course, people who were annihilationists—when your life was finished that was it, it was complete. Others thought you went up to this very high realm and then that was it, cut off. So there's masses of ideas but the general thing was, was there a way out of this, you see. So that's the Buddha's—that's what he means by at its basic thing about *dukkha*, about suffering—was there a way out of this onward going, and that's what the word *saṃsāra* means.

So, he says, there's no discoverable beginning, you see. But then he points, of course, to an end, you see. I mean, the reason is, of course, because of this hindered by ignorance and fettered by craving. So, the ignorance, remember, is not knowing who or what we really are. In so doing, we make the mistake, we think we are what we appear to be. And being humans we seek happiness in the human form. And that's where the attachment comes. And that's where the suffering comes.

Then he says of course that it's enough to become disenchanted. And what does disenchantment mean, you see? When you're disenchanted. So when you fall in love with somebody, there is that complete enchantment with the other. Their voice, the way they walk, the way their hair is. That's why nobody fell in love with me, you see. So, there they see that, and then suddenly, of course, about three months on, or six months on, something goes off and there's a disenchantment and suddenly they just—yes, to be enchanted is actually a word coming from witchcraft. You're drawn into, you're enchanted, you're drawn into, you're being mesmerized, enchanted, you see.

So to become disenchanted with something, to become dispassionate, in other words, not to have these feelings about craving and all that around things. And then finally, it's enough to be liberated from them. And of course, that liberation really means this complete disidentification and dispossession, mental dispossession of everything that's in this world. And that's what we mean by renunciation.

Now remember we're talking about a relationship, we're not talking about the actual things. We're not talking about not eating pleasant food anymore, we're talking about not having this wrong relationship with pleasant food. You've got to be careful or else you end up just dying of starvation because you think you've got to give up food. No, you don't have to give up any food.

And then, of course, he says the same thing for fathers, so both mothers and fathers. But that's an interesting thing for us, isn't it? The idea of time, how we perceive time. If it's progress, if we're always looking for progress, and you see that in our economic system, we're always looking for growth. They can't, these people in power, they can't think of an economic system which isn't growing. They can't get their heads around the idea that perhaps it's just sustainability we want. Just something that sustains and gives everybody enough food, enough clothing, etc. It's always really growth. And it's just very much a western thing. Very much a western thing.

Let me carry on because there's another two here which is worth doing. So a certain monk approached the Blessed One and paid homage to him and sat down at one side and said to him, Venerable Sir, how long is an eon? We'll talk about time again. An eon is long, monk. It is not easy to count it and say it is so many years, or so many hundreds of years, or so many thousands of years, or so many hundreds of thousands of years. Then is it possible to give a simile, Venerable Sir? It is possible, monk, said the Blessed One. Supposing, monk, there was a great stone mountain, a yojana long, and a yojana wide, and a yojana high, without holes or crevices, one solid mass of rock—a yojana is seven miles approximately—at the end of every hundred years a man would stroke it once with a piece of cloth. That great stone mountain might by this effort be worn away and eliminated before the eon would still not have come to an end. So long is an eon. And of eons of such length we have wandered through so many eons, so many hundreds of eons, so many thousands of eons, so many hundreds of thousands of eons. For what reason? Because, monks, this *saṃsāra* is without discoverable beginning. And then you get that repetition: A first point is not discerned of beings roaming and wandering on, hindered by ignorance and fettered by craving. For such a long time you have experienced suffering, anguish and disaster and swell the cemetery. It is enough to become disenchanted with all formations, enough to become dispassionate towards them, enough to be liberated from them.

And I'm beginning to wonder why Bhikkhu Bodhi had so many of these collected. He only needed one or two.

So here again this idea of time, you see, this idea of time. Of course there's what you might call scientific time or physical time, like the time it takes for the earth to go around the sun, something objective of that nature. So we've got hours and years and all that. There's also psychological time, you see.

Remember that sometimes time seems to drag when we don't particularly enjoy it. And sometimes we wonder where the time went. Sometimes we don't get enough time. So there's also this business of time as a mental thing.

Now, just as an aside, remember the mind is always projecting a future for us. So when we're happy, the mind presumes, that's how it's going to be forever. So when the stock markets rose, and they rose, and they rose, everybody thought, well, it's going to be forever. When you're in the other side, when you're in depression, the mind says, well, this is how it's always going to be. When you've got pain, this is how the mind's going to always be. So, really be careful of that because the mind is always fooling us. It's always creating a future. And it's always regretting or nostalgic for the past. The mind won't stay in the present. It doesn't like the present. Because it experiences the present as a sort of deadness. Like nothing happens in the now. If you're right in the now, nothing much happens. And if you're in the now, you don't know what's going to happen next. And that's too fearful. So the mind is always creating the next moment for us.

Now that's what you're doing in meditation. You're watching how the mind is always creating the next eon. What are you going to do when you retire? I don't have to think about that anymore.

Just do take a next one just to finish off. Then there's just one more for next week and we'll bring it to an end. Again, something very similar.

At Rajagaha in the bamboo grove, the squirrel sanctuary, a certain Brahmin approached the Blessed One and exchanged greetings with him. Now Rajagaha was the capital city of Magadha which is present day all around Varanasi—it's all that area—and Bimbisara was the king who was a great supporter of the Buddha. And it was around there that there would have been this shrine area where ascetics would collect and sit and then people would come ask them questions, bring food, etc.

If you go to Rajgir now, and it's a circle of mountains which would have been great for fortification. Now it's just a village on one end of it. And on the other side there's a hill called Vulture's Peak where the Buddha gave many a talk, especially in the Mahayana tradition. And if you go there now, there's still the hot baths. So that's probably why the king and his people chose it to be their capital city.

So when they had concluded their greetings and cordial talk, he sat down to one side and asked, Master Gautama, how many eons have elapsed and gone by? The Brahmin, many eons have elapsed and gone by. It is not easy to count them and say there are so many eons, so many hundreds of eons, so many thousands of eons, so many hundreds of thousands of eons. But is it possible to give a simile, Master Gautama? It is possible, Brahmin. Imagine, Brahmin, the grains of sand between the point where the river Ganges originates and the point where it enters the great ocean. It is not easy to count these and say there are so many grains of sand, so many hundreds of grains, so many thousands of grains, so many hundreds of thousands of grains. Brahmin, the eons that have elapsed and gone by are even more numerous than that. It is not easy to count them and say there are so many eons and so many hundreds of eons and so many thousands of eons and so many hundreds of thousands of eons. For what reason? Because, Brahmin, the point is not discerned. This *saṃsāra* is without discoverable beginning. A first point is not discerned of beings roaming and wandering on, hindered by ignorance and fettered by craving. For such a long time, monks, you have experienced suffering, anguish and disaster and swell the cemeteries. It is enough to become disenchanted with formations, enough to become dispassionate towards them, enough to be liberated from them.

And just as a final thing, modern science, which equates very much with the Buddhist understanding of the mind, this idea of the vacuum which contains this unknowable energy, out of which the manifest universe seems to arise, the manifest and the unmanifest. And in Buddhist understanding there is this what you might call ground consciousness, the Nibbanic consciousness. And this Nibbanic consciousness finds itself in what you might call what we experience as the mind. And what we mean by mind is thoughts, images, emotions, and how the mind actually contacts the world physically—light, etc. And that, actually speaking, everything is coming out of that base nine. It's not the other way around.

So, you could say that a materialist, looking only at matter, has to then find a way of explaining how consciousness arises from subatomic particles. And they can't. It's called a hard problem. But from a spiritual point of view, it's actually coming the other

way. It's as though they're looking at the world at the wrong end of the telescope. It's actually coming out of this emptiness, this vacuum, which, within us, is this Nibbanic consciousness, the knowing, you see.

Every time we're in that position within ourselves, observing, observing thoughts, observing images, feeling and observing sensations and feelings within our bodies, we're actually moving back into that primordial state of pure intuitive awareness. That's why the Buddha says those who are mindful are in the presence of *Nibbāna*. But the Buddha told us not to identify with that. Well we won't go into that not tonight anyway—actually that isn't quite correct but I'll bring this to an end so that we can move on to a discussion.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you become disenchanted with life and move towards your own divine bliss sooner rather than later.

11. Rounds of Becoming

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's stark description of saṃsāra as having no discoverable beginning - beings endlessly roaming and wandering, hindered by ignorance (avijjā) and fettered by craving (taṇhā). Drawing from the scriptures, he explores how even when oceans dry up, mountains burn, and the earth perishes, suffering continues for those caught in these rounds of becoming.

The teaching centers on the powerful simile of a dog tied to a post, running in circles without understanding what binds it. This represents how beings revolve around the false pillar of self-identification with the five khandhas (aggregates): form (rūpa), feeling (vedanā), perception (saññā), volitional formations (saṅkhāra), and consciousness (viññāṇa). Bhante explains four different ways people conceptualize the self in relation to form, showing how each becomes a binding post around which we endlessly circle.

The discourse illuminates how this self-identification traps us in cycles of birth, aging, and death - not referring to physical death, but the constant arising and passing of the sense of 'me' through dependent origination (paṭicca samuppāda). Only through Right Awareness and understanding the true nature of these aggregates can we cut the leash that binds us to this pillar of selfhood, finding freedom from the rounds of becoming.

*Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato
Sammāsambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa*

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble, and fully self-enlightened.

So we're actually coming to the end of our chapter on the human condition. And this is actually the last bit of quotation from the scriptures. So I shall read it as usual. Listeners, when you see this word "monks" in the scriptures, it stands for everybody who's listening.

"This saṃsāra is without discoverable beginning. The first point is not discerned of beings roaming and wandering on, hindered by ignorance and fettered by craving. Now there comes a time, monks, when the great ocean dries up and evaporates and no longer exists. But still I say, there is no making an end of suffering for those beings roaming and wandering on, hindered by ignorance and fettered by craving. There comes a time, monks, when Sinaru, the king of mountains, burns up and perishes and no longer exists. But still, I say, there is no making an end of suffering for those beings

roaming and wandering on, hindered by ignorance and fettered by craving. And there comes a time, monks, when the great earth burns up and perishes and no longer exists. And still, I say, there is no making an end of suffering for those beings roaming and wandering on, hindered by ignorance and fettered by craving.

"Suppose, monks, a dog tied up on a leash was bound to a strong post or pillar. It would just keep on running and revolving around that same post or pillar. So too, the uninstructed worldling regards form as self, feeling as self, perception as self, volitional formations as self, and consciousness as self. And he just keeps running and revolving around form, and around feeling, and around perception, around volitional formations, and around consciousness. And as he keeps on running and revolving around them, he's not freed from form. Not freed from feeling. Not freed from perception. Not freed from volitional formations. Not freed from consciousness. He's not freed from birth, aging and death. Not freed from sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair. Not freed from suffering, I say."

It's a bit heavy, isn't it?

So here we have some old themes. This business of *saṃsāra* has no discoverable beginning. Really, that's just looking at cause and effect. If you go back on cause and effect, you don't seem to get to a beginning of it. In other religious forms, they try to form a beginning by saying a god started it at some point, but from the Buddha's point of view, there's no discoverable beginning for this. Which is awful, isn't it? It presumes that we've been going round and round like this dog for yonks. Roaming and wandering around, hindered by ignorance and fettered by craving.

So remember, these are the two points on dependent origination. It begins by this fundamental not understanding, not knowing, which produces for us a misunderstanding. And that's the delusion. What is the delusion? The delusion is thinking that we are human beings in an absolute sense. Conventionally, obviously, we're not apes, or at least most of us aren't. You see some people walking along dragging their knuckles on the floor, but apart from those... So we have this mistake, and what the mistake does is it makes us seek real happiness in the sensual world. There's the desire.

And as you know, this desire leads to acquisition. We have to defend it, and therefore you get the opposite, the aversion, the hatred, and if the enemy is too big, fear. So remember, those are your three fundamental dispositions: acquisition, acquisitiveness, aversion, and fear. And from then, all human misery stems.

And then he gives us three images. There's the ocean, there's the mountains, and the earth. And he just says, well, when all this disappears... we know from science that this earth will disappear. At some point, the sun will... what do they call those big red blowout stars? Supernovae. That's it, we've had it then. We have to make sure that we're already inhabiting another planet. So once we know that the Earth is going to die at some point, and it'll probably die quicker than we think because of our own actions, and the ocean comes and then etc. But still, this doesn't mean that beings don't go on.

So this presumes, remember, there's always a presumption that there isn't just this physical body, there's also the mental body, the *mano-maya-kāya*, the body made by the mind, which is within this body and leaves the body when we die. But remember that that's not to be confused with the *nibbāna-dhātu*, as they like to say in Theravada, the element of *Nibbāna*, or that which is the Buddha within.

We begin to understand what that might be the more we meditate and the more we recognize what the qualities are of the one who's observing, that which is observing.

And then we get this image of the dog on a leash tied round and round, just running and running around a pillar. There's no end to it. The dog doesn't know what's tying him to the pillar. He just keeps running. He thinks that the faster he runs, the more chance there is of escaping. But he doesn't realize that he's tied to this pillar.

So what is this pillar that we're tied to? It's the self. That's the pillar, that's the false pillar that we've driven into our existence, thinking that, well, this is what I am. And therefore, we're always going to run around the demands of the self. And the self is what? Seeking happiness. Seeking happiness in this sensual world.

And this takes us to this whole business of what we think the self is. So remember there are four positions. And he has it nicely written here at the back. So, people regard the self as form. So, I am my body. That's the materialist position, isn't it? I am my body. And it gives an example of a flame of an oil lamp and its colour are indistinguishable. So, the flame and the colour are the same. So, a materialist will say, well, I am my genes. Full stop.

And then somebody says, well, the self as possessing form. So it's more the image of a tree possesses a shadow. So the real me is my mind, my heart and mind. But the body is not my real me. It's something I possess, but it's not me. And then there's the form which is in self. So it takes the formless mind as a self within which form is situated. So I am this mind of mine, this heart-mind of mine, and within that you find this body. Again the image is of a scent in a flower. The scent is in the flower, but then we think well, the flower is not the scent.

And then the self is in form in the sense of a jewel in a casket. So it's situated within the body, but it's not the body.

So we've got all these different ideas of a self, as to who we are, as to what we identify with. And that becomes the pillar. And then we keep running around the demands of this self.

And he goes through his usual way of describing the human being, which are these five *khandhās*. So the *khandhās* are these five aggregates, these heaps. It's just a way of looking at a human being to see where the problem is. There are many ways that you can split up the human form, but the way the Buddha does it is to show us where the problem is.

So the first one is the body itself. There's a whole thing that we call the body, both the physical part of our body and the way the mind experiences the body, through feeling, sensation. So for instance, the nail on my finger here... I don't know it, do I? I don't even feel it grow, I don't know anything about it. But I do know it by the sense of touch, and the fact that I can see it. But I don't actually know the nail in itself, do I? Strange. Do you think? I keep going on about, this is my body.

And then there's feeling. All these feelings, they're me. They tend to be easier to identify with. So when I've got a pain, that's me.

Then there's the perceptions. So perceptions lead to a lot of thoughts. So what I perceive, I believe, is actually true. And through our science, we might even come to the conclusion that what I see is actually the way it is. So when I see a tree, I believe that that's the way it is. But in fact, if I take another position, I see the tree differently. And other people see the tree differently. But I'm of the opinion in myself that when I look at a tree, that's the way it really is.

And then there's volitional formation. So these are what we would normally call our emotional thought life. And we identify with that strongly. I'm not feeling well. This is my opinion.

And there's consciousness. So the consciousness there is that I am that which cognizes and which can grasp things. It's a discriminative consciousness. So I am that.

So all these identities are part of this idea of who I am, which is this pillar. And I'm just running and running around this pillar, this self. And just like the dog, I don't see it. I don't see the problem.

Not until you become instructed. So we've all been instructed that there's absolutely no excuse for keep running around this pillar for heaven's sake. But until we do, then at least, as soon as we do realize where the problem lies, then at least we don't run around so manically. We still try and make a break for it and just find ourselves running around when we get lost in our indulgences and get caught up in hatred and all that. But at least when we wake up we think, hold on, I'm just running around this pillar again.

And he says there won't be... you're just not freed. Won't be freed from birth, aging and death. Now remember this birth, aging and death is the birth, aging and death of the self. The Buddha does not suffer from the birth, aging and death of self. He's liberated from that. His body dies and the Buddha within remains, goes who knows where. It doesn't have a lodging. It doesn't have a state. But it's understood in Mahāyāna Buddhism that there is also the *sambhoga-kāya*, the body of delight, which is the angelic body. It's still there. But it's not fooled by it.

So remember, whenever you hear in the scriptures this business of birth, aging, and death, it's always about the self, the idea of a self. And it's happening all the time. It doesn't happen when you're asleep. When you're asleep, there's no birth, aging, and death of a self. And when you wake up, you say, oh, here I am again. You say that every morning, don't you? Ding-a-ling-a-ling, oh, I'm here. Here I am again. And every time we go through the dependent origination, there's a self. So we're not always doing it. But every time we do it, there's a process of being born as me, and whatever me is doing comes to an end, and then there's a death.

And because of that, there will continue to be sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection, and despair. That's terrible, isn't it? There will be no freedom from suffering, I say.

So that brings us to the end of this section. And next week, which is my last Tuesday before Noreen comes, I'll just pull it all together, just this whole business on this section, which tends to be, shall we say, meditating on the dark side of life.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and that you will, by your constant endeavour, cut the leash around that post sooner rather than later.

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